2025 Frank Turner Best paper award

Since 2004 *International Social Work* has awarded an annual prize for the best article published in each volume. The prize was previously known as the Frank Turner Award.

Articles for the best paper published in 2025 were shortlisted by the Editors, and then judged by IASSW, ICSW and IFSW, according to the criteria of *'scholarship, relevance to a wide range of readers, originality, international focus, and contribution to international theory, policy and research'* and also which reflected the aims and scope of the journal, *'to explore and promote the development of international social work'*.

Judging has now been completed for the best article published in 2025 and the winner is **Álvaro Elices Acero, Juan Mª Prieto-Lobato, and Carmen Rodríguez-Sumaza, for their paper: The role of social workers in long-term care for older adults: A mixed-methods systematic review in Europe and North America from 2000 to 2022. *International Social Work*, 68(1), 7-21. https://doi.org/10.1177/00208728241269670**

International Social Work, IAASW, ICSW and IFSW would like to congratulate all authors shortlisted. They are:

The role of social workers in long-term care for older adults: A mixed-methods systematic review in Europe and North America from 2000 to 2022

Álvaro Elices Acero, Juan Mª Prieto-Lobato, and Carmen Rodríguez-Sumaza

https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/epub/10.1177/00208728241269670

Abstract
Demographic ageing implies increased care needs, in which social workers play a key role. However, knowledge about their practice is limited and fragmented. This mixed-methods systematic review integrates evidence from 19 studies published between 2000 and 2022 on the roles of long-term care social workers in Europe and North America. The findings reveal that service and case management, direct support, personalisation of care and community engagement are leading roles. Limitations with implications for practice are also detected, such as lack of specialisation, paperwork burden, and work overload, which should be overcome to maximise social work's contribution to care quality.

Keywords
Community-based care, home-based care, long-term care, nursing homes, older adults, social workers' role

Findings from a European, cross-national project study on service user participation: Implications for social work policy, practice and education

Jim Campbell, Sarah Donnelly, Bláithín Gallagher, Griet Roets, Walter Lorenz, Helena Blomberg, MonikaČajko Eibicht, Zuzana Havrdova, Dana Hradcová, Christian Kroll, Idalina Machado, Sara Melo, Pavla Povolná, Rudi Roose, and Laura Van Beveren

https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/epub/10.1177/00208728241305449

Abstract
This article reports on a European project that sought to explore the relationships between social work and service user participation, using a five-country (Belgium, Czech Republic, Finland, Ireland and Portugal) case study approach. It revealed areas of comparison and contrast depending upon respective histories of social work development, organisation, education and research that determined forms of service user participation. It is argued that such cross-national case study approaches can enhance our understanding of vital aspects of social work organisation, practice, education and research in the social work research, policy and practice community in areas of service user participation.

Keywords
Case study approach, comparison, Europe, service user empowerment, social work

Singapore's refreshed social compact and its implications for social work practice in Singapore

Whee Peng Chan and Bee Lian Ang

https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/epub/10.1177/00208728251338985

Abstract
The nature of social work requires the profession to be adaptive and responsive to changes in the political, economic and social environment where the practice occurs. The social work profession in Singapore has developed in tandem with the nation's relatively young history of nation building. This article uses the recently announced new social compact of Singapore as a context to present an update of the political and social-demographic situation in Singapore. The article discusses the significance of the refreshed social compact and offers views on the possible implications for social work practice in Singapore.

Keywords
Many helping hands, social compact, social policies, social work practice, social work profession

Social work practice following the COVID-19 pandemic: Reflections from Brazil, India and Scotland

Maria Lúcia Teixeira Garcia, Gary Spolander, Fabiola Leal, Francis Adaikalam, and Neil Gibson

https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/epub/10.1177/00208728241313034

Abstract
COVID-19 impacted globally, on individual health, care systems and social reproduction. Excessive death, lockdowns and social policy change had immediate and long-term national and global implications. Attention has been given to the immediate consequences, including its disproportionate impact on parts of society such as older people, "black" and "ethnic minorities", and migrants. This raises questions for social work about wider enduring lessons including social inequality and globalisation. Reflecting across three countries, we encourage debate on future professional lessons, recognising constraints the pandemic has imposed and the dilemma of relying on historical precedents, of which we now find we have none.

Keywords
COVID-19, inequality, international social work, professional lessons, public health, reflective practice

Social work graduates' professional socialisation and identity: Perceptions and experiences of social workers and supervisors

Rojan Afrouz, Kim Robinson, Angela Daddow, and Tamara Holmes

https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/epub/10.1177/00208728251319494

Abstract
Professional socialisation is a complex and interactive process through which professional roles and skills are learned and internalised. In social work, this complexity is due to a changing professional landscape, contested discourses and differing organisational contexts. This article reports on an Australian study exploring the perceptions and experiences of early career social workers and supervisors on professional socialisation. The study used qualitative methods to interview 18 participants. The findings highlighted the importance of recognition of subjective experiences, negotiating power and supervision. The findings can inform practice guides and policies for graduate programmes and practice settings.

Keywords
Critical social work, professional socialisation, social work, social work graduates, social work identity, supervisors

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Learning from the life of Dr Jane Goodall for social work practice and humanistic practice

Patrick O'Leary[1] and Tsui Ming-Sum[2]

We pay tribute to life and global contribution of Dr Jane Goodall who passed away recently. Dr Goodall was not a social worker; she is a highly respected pioneer in primate ethology and an advocate in animal and nature protection. With more than six decades of down-to-earth and round-the-globe practice, she was not only well known for her field research work with chimpanzees in the forest in Tanzania, Africa, but also the advocacy movement for protecting both the animals and their living environment as well as the educational networks all over the world in her later life.

In her research journey, Dr Goodall discovered that chimpanzees have human behaviours, such as hugs, kisses, and pats on the shoulder. This indicated that there are close and supportive bonds among family members and other individuals in the same community. In the process, she also found that the chimpanzees know using tools for getting food. In the process, she also named the individual chimpanzees with different personalities just like friends. After 10 years of research, she also suddenly witnessed the war among chimpanzees, it revealed that chimpanzees are like humans, there are both bright and dark sides in their life.

With the knowledge from her brilliant field research, Goodall was awarded a PhD in Ethology from University of Cambridge. Throughout her career, she wrote 32 books. It is interesting that 15 books were written specially for children, because she thought that passing the wisdom and knowledge to the next generation is one of the most important missions.

You might wonder what the relationship of Dr Goodall to social work is. Her rise as leading scientist opened doors for women to pursue careers that often had been only the domain of men. Dr Goodall recognized the role of discrimination in limiting our ability as humans to harness all the collective expertise and wisdom regardless of culture, gender, sexuality, or religion for common good. As her work progressed her connection to the social justice especially for children and young people became central. 'Roots and Shoots' a youth programme was established as a key part of the work of the Jane Goodall Institute. The purpose of this programme was to inspire and empower young people to take part in conservation and humanitarian projects. As Dr Goodall's career progressed, she used her expertise as primatologist to advocate not only for animal rights but also human rights especially in the context of environmental protection. These endeavours are central to the mission of social work. Central to this orientation was Dr Goodall's attention to the importance

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of building understanding to enable care and practical help, as she stated: 'Only if we understand, can we care. Only if we care, we will help. Only if we help, we shall be saved'.

Let us go back to the theme of this editorial, what can we learn from Dr Goodall? May we try to summarize as follows:

First, practice in the field is number one. As human professionals, practice is the core of our social work profession. Although we always start our professional intervention from theories and models and take actions based on various types of evidence. Summarizing and reflecting over the practice experience and trying to conceptualize them is one of the major approaches to build up our own practice wisdom and knowledge. Dr Goodall always located her work and knowledge to its application to the field, in much the same way social work research is action orientated aiming to make a different in the field of social work practice, not knowledge for its own sake but for all people and our world.

Second, Communication and care is essential for the family and community. As was manifested in Dr Goodall's research, close communication with supportive gestures (both verbal and nonverbal) will form the bonds of our relationships. It consolidates our groups and reduces the confrontations and conflicts.

Third, as professionals, ethical commitment is a further step for our helping intervention. If we discover that there are structural issues behind the social problems, we need to understand that only remedial or preventive measures are not enough, we also need advocacy, empowerment, and anti-oppressive practice. Of course, it is easier said than to be done. We do not only need to be full of courage, but also smart and tactful.

Fourth, storytelling can be a powerful narrative to induce interest and changes. With holistic views and empathetic understanding, the real stories of our clients attract the public's attention and support. Of course, privacy and consent from clients need to be upheld.

Fifth, Dr Goodall's work was not about building power through holding knowledge, but imparting her knowledge and skill to empower others, especially children and young people. She did this in holistic way looking at ways communities can work together to simultaneously preserve the environment and improve the lives of people and animals. In this way an ecological approach was taken to how to bring about meaningful and sustainable change.

Let us go further, social workers are doing humanistic work. What did Dr Goodall life teach us? Dr Goodall inspired us that where there is will, there is hope. Throughout her life, she maintained a sense of hope and optimism for what we humans are capable to achieve and preserve. With this she advocated for children as the most important people if we want to survive and develop our civilization. We human beings are smart to invent various tools, but so stupid to use them in killing at wars. Although humans will have differences, we need to address them in peaceful manner. In this way Dr Goodall warned us of the danger of apathy both in responding to the crisis of climate change but also in tolerating violence and injustice. This is best summed up in her words: 'You cannot get through a single day without having an impact on the world around you. What you do makes a difference, and you have to decide what kind of difference you want to make'.

Dr Jane Goodall's work was prefaced on the acknowledgement that ultimately the survival of humanity is inextricably linked to all people and the preservation of all living things in our environment. We close our paper with Dr Goodall's own words that offer us hope as well as a challenge for global humanity: 'We can have a world of peace. We can move toward a world where we live in harmony with nature. Where we live in harmony with each other. No matter what nation we come from. No matter what our religion. No matter what our culture. This is where we're moving towards'.

Article

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What makes social work research distinct? A comparison of three Latin American and three Anglophone countries

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Abstract
This study explored and compared conceptualizations of social work research across Anglophone and Latin American countries. Open-ended survey responses ($n = 46$) from participants in three Anglophone countries and three Latin American countries were analyzed. Three themes emerged: (1) social work research seeks solutions or actions; (2) social work research integrates an ecological approach; and (3) social work research is upheld by ethics and social justice. The themes highlighted unique contributions of social work research, with nuances between Latin American and Anglophone respondents. Implications include expanding the study to other countries and highlighting ethics and transformation in social work research.

Keywords
Latin America, North America, research, social justice, social work, United Kingdom

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Introduction

The social work profession continually explores ways to enhance its research capacity, culture, infrastructure, and identity (McRoy et al., 2012; Orme and Powell, 2008; Palinkas and Soydan, 2012). Across the globe, social work has experienced tension in setting itself apart from other disciplines and creating a professional identity (Daly et al., 2024). On the one hand, some scholars seek to increase the 'science of social work' from a positivist lens, focusing on building evidence for specific interventions that target human behavior (McNeece and Thyer, 2004). On the other hand, another group of scholars argue that social work is inherently intertwined with social justice, anti-oppressive practices, and a duty to transform society (Nicotera, 2019; Pease, 2020), hence the argument for a 'critical consideration' of evidence-based practice to integrate scientific inquiry with the social justice and critical framework of social work (Maynard, 2007).

Research and scientific inquiry have been identified as key components that set social work aside as a unique discipline and profession apart from charity and philanthropy (Thyer, 2010), while a commitment to social justice and equity differentiate social work from other social science disciplines (Finn, 2021; Thompson and Stepney, 2022). The International Association of Schools of Social Work (IASSW) approved a recent declaration stating that the purpose of social work research is to support the profession through developing knowledge, theory, social policies, and practice-based interventions. Social work research also targets multiple stakeholders, including policymakers, communities, and clients (IASSW, 2024). This statement reflects the ongoing quest to define and characterize social work research.

The question about social work's unique contributions as a discipline has been raised since the early 20th century (Tannenbaum and Reisch, 2001), particularly by Flexner (1915), who claimed social work was not a profession as it failed to derive material from learning and science to inform the activities of the profession. Since then, social work has engaged in numerous initiatives to address the quality and quantity of social work research and to define and promote social work research as distinctive (McRoy et al., 2012; Orme and Powell, 2008; Palinkas and Soydan, 2012; Shaw, 2007). This debate is particularly relevant as new technology such as artificial intelligence is being introduced and implemented across the discipline. Although ethical concerns related to the use of artificial intelligence in social work have been raised including confidentiality, systemic bias, and surveillance (Reamer, 2023), the explosion of available tools also brings new questions to the breadth and depth of possible research, particularly at a global scale.

While formal social work has emerged from a place of scientific inquiry (Moya, 2023; Rubilar, 2015), this relationship has not always been visible. The evolution of social work over time has also depended largely on historical, social, and political factors, which vary across cultures, countries, and regions. In their global study of social work research, Martínez et al. (2015) used science mapping to identify key themes and periods of social work research over time. Martínez et al. (2015) concluded that the 'first period' of social work research (1930–1989) largely focused on topical areas such as children and vulnerable families, while the 'second period' (1990–2002) was influenced by the emerging HIV pandemic and health-related research, followed by a 'third period' (2003–2012) of research that included more outcomes related to mental health. While this added a dimension of time to consider when exploring social work research, they did not differentiate findings by geographic region.

In parallel, some researchers have followed social work researchers and professionals over time to explore the contributions of social work research, including the trajectories and visions of professionals who conduct research as part of their practice (Rubilar, 2009; Teater, 2017). This is particularly relevant in the United States, United Kingdom, and Chile, as these three countries have the longest history of formalized schools of social work (Ehrenreich, 1985). While formal social

work emerged in the United States and the United Kingdom at the beginning of the 20th century, the first formalized school of social work outside of these two countries was established in 1925 in Chile. In the 100 years since its inception, formal social work in Chile has guided the formalization of social work as a discipline in several other Latin American countries (Moya, 2023). To date, few studies have compared formal social work and how research has evolved over time in these different cultural contexts and settings.

In a seminal study for Chile, Rubilar (2009) used a qualitative longitudinal research design to follow a group of Chilean social workers; this project began in 2008 and has had over 100 participants across the country explore their research trajectories and transitions. In the United States, Teater (2017) interviewed 20 social work academics to explore their research agendas, approaches, and connections to social work practice. Teater found the social work academics to minimally connect their research to social work practice where research questions were rarely derived from social work practice and there was a lack in disseminating research to the social work practice community. These two studies provide insight into trajectories and changes over time in social work research priorities and foci. However, to date, few studies have directly compared conceptualizations of social work research among different regions or groups that may approach social work from diverse lenses. Notably, Roche and Flynn (2018) found that less than 10 percent of articles written about social work were in languages other than English. Indeed, much of the literature on social work research focuses on Western perspectives (Muñoz-Arce et al., 2021), highlighting a need to more actively engage and compare the role of social work in the Global North and Global South.

A gap in this quest to highlight the relevance and distinctiveness of social work research is the inclusion of how social work researchers from across the globe conceptualize social work research. Gathering and consolidating the views and perspectives of social work researchers can strengthen the discipline of social work in defining itself and its contribution to the profession through knowledge creation. Thus, this study addresses a gap by comparing Anglophone (Global North) and Latin American (Global South) social workers' conceptualizations of social work practice and research. Furthermore, this study situates itself at the ongoing debate of ethics and social justice in social work research and practice, and how increased technology and artificial intelligence may shape the field's trajectory. It is guided by the premise that social work researchers share common elements and key differences in their approach to research, while their research trajectories shape how they conceive and understand their work. Furthermore, this study offers an opportunity to critically rethink connections between research and practice and advance future research agendas from lines of research that emerged among the participants in the study, adding to the current debate about knowledge generation through social work research.

Current study

This study explores conceptualizations of social work research among social work researchers across the globe by asking the following research questions: 1) *What differentiates social work research from other research?* and 2) *How do Latin American and Anglophone respondents characterize social work research?* The focus of comparing Latin American and Anglophone countries was selected given the long history of formal social work in both areas. As formal social work emerged, it integrated a scientific approach, distinguishing it from other charity work by its use of science and evidence. Therefore, it is important to understand how research and scientific inquiry in social work have evolved over time in both contexts – as US- and UK-based schools have guided other Western-based social work, while Chile has led the way in Latin America (Moya, 2023).

The present study also expands on an informal inquiry conducted by Teater in 2022 that involved analyzing the responses of 18 social work researchers from 14 different countries on the following two questions: (1) What is social work research? and (2) What makes social work research distinctive from other research produced in other disciplines? From the informal inquiry, Teater (2022) identified the following three themes on what makes social work research distinctive: (1) Touches reality, participatory approaches, and transformative and developmental in nature; (2) Applied, community-driven approaches that improve social well-being in general; and (3) System changes and advocacy, to develop a fairer, more democratic, sustainable world. The themes pointed to social work research as distinctive by being multifaceted, by focusing on real-world problems, often involving the inclusion of participants/community in the research and/or research process, and seeking to be transformative by advocating and moving toward social justice. This inquiry led to further questions around how social work research is defined and conceptualized as distinctive from other disciplines. Thus, this study built on the informal inquiry to formally survey social work researchers across the globe to compare and contrast visions of social work, connect diverse agendas, identify research activities, and propose future research agendas. The aim is to administer this survey annually; results from the first initial survey are presented in this article.

The main premise in this exploratory study is that social work research across the globe shares common elements that characterize it despite different methodological foci and approaches, while there may be unique components among respondents in the Global South and Global North. These characteristics are shaped by debates about the legitimacy of social work as its own discipline and its close ties to social justice and transformation.

Method

Data collection and recruitment

Data for this study came from an online survey administered to social work researchers across multiple countries. The goal of the project was to explore definitions of social work research across the globe and perceptions of how social work research is distinctive from research produced in other disciplines. In addition to seven socio-demographic questions, respondents were administered a series of open-ended questions related to differentiating social work research (e.g. '*What makes social work distinctive from research produced in other disciplines*?'), defining social work research (e.g. '*In your own words, how would you define social work research*?'), and identifying unique contributions of social work research (e.g. '*How and in what ways does social work research contribute to knowledge*?'). The first two open-ended questions were derived from the informal inquiry by Teater (2022).

A team of social work academics from Chile and the United States developed a questionnaire to address the main research questions that could reach diverse respondents across several countries. The questions were initially drafted in Spanish and then translated to English, with active input from researchers in both the United States and Chile. After the draft was complete, the questions were translated into Portuguese. The Qualtrics questionnaire was distributed through listservs (e.g. European Social Work Research Association [ESWRA]; *Red de Investigadoras e Investigadores en Trabajo Social Chile*), contacts of the research team, and social media (e.g. X; Facebook). An anonymous link was provided in the flyers distributed on the research-focused listservs and any social worker who consented was eligible to complete the survey. The information and flyer could also be forwarded/shared more broadly by individuals who received it on one of the initial listservs. Social workers could opt to complete the survey, resulting in a convenience sample of social workers connected to various international social work networks.

The main sample frame was social work researchers given the focus of this study on exploring and comparing definitions of social work research, and could include both academic and practitioner researchers. The questionnaire began with the following statement: 'you are being asked to participate in this research study because you engage in social work research'. In addition, after the respondents provided consent, they were asked, 'Do you participate in social work research?'

Data were collected between October 2023 and January 2024 and data collection finished based on the study time frame and once there were over 60 open-ended responses. Respondents were able to read the informed consent and click on an 'I consent' button on the online survey prior to beginning the survey. In the case that they did not consent, the survey automatically routed to the 'end' page. All data collection procedures and study design were vetted and approved by the third author's Institutional Review Board. Special considerations were given to ensure respondent confidentiality; no individually identifiable information was asked on the survey (e.g. names, email addresses). For respondents who wanted to opt-in to future studies, they had an option to click on a link at the end of the survey that redirected them to a separate form to enter their contact information so that this information would not be linked to any individual survey responses.

Study sample and research setting

A total of $n = 121$ started the survey, of whom $n = 118$ individuals consented to participate and $n = 88$ individuals completed the online survey. Among individuals who completed the survey, $n = 46$ resided in an Anglophone or Latin American country and thus were included in the analytic sample. The only individuals who responded in Portuguese ($n = 2$) resided in Portugal; therefore, considering likely cultural differences, we only included responses from Latin American or Anglophone countries in this analysis. Table 1 displays the socio-demographics of survey respondents for the subsample of Anglophone and Latin American respondents used to address the research questions of this study. Most Latin American respondents resided in Chile ($n = 14$; 30.9%), followed by Argentina ($n = 2$; 4.2%) and Colombia ($n = 1$; 2.1%), whereas most Anglophone respondents resided in the United States ($n = 23$; 50.0%), followed by the United Kingdom ($n = 5$; 10.8%) and Canada ($n = 1$; 2.1%). The majority ($n = 44$; 95.7%) of respondents in our analytic sample reported that they participated in social work research. Most identified as female, which is consistent with the gender distribution of the discipline and reflective of the feminization of care professions (Sands and Nuccio, 1992).

Data analysis

All survey data were exported from Qualtrics to a csv file and analyzed in Excel. Closed-ended questions related to demographics were analyzed using frequencies and percentages with Pivot Tables. The research questions of interest were addressed from open-ended questions where the authors sorted and coded the open-ended items in Excel using a thematic analysis approach (Guest et al., 2012). To answer the research questions of this study, the focus was on analysis of the open-ended responses, particularly the question, 'What makes social work distinctive from research produced in other disciplines?' To reduce the risk of bias and increase the trustworthiness of the data, two PhD-level social work researchers independently coded the data using a two-stage approach. The open-ended responses were coded in the original language of the survey (English or, Spanish) and were later translated by the corresponding author (who is fluent in English and Spanish). In the development of the survey, a native Portuguese speaker also reviewed the text.

In the first stage of the data analysis, and consistent with an applied thematic analytic approach (Guest et al., 2012), each researcher identified the main concept or idea underlying each response.

Table 1. Characteristics of Anglophone and Latin American respondents in the toward a global definition of social work survey, 2024 ($n = 46\%$).

Participate in social work research		
	Yes	44 (95.7)
	No	2 (4.3)
Gender		
	Male (cis or transgender)	12 (26.1)
	Female (cis or transgender)	28 (60.9)
	Nonbinary/nonconforming	2 (4.3)
	Self-identify	4 (8.7)
Country of residence		
	United States	23 (50.0)
	Chile	14 (30.9)
	United Kingdom	5 (10.8)
	Argentina	2 (4.3)
	Canada	1 (2.1)
	Colombia	1 (2.1)
Age		
	25–34	4 (8.7)
	35–44	14 (30.4)
	45–54	14 (30.4)
	55–64	7 (15.2)
	65 +	7 (15.2)
Professional role		
	Assistant professor	8 (17.4)
	Associate professor	14 (30.4)
	Full professor	7 (15.2)
	Adjunct/auxiliary professor	3 (6.5)
	Lecturer	1 (2.1)
	Administrative position	6 (13.0)
	Retired faculty	2 (4.3)
	Postdoctoral fellow/doctoral student	4 (8.7)
	Skipped	1 (2.1)

In this stage, each open-ended response (86 total) was analyzed, and the key idea or concept was extracted. Thirteen initial codes were developed, including 'scientific method', 'generating knowledge', 'action-oriented', 'multidisciplinary', and 'applied', among others. In the second stage, the researchers used a constant comparison method to group codes from the first stage by larger themes. During this process, the two researchers met monthly to discuss emerging themes and resolve any discrepancies. As in other recent thematic analyses (Roberts et al., 2019), discrepancies were resolved by discussing the decisions the two researchers had made and coming to a consensus; as the larger themes emerged in the second phase of coding, two additional researchers involved in the design of the study provided feedback and identified similarities and potential ways to further collapse and combine themes. The results from this iterative process yielded three main themes.

Trustworthiness was addressed in the following ways: (1) To enhance credibility, the authors engaged in reflection and discussion about emerging themes, used actual words from the data, and

connected literature to the concepts that began to emerge from the data (Chiovitti and Piran, 2003); (2) To enhance transferability, the researchers reported the results using thick descriptive data, particularly through the use of direct quotes; and (3) To enhance dependability, the researchers maintained an audit trail, which involved detailed field notes and a thorough description of the data collection and the stages of data analysis (Lincoln and Guba, 1986; Shenton, 2004).

Results

Respondents overwhelmingly identified components of social work research that distinguished it from research in other disciplines. Across the sample, only three individuals responded that they were 'not sure' or that there 'was nothing' that differentiated social work research from other disciplines' research. All three individuals who reported no difference completed the survey in Spanish and worked for universities in Chile. All remaining respondents identified differences and those differences were analyzed and grouped into the following three themes: (1) Social work research seeks solutions or actions; (2) Social work research integrates an ecological approach; and (3) Social work research is upheld by ethics and social justice. At the core, all three themes reflected values that recognized the role and contributions of the research subjects as active participants in the process and the importance of context in understanding human behavior. This aligns with findings from prior studies that have concluded social work research is guided by professional ethics that shapes the research questions and interactions with research participants (Rubilar, 2009; Shaw, 2007). Together, the themes also evidence the legitimacy social workers place on research unique to the discipline and identify core components that set it apart from other research.

Social work research seeks solutions or actions

The first theme that emerged, *social work research seeks solutions or actions*, encompassed the idea that there were practical applications that informed the research and a bridge between research and practice (Gray et al., 2015; Heinsch et al., 2016). Several respondents, both from Anglophone and Latin American countries, reported that social work research was 'applied' and had a focus on 'betterment' or 'solutions' to real-world problems. In this sense, there were similarities among Anglophone and Latin American respondents with regard to the applied, solution-focused nature of social work research. As one respondent signaled, '*in my experience, social work research has a specific location in relationship to social problems and issues, as well as a stronger sense of relationship with and responsibility to our research respondents*' (respondent 19, completed survey in English). Another respondent reported social work research being '*change-oriented*' (respondent 33, completed survey in English).

For other respondents, social work research generated knowledge or evidence that had real-world, practical implications. For example, respondent 21 (completed survey in English) indicated that social work research contributed '*by defining problems, identifying causes, and offering solutions that are not based on the hegemonic paradigm*'. Another Latin American respondent noted, social work research '*produces evidence to make decisions about social programs and policies*' (respondent 25, completed survey in Spanish).

Similarly, an Anglophone respondent indicated:

> Social work research provides evidence to both practice and policy. Social work has become increasingly evidence based, and research is needed to contribute towards this [. . .] not just empirical research, but also qualitative research that provides a platform for those who use services to contribute, (respondent 66, completed survey in English)

Notably, several Anglophone respondents tended to report 'building evidence' to evaluate existing programs and policies. In contrast, multiple respondents from Latin America tended to mention producing evidence 'to make decisions' about developing or implementing programs and policies. In both cases, data and knowledge generation through social work research was considered as a means to a more applied solution or tangible action that could improve practice or policy. Respondents from both Anglophone and Latin American countries noted that social work research '*provides scientific evidence about certain social problems and their complexity and proposes improvements or collective resolutions*' (respondent 64, completed survey in Spanish.). Another participant noted that social work research '*collects data and organizes it through the lens of relevant topics for social work (e.g. justice, equality, peace*') (respondent 48, completed survey in English). Thus, beyond generating data or knowledge for the sake of research, this theme overlapped with other themes related to the holistic and applied approach and focus on ethics/social justice as those pillars guided knowledge generation.

In these cases, social work research went beyond other social science research in identifying or learning about issues; rather, it sought *solutions or actions* either through interventions or policies that could best address social issues at hand. In parallel, several respondents reported that social work research was 'practice-based' and differentiated itself from other social science research based on its practical applications and grounding. One respondent indicated that social work research '*has a practical layer that other disciplines do not*' (respondent 1, completed survey in Spanish).

Social work research integrates an ecological approach

The second theme that emerged was that social work *integrates an ecological approach.* The ecological or 'person-in-environment' approach emerged more among Anglophone respondents, while some Latin American respondents mentioned multiple 'layers' or 'factors' to consider such as individual and structural factors. Both Anglophone and Latin American respondents referred to 'socio-political' contexts and factors that social work research considers.

In contrast to some other social science research, respondents reported that social work research incorporated a 'person-in-environment' framework that focused on individuals within their socio-political contexts to understand social issues at hand. Some respondents reported this as a '*holistic*' or '*systems approach*' that was '*unique*' (respondent 24, completed survey in English). One respondent stated that social work research could '*address the complicated and complex social, cultural, and political factors that have impacted individual and social well-being*' (respondent 79, completed survey in English).

As one respondent stated, social work research '*is typically collaborative in nature, with elements of ecological perspective (micro, mezzo, and macro lenses) as a framework*' (respondent 42, completed survey in English). Thus, by examining multiple lenses, respondents reported gaining a more holistic understanding of human behavior and social issues. This included recognition that '*individual behavior and outcomes are dependent on several intersecting factors and dimensions*' (respondent 57, completed survey in English). This connects with the complexity of the social issues investigated through social work research that require diverse and multidimensional perspectives. A Latin American respondent indicated: '*It is an intellectual and political exercise that is key to strengthening and constantly updating the discipline and is shaped by historical contexts*, (respondent 72, completed survey in Spanish). This aligned with other Latin American responses that focused on the inclusion of 'dimensions of time and space' or 'geography' in exploring various research questions.

Social work research is upheld by ethics and social justice

The third and final theme that emerged was that social work research *is upheld be ethics and social justice.* In this theme, respondents focused on values such as human rights, social justice, and dignity that differentiated social work research from other social science research. As one Latin American respondent reported, social work research had '*a clear focus on transformation*' (respondent 22, completed survey in Spanish). Similarly, an Anglophone respondent stated that social work research '*addresses social injustice*' (respondent 18, completed survey in English). Several Anglophone and Latin American respondents mentioned the commitment of social work research to 'human rights' and 'social work values' (respondent 25, completed survey in Spanish, and respondent 32, completed survey in English), identifying these as unique components.

Within this theme, one key value of social work research identified was the 'value' and 'worth' placed on each individual. Anglophone respondents often recognized individuals with lived experience as experts in their own narratives. As one participant noted, '*in the best instances. [social work research] fills in static concepts with lived experience and other examples*' (respondent 31, completed survey in English). In contrast, Latin American respondents more frequently reported '*ethical considerations*' and '*values*' when engaging research participants as components that set social work research apart (respondent 25, completed survey in Spanish, and respondent 43, completed survey in English).

In addition to recognizing the value of individuals with lived experience, respondents also identified values of equity and justice and repairing harm that differentiated social work research. For example, one researcher reported:

> Research that is grounded in equity and justice and is conscious of the damage that research has caused in the past and intentionally works to avoid perpetuating any form of data violence, coercion, and misinformation. Ideally, social work research is in partnership with, never research on, and is participatory when possible. (respondent 34, completed survey in English)

This theme has highlighted the importance researchers place on adhering and upholding the ethics and values of work both within the development and design of the research and in the purpose of the research findings.

Discussion

This study explored how social work researchers across the globe defined social work research, with a focus on comparing Anglophone and Latin American researchers. Respondents identified key pillars of social work research that differentiated it from other social science research, including its applied approach, ecological perspective, and adherence to social work values and ethics, such as active participation and transformation of society. While each of these three themes alone may not distinguish social work research from research of other disciplines, together they provide a formula of the distinctiveness of social work research. Together, these themes reflect the ethical and values-driven nature of social work research with the aim to improve society or social problems and transform the profession of social work and the lives of people. Further, they reflect the implicit or explicit values related to social justice, transforming society, and human rights, all of which guide and differentiate social work research from other social science research. All themes related to core values in the Social Work Code of Ethics, such as social justice, dignity and worth of people, human rights, and the importance of human relationships (International Federation of Social Workers [IFSW], 2018; National Association of Social Workers, 2021).

Notably, most of the themes emerged from both Anglophone and Latin America, which may reflect certain similarities in how social work research is understood, taught, and conducted in diverse contexts. However, it is important to note that in some of the themes, such as *social work seeks actions or solutions*, there were some differences in how respondents in Latin American and Anglophone contexts conceptualized evidence generation. Anglophone-based respondents tended to focus on building the evidence for existing programs and policies, whereas respondents from Latin America tended to focus on generating evidence to inform decision-making about program and policy development and implementation. This aligns with a focus in Anglophone-based research on building the 'evidence-base' for practices and that have been evaluated using rigorous experimental or quasi-experimental designs and then having the collective body of research rated by clearinghouses (Zheng et al., 2022). Though some research from Latin America has found a lack of social work perspectives in policy debates, as well as critical perspectives about how knowledge is produced, findings from this study highlight potential to include social work research in these arenas (Muñoz Arce et al., 2021; Muñoz Arce and Rubilar, 2021).

Questions associated with ethical and political debates are also found in Latin perspectives, which raise questions about justice and human rights. These 'sensitive topics' (Cornejo et al., 2019) cover conflicts with the state, excessive use of force, and unequal application of rights – issues often addressed by social work research. While Anglophone respondents tended to focus on social work ethics such as the 'unique value' and 'worth' of individual clients, Latin American respondents tended to have a more reflexive approach of incorporating ethics and human rights into their interactions as professionals with research participants. While some Anglophone respondents did recognize the importance of larger transformation and social justice, many focused on the inherent value and dignity of each individual, taking a more individualistic approach to understanding complex phenomena. This may align with a more humanistic and individualistic focus of micro and clinical social work in Anglophone countries that has been critiqued as failing to enter into larger critical discussions about the role of power, privilege, and structural barriers (Whitaker et al., 2021).

Themes from our study also highlight ideals of social work research, such as centering individuals with lived experiences and ensuring that research is focused on solutions to real-world issues. It is worth noting that other researchers have concluded a need to increase the practical applications of social work research (Teater, 2017) and to ensure that it does take an anti-oppressive approach (Pease, 2010). Despite the fact that several respondents mentioned social transformations (aligning the conceptualization of social work research with international definitions), the responses largely focused on individuals and individual change. Although several respondents mentioned an ecological approach to social work research, few focused on structures, structural mechanisms, or systems that produce inequality and oppression. This speaks of a particular conception of 'the social', which distances itself from the most critical approaches in the discipline (Dunk-West and Saxton, 2024; Healy, 2001).

Notably, Anglophone and Latin American respondents did not reference the theoretical basis of social work research. It seems that the research 'springs' from what is required by practice – either to 'test' a model of practice (Anglo Social Work) or to raise knowledge from practice that can be seen by policymakers or other decision makers (Latin American Social Work). There were no references in the responses to the place of theory in the production of knowledge. The silence regarding the relationship between theoretical bases and research may reinforce the place of sub-alternity that is sometimes attributed to social work compared to other social sciences. This may inhibit Social Workers from reaching positions of power that make decisions related to social justice (Briskman et al., 2020; Howe, 2017).

While participation appears as a component in one theme, this is an area that may require more in-depth exploration. Although some respondents mentioned a co-production of knowledge, transdisciplinary perspectives of knowledge creation, or active knowledge development with research participants, the role of knowledge generation and contribution remains understudied. Debates about knowledge construction and the role of the researcher and participants are relevant debates in the disciplinary agenda of social work (McGlade et al., 2020) and have high visibility in the international definition of social work. Furthermore, these debates are important as artificial intelligence begins to permeate the field and generates new discussions about how knowledge is created and shared (Reamer, 2023). Future research could explore the interactions and transactions among researchers and participants, particularly in light of international definitions of social work research that focus on its 'interdisciplinary and transdisciplinary' nature and the 'co-construction' of theory through 'interactive process[es]' (IASSW, 2024).

There is also nothing about 'indigenous' or non-hegemonic knowledge in the respondents' accounts. Part of the legacy of colonialism is that Western theories and knowledge have been exclusively valorized and in contrast local knowledge has been devalued, discounted, and hegemonized by Western theories and knowledge. This is interesting, even in the responses of participants from Chile, Argentina, and Colombia, there was a lack of mention about indigenous, popular, or non-hegemonic knowledge, which contrasts with visions that attribute a critical character and the decolonial potential of Latin American social work (Alicea-Rodríguez, 2019; Garrett, 2021).

Limitations

This exploratory study has several strengths, such as including responses from social work researchers across the globe. However, there are also notable limitations. First, the convenience sample and relatively small number of responses by geographic region are not necessarily representative of all social work researchers. While we noted some general trends in our results and compared themes in the English and Spanish responses, these are not necessarily transferable beyond the sample. Furthermore, although respondents from six countries were included, 50 percent of the sample resided in the United States and the majority of Spanish-speaking respondents resided in Chile. Therefore, results are not necessarily transferrable or reflective of all Latin American or Anglophone countries. Second, there were several countries that only had one or two responses. Future research could strategically recruit and sample to compare and contrast experiences within each country or geographic region. Third, the few respondents who reported no differences between social work research and other social science research could be considered conflicting/contradictory cases. Future research could explore these perspectives in more depth and specifically sample other Latin American countries to compare and contrast themes.

Implications for social work practice and research

The findings of this study have moved the profession forward in articulating the distinctiveness of social work research. The three themes from this study can be used to promote social work research with clarity and purpose in social work education, practice, and academic communities. Specifically, the message on how social work research is distinctive can be simply stated with the following statement: 'Upheld by ethics and social justice, social work research integrates an ecological approach to seek solutions and actions to real-world problems'. This message can be integrated into social work education research courses to provide a foundational context for students to learn and engage in social work research. Doctoral programs could include the statement in their

program's mission and vision statements to specify the purpose and aim of social work research, thus assisting future social work researchers to articulate their future research agendas.

By incorporating this statement in social work education, future social workers can have a clear understanding of research for their practice. Practitioners can use the statement to guide their practice-informed research and research-informed practice by ensuring they are upholding the values and ethics of the profession in their research endeavors, and conducting research that aims to seek solutions and actions that will move toward social justice. Practitioners can better articulate why they are conducting research with individuals and communities and how their research findings can be used to advance practice and promote better lives for individuals, families, groups, communities, organizations, and society.

Having a specific statement on the distinctiveness of social work research can help to legitimize and promote the uniqueness of social work research within academic spaces across the globe. It can also help establish global research agendas and trajectories that permeate borders. The statement can help to support funding for social work research as it demonstrates the ways in which social work research has impact and is unique. Clarity on social work research can also help in tenure, promotion, and academic advancement opportunities and decisions where professionals from other disciplines may have limited knowledge of social work research. Finally, as this study was exploratory, future research should build upon these initial findings and probe for specific components such as the relationship between researcher and participant, co-construction of knowledge, and social transformations.

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Approval provided by the College of Staten Island, City University of New York. Research was approved as exempt on 10/31/2023 (protocol # 2023-0687-CSI). Recruitment of participants began in November 2023.

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Article

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Understanding social work supervision in the context of social development practice: A comprehensive analysis

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Abstract
Supervision is crucial in social work for enhancing service delivery standards. In South Africa, deficiencies in supervision practices and ineffective implementation of the social development approach have negatively impacted service quality. This study investigated the relationship between supervision and the adoption of the social development approach within the Department of Social Development in Mpumalanga's Gert Sibande District. Using a qualitative case study design and semi-structured interviews, the findings revealed that supervision in the district does not effectively support the social development approach, raising concerns about service delivery quality.

Keywords
Service delivery, social development approach, social work supervisee, social work supervision, social work supervisor

Introduction

Various studies and scholars have emphasised the importance of the practice of social work supervision in rendering quality social work services (Call, 2020; Engelbrecht, 2019; Ncube, 2019, 2019; Ross and Ncube, 2018). In this light, social work supervision is viewed as the fulcrum of the social work profession (Ross and Ncube, 2018). Furthermore, Engelbrecht (2015a) posits that social workers and social work supervisors are progressively viewed as the most significant resource in tackling the needs and challenges of society due to their appropriate training and skills

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to deliver effective services. The depth of their diverse knowledge and skills makes them a resource for social welfare and various other sectors locally and internationally (Department of Social Development [DSD] and South African Council of Social Service Professionals [SACSSP], 2012). However, Botha (2002) argues that if an organisation renders supervision of inferior quality to its social work practitioners, it places itself at a risk of poor service delivery to its service users.

In 1997, the government of the Republic of South Africa (RSA) (1997) adopted the White Paper for Social Welfare to transform the social welfare sector towards a developmental slant and maximise the potential of citizens, particularly the previously marginalised (Midgley, 2014; Patel, 2015). A social development approach emphasises the importance of spending on citizens, eliminating obstacles and allowing citizens to journey towards the fulfilment of their dreams with dignity (Patel, 2015). Social work practitioners are obligated by the dictates of their profession to protect human dignity and human rights. Therefore, the social development approach facilitates this endeavour as it promotes human rights and human dignity (Ncube, 2021; Patel, 2015). Dlangamandla (2010) asserts that social workers have skills that effectively contribute to the required implementation of the social development practice approach.

The SACSSP (2007) requires that social workers be supervised in their field of practice as part of their continuous learning process that occurs within a specific reciprocal relationship between a supervisor and a social worker during which knowledge is deepened, and skills are developed. In the Framework for Supervision for Social Work Professionals in South Africa, a set of reasons for the importance of supervision of social workers is provided, one of which is that supervision contributes to the improved quality of services offered to service users (DSD and SACSSP, 2012). Then, supervision can be used to control and increase accountability in social welfare services rendered within the communities while and equipping inexperienced social workers with skills and knowledge to deliver effective services (Botha, 2002). Patel (2015) specifies that the supervision of social work professionals contributes to the appropriate application of the chosen approach to service delivery. Ncube (2019) advances an argument that social work supervision must facilitate an understanding and application of the agency's chosen service delivery approach to the extent of creating a symbiotic relationship between the two. In a myriad of service delivery approaches, the DSD opted for a social development perspective. That lends the South African type of social work to developmental social work. For this reason, this study sought to explore the extent to which the practice of social work supervision in Mpumalanga facilitates an understanding and adoption of the social development practice approach to service delivery.

Therefore, the aim of the study is to explore the extent to which social work supervision at the DSD in Mpumalanga's Gert Sibande District facilitates the adoption of the social development practice approach. The research question guiding the study was: How does social work supervision in this district influence the adoption of the social development practice approach? To address this question, the study aimed to achieve three objectives: first, to explore the extent to which social workers and supervisors prioritise supervision; second, to elicit their views on the practical understanding of the social development approach; and third, to investigate how supervision within the department fosters an understanding of this approach in practice.

Literature review

While there is a significant amount of literature on social work supervision, there is a paucity on social development-informed social work supervision with a particular focus on how the approach informs the practice of supervision and vice versa. Two scholars who have attempted to focus on this area are Engelbrecht (2019) and Ncube (2019). Nonetheless, their studies left knowledge, methodological and practice gaps for continued empirical investigations in this area. Although the

present study refers to a specific geographic location, its outcomes contribute to the broader body of social work supervision literature. The SACSSP (2007) states that social work is a profession that envisions improving the ability and social functioning of persons, and societies. Zastrow (2014) states the practice of social work emphasises the proficient use of social work values, principles and techniques. Furthermore, theoretical knowledge, skills and techniques in social work are used to ensure the professionalism of social work practice. The global definition of social work encompasses these stating that

> Social work is a practice-based profession and an academic discipline that promotes social change and development, social cohesion, and the empowerment and liberation of people. Principles of social justice, human rights, collective responsibility and respect for diversities are central to social work. Underpinned by theories of social work, social sciences, humanities and indigenous knowledges, social work engages people and structures to address life challenges and enhance wellbeing. (International Federation of Social Workers [IFSW], 2014)

With this understanding of the profession, social work supervision then becomes the mainstay that underpins the profession in the rendering of quality services. It also provides a platform for accountability (Call, 2020). Thus, supervision is an effective tool in the development of social workers with knowledge and skills to be used when the social workers serve people (Engelbrecht and Ncube, 2021; Ross and Ncube, 2018). Supervision is a distinct evidence-based practice performed by a designated supervisor to promote efficient and professional social service delivery (DSD and SACSSP, 2012).

Mokoka (2016) and Smith (2014) argue that social work supervision provides practitioners with an opportunity to collaboratively deal with work-related tension and to be aware of their emotions concerning work and stressors that may weaken service delivery if unattended. It further increases the supervisor–supervisee relationship and is largely determined by external factors, such as the agency environment, supervisee needs and presenting problems of the social service users (Hafford-Letchfield et al., 2014). The development of social work practice and supervision relies on both the social worker and the supervisor providing competent professional services (National Association of Social Workers [NASW], 2013). Therefore, both the supervisor and the social worker are integral components in the development of the type of supervision provided as well as the supervisory relationship between the two of them.

Furthermore, the implementation of the supervision practice is affected by the organisation's internal dynamics including its aims and objectives, the availability or absence of policies on supervision and the approach to service delivery (Dirgeliene, 2016; Openshaw, 2012). Appropriate implementation of social work supervision leads to improved work performance, quality of work, professional socialisation, and social workers' confidence (Bradley et al., 2010). Engelbrecht, (2012) state that supervision practice is a force for change within the social work profession. An appreciation of this agency-based supervision practice, helps to understand the opportunities and limitations that exist for supervision (Kadushin and Harkness, 2014). Hence, Ncube (2019) highlights that how supervision is practised is of critical importance given its pivotal nature to service delivery in the profession of social work.

The evolution and significance of social work supervision

The profession of social work emerged in the late 19th century as a response to the social ills and needs identified among the working class. It achieved formal recognition and professional status in the first half of the 20th century (Danış and Kirbaç, 2013).

To give an international context of the evolution of social work supervision in South Africa, Busse (2021; Stuart, 2019) states that the history of social work supervision is closely intertwined with that of social work itself, particularly in Europe and North America, where both developed concurrently. Despite its significance, the exact origins of the traditional model of social work supervision remain uncertain (Munson, 2002). Furthermore, ongoing debates and divergent views regarding the origins of social work supervision reflect its complex and evolving nature (Kadushin and Harkness, 2014). Kadushin and Harkness (2002) argue that before 1920, there was limited information about the practice of social work supervision, with supervisors primarily dictating to their supervisees on what needed to be done in practice. Alongside the development of social work, the practice of supervision also evolved, initially seen as an individual support service focused on personal introspection and 'matters of the soul'. However, this approach faced criticism for its limited scope, leading to calls for supervision to be viewed as an instrument of emancipation for the practitioner (Busse, 2021).

Initially, in South Africa, the development of social work and the practice of supervision followed a similar trajectory to that of its Western counterparts, albeit under different conditions. To a larger extent, the historical outline of social work and supervision in South Africa was shaped by the country's political history, social welfare practice and the success of social work in rendering services to social service users (Engelbrecht, 2010; Patel, 2005; Smith, 2014). Social work training for Caucasians and other racial groups was introduced in the 1940s and 1950s (Mazibuko and Gray, 2004; Noyoo et al., 2021), and the practice of social work supervision became systematic and scientific during the first half of the 20th century. The formalisation of the social work profession in South Africa was further enhanced by the development of the Social Work Act in 1978, which led to the establishment of the Council of Social Workers, a statutory body (Republic of South Africa, 1978). This body mandated that all social work professionals must register and renew their registration annually to practise (DSD and SACSSP, 2012). Engelbrecht (2015a) highlights the salience of supervision as a mandated practice in South Africa.

The South African government embraced a social welfare paradigm that facilitated a shift from a preoccupation with residual services to a developmental approach to service delivery. Various theoretical perspectives aligning with the developmental paradigm, such as the strengths perspective and the ecological perspective, were identified (Engelbrecht, 2010). However, studies focusing in some areas of South Africa indicate that the way in which supervision is rendered in South Africa does not correspond with these theoretical standards, thereby failing to facilitate a developmental trajectory as espoused in the social development practice approach (Engelbrecht, 2010; Ncube, 2019; Tsima and Ncube, 2023). Engelbrecht (2010) further asserts that the roles of supervision in South Africa reveal knowledge gaps among supervisees, irrespective of their agencies. The primary drive in developing and refining social work supervisory practices in South Africa is to meet the basic needs of the citizens. According to Kadushin and Harkness (2002), supervision lies in the augmented integration of theoretical doctrines into supervisory practices, which should align with a chosen service delivery approach (Ncube, 2019). In the evolution of supervision, the suggested adaptation seems to have been overlooked, resulting in a scenario where traditional supervision – aligned with residual and institutional approaches – persisted despite the welfare orientation shifting towards a developmental focus.

The development of various theory-informed supervision approaches, such as the strengths-based model (Engelbrecht, 2021), process model of social development supervision in social work (Ncube, 2019), integrated developmental model (IDM) (Stoltenberg and McNeill, 2010) and others reflects the ongoing efforts to improve supervision practices in South Africa. These models aim to assist social workers in becoming accountable and maintaining ethical standards in their field of practice (DSD and SACSSP, 2012). The models also support professional development

by providing social workers and supervisors' opportunities for professional learning, thereby enhancing their knowledge and skills to effectively navigate difficult and diverse practice environments (Ncube, 2019).

Amid challenges in social welfare service delivery, the DSD developed a Recruitment and Retention Strategy for Social Service Practitioners to address the deterioration in productivity, the quality of rendered services and disorganised supervision structures (DSD, 2017). The strategy highlighted the importance of supervision for social work professionals, leading to the development of a supervision framework reflecting its critical role in the profession (DSD and SACSSP, 2012). Throughout the history of social work supervision, the lack of adequate supervision has been noted to affect the professional growth of social work professionals and impugn the integrity of the profession (Engelbrecht, 2013).

The competence of supervisors is essential to providing quality supervision, as emphasised by Call (2020). The supervision framework stipulates that supervisors may only supervise in areas of their competence (DSD and SACSSP, 2012). The IFSW (2014) further emphasises the legal responsibility of social work supervisors to ensure quality supervision, protecting service users from unscrupulous practices. To support and strengthen supervision practices, the NASW (2013) developed practice standards for social work supervision. These standards promote critical reflection on practice by social work supervisees and ensure that supervision involves every part of service delivery, including the organisation (agency), social work supervisor, social worker (supervisee) and the service user (Kadushin and Harkness, 2002).

In consideration of the preceding discussion and notwithstanding other definitions within the broader body of social work literature, supervision in social work, for the purposes of this article, is conceptualised as a middle-management function. It employs supervisory approaches that align with and support the practice approach of the agency or supervisee. This function facilitates the supervisee's ability to fulfil their responsibilities effectively, guided by relevant theories, skills, techniques, legislation and agency policies.

Theoretical lens

The social development theory (Boshoff, 2013; Patel, 2015) was used as the theoretical framework for this study, linking social and economic development based on principles such as self-help, self-determination and active participation in service rendering. Furthermore, informed by this theory, social development is recognised as a macroeconomic policy framework (Midgley, 1995), aimed at fostering human capital development, reducing inequality and promoting long-term economic growth (United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs [UNDESA], 2020). It aims to bring visible social and economic development to people's lives, improving their proficiencies, opportunities and decision-making (Sen, 2000). Building on its theoretical foundation, Patel (2015) introduces a social development practice approach, characterised by 'multimodal social development interventions'. She contends that social development has evolved beyond being merely a macroeconomic policy framework. Instead, it now encompasses a practice-oriented approach that integrates interventions across micro, mezzo and macro levels of practice.

As both a practice approach and a theoretical lens to welfare, social development promotes human rights and dignity, advocating for national participation and democratic decision-making processes (Patel, 2015). The South African social welfare system is largely based on a social development approach, as reflected in the work of Lombard and Kleijn (2006) (the White Paper for Social Welfare in 1997). Due to ever-escalating socio-economic challenges, and within the scope of its social development approach to welfare, South Africa has stepped up its cash transfers to the indigent, particularly millions of vulnerable children (Khan, 2022; Nnaeme et al., 2020).

Ncube (2019) argues that the socio-economic situation in South Africa has worsened since the inception of the new democratic dispensation in 1994, advocating for thorough orientation of social workers on the social development approach to mitigate the prevailing socio-economic challenges. The effectiveness of the social development approach depends on the extent to which the supervision practice is implemented, making social work supervision pivotal in the implementation of this practice approach (Silence, 2017). However, there are significant gaps between policy announcement and its implementation, affecting the application of the approach in practice (Engelbrecht, 2013). It is crucial for supervisors to understand and apply the social development practice approach to ensure effective developmental social work services in South Africa (Ncube, 2019).

In practice, supervisors must have a strong knowledge of social development theory, integrating it into their supervision practices to render quality supervision and enhance service delivery (Engelbrecht, 2013; Ncube, 2019). Despite the importance of supervision, studies indicate that supervision is not always effectively implemented in South Africa, with social workers often not receiving adequate supervision (Engelbrecht, 2010; Mboniswa, 2007). This deficit can negatively impact the application of the social development approach in practice, highlighting the need for improved supervision practices (Engelbrecht, 2013). Thus, social work supervision practice and the service delivery approach within which it operates (in this case, social development) are inextricably linked.

Methodology

Research approach and design

The study adopted a qualitative approach and an instrumental case study design. The qualitative approach provided deep insights into social workers' subjective experiences and perceptions of supervision. The instrumental case study design enabled the examination of social work supervision as a broader phenomenon by focusing on the Gert Sibande District in Mpumalanga, South Africa. An instrumental case study is a type of single case study involving exploring some general areas of the phenomenon, supervision in this case, to enhance understanding rather than a particular case (Kekeya, 2021). With regard to generalisability, while the study is not aimed at statistical generalisation, the insights gained may be transferable to similar contexts or inform broader theories. The focus in this case is seen through the lenses of the few supervisors and supervisees.

Population and sampling

The study focused on social work supervisors and practitioners (supervisees) employed at the DSD in the Gert Sibande District Municipality, Mpumalanga Province, South Africa. Using a non-probability, purposive sampling method, eight participants (four supervisors and four supervisees) were selected based on predefined criteria, including at least 1 year of professional experience with the department and current employment in the district. Participants were chosen independently, avoiding supervisor–supervisee pairings to minimise conflicts of interest and socially desirable responses. The small sample size was justified by the study's qualitative focus, prioritising in-depth understanding of participants' experiences over generalisability. Recruitment took place in October and November 2021 through staff meetings arranged with assistance from district and sub-district officials. During these meetings, the researcher explained the study's objectives and obtained informed consent after providing clear, written information.

Data collection method and tool

The study used a semi-structured interview schedule as an instrument for the collection of the data. Interviews were administered through face-to-face interaction between the researchers and the participants. Greeff (2011: 43) argues that semi-structured interviews allow the researcher to explore the participants' opinions, approaches and ideas about definite phenomena. The following are overarching questions that facilitated data collection: to what extent do participants prioritise social work supervision at the Mpumalanga DSD? What are the views of social work supervisors and social workers on their understanding of the social development approach in practice? To what extent does the supervision used in Mpumalanga DSD teach an understanding of the social development approach? Interview sessions with each participant lasted between 45 and 90 minutes, depending on the depth of data requiring further exploration.

Data analysis

The researchers employed thematic analysis to analyse the data in this study. According to Braun and Clarke (2013), thematic analysis follows a six-phase framework. This framework includes the steps of familiarisation, immersion in the data, theme identification, coding, elaboration, interpretation and verification (Terre Blanche et al., 2006). Themes were identified by coding relevant points, most of which corresponded to the key questions asked of participants. The first researcher did the first round of data analysis after which the second researcher confirmed the process, the themes and the accuracy of the outcomes of the process. Data outliers, particularly those deviating from dominant narratives in the literature, were identified and recorded as findings.

Trustworthiness and rigour

This study adhered to Lincoln and Guba's (1985) model of trustworthiness and rigour. Credibility was enhanced through detailed descriptions of the context, setting and theoretical framework, as well as member checking during and after interviews. Transferability was supported by clearly defining the study's problem, while dependability was ensured through a transparent explanation of the research process. The researchers' background as social workers contributed to their understanding of the phenomenon and the context of the data collection. Neutrality was maintained by minimising biases and conducting correspondence cheques with participants.

Ethics

Ethics clearance was obtained from the University of Johannesburg's Faculty of Humanities Research Ethics Committee, along with permission from Mpumalanga's DSD. No incentives were provided, and to reduce bias, the first researcher excluded the sub-district in which she is employed. Key ethical considerations included informed consent, voluntary participation, confidentiality (using coded identifiers) and ethics of care. Although the study posed minimal risk, arrangements were made with the employee assistance provider to offer counselling if needed.

Limitations of the study

Despite careful preparation and achieving its aims, this research faced limitations beyond the researchers' control. As Wiersma (2000) notes, qualitative research often encounters challenges with validity and reliability due to its specific settings. Another limitation was the small number of

Table 1. Demographic profiles of participants.

Participants	Age	Gender	Race	Section	Work experience	Years under supervision
Supervisee A	27	Female	Black	Social work – foster care	4	4
Supervisee B	24	Female	Black	Social work – foster care	4	4
Supervisor A	42	Male	Black	Social work supervisor – foster care	17	11
Supervisee C	29	Female	Black	Social work – foster care	6	6
Supervisor B	45	Female	Black	Social work supervisor – foster care	8	8
Supervisor C	46	Female	Black	Acting social work supervisor – foster care	8	10
Supervisee D	30	Female	Black	Social work – foster care	8	8
Supervisor D	42	Female	Black	Acting social work supervisor – foster care	8	8

participants, which restricts generalisability. However, it is in the nature of instrumental case studies to be less concerned about the case but use the collected data, irrespective of the size, to provide an insight into a broader phenomenon, setting the stage for future, larger studies. Researchers took steps to ensure that these limitations did not undermine the study's overall credibility.

Data presentation and discussion

Profile of participants

The initial section of the interview schedule was designed to gather the participants' key demographic information. Table 1 presents the demographic profiles of the eight participants, including their age, gender, race, job level, social work experience, years of supervision at the DSD and time spent in their current role. These demographic details serve as a validation tool. To ensure participants' confidentiality, the researchers used alphabetical codes for identification.

Gender of participants

The participant profile reveals a higher number of females than males, consistent with Whalley's (2012: 92) observation that social work is predominantly a female-dominated profession. This finding is supported by scholars, such as Canpolat (2022), who notes that men often gravitate towards careers in science and engineering, while women tend to choose fields like social work, education and administrative support. Despite this gender distribution, it did not influence the study's outcomes, as gender was not a relevant factor in the research.

Participants' job titles

The study included four social work supervisees, consisting of two junior social workers and two senior social workers. In addition, there were four social work supervisors, with two permanently employed as supervisors and the other two serving as acting supervisors. This indicates that the

employer is making efforts to comply with statutory requirements for supervision practice. While the social work supervisees had an average of over 5 years of practice experience, the supervisors averaged 22 years of experience. This level of experience aligned well with the study's objectives, as the participants were well-equipped to provide in-depth insights into the phenomenon of supervision in their context.

Setting

All participants are assigned to the foster care unit within the DSD. This unit is tasked with ensuring the care and protection of children unable to reside with their biological families due to circumstances, such as neglect, abuse, abandonment or the death of primary caregivers. As the largest social service unit within the department, the foster care unit represents a significant proportion of the department's social work activities. Notably, the DSD is the largest employer of social workers in South Africa, underscoring its pivotal role in the country's child welfare system.

Main themes emerging from data

Functions of supervision: Administrative, educational and supportive dimensions

The question on the functions of supervision was posed to both groups of participants. In line with earlier theorisations of supervision, Engelbrecht (2010) reflects on three functions of supervision. These were used as themes given the collected data.

Administrative function

Administrative supervision primarily emphasises the accurate, effective and timely implementation of organisational policies and procedures (Engelbrecht, 2010). It also centres on evaluating the supervisee's performance against established standards. The participants' responses regarding the administrative component of supervision were consistent, though expressed differently. Below are some of the direct quotes from the data.

> The administrative component is where the focus of our supervision is mostly based on. As a social worker, I always require assistance from my supervisor on how I can complete forms which are used within the department to render services. (Supervisee A)

> I employ the administrative function as I always assist the social workers with information about procedures and processes of completing forms at the Department. The focus of our work is largely statutory foster care. (Supervisor A)

> The administrative function is adequately implemented as there are times you are just given a form or any other document without receiving proper explanation on what is expected or what I must do as a social worker. My supervisor always guides me accordingly. I now understand most procedures because of the guidance from my supervisor. (Supervisee B)

Evidently, participants reflected a level of understanding social work supervision's administrative function and its impact on their functioning. Nonetheless, there was a varying degree to which supervisors employed this function of supervision practice. While some participants were happy

with the level of administrative function applied in their contexts, there were others who noted its application but wished that more of it could be employed. Participants understood the centrality of supervision, and the administrative function in line with Voicu's (2017) postulation that the practice is a solution that can bring support, competence, education, information, orientation, which provides a good development for the professional workflow.

Educational function

Kadushin and Harkness (2014) note that educational supervision is centred on enhancing the practitioner's knowledge, skills and methods essential for effective field practice. Engelbrecht (2010) adds that this function supports the supervisee in advancing their professional competencies to perform their tasks more effectively. Mokoka (2016) agrees, stating that this component empowers supervisees to intervene across various situations and levels of intervention within their field. According to DSD and SACSSP (2012), this aspect of supervision also addresses the educational needs of the supervisee within the context of an agreed-upon workload. Below are some of the quotes from the collected data.

> Opportunities for continuous development are provided to us through regular external workshops. These workshops facilitate the development of our knowledge and skills. (Supervisee C)

> Due to the amount of workload that one has as a supervisor there is hardly time to do any supervisory functions beyond the administrative function. As a result, we send supervisees for external workshops to supplement their knowledge. (Supervisor B)

> The educational function is done when it's convenient for both parties. While it is important, the work conditions relating to the workload of both the supervisor and the supervisee does not allow one to spend elongated periods on supervision. (Supervisor C)

The presented data suggest that the educational function of supervision is constrained by workload pressures for both supervisors and supervisees. Second, given these constraints, workshops become an alternative to supervision to develop supervisees' knowledge and skills. However, if supervisees can find time for workshops, they may as well find time for comprehensive supervision, which is usually less than that of a workshop. It then leaves the workload of supervisors as the only plausible excuse for failure to execute educational supervision. There may be other reasons, such as competence of supervisors and lack of interest but that is beyond the scope of the collected data. Furthermore, supervision appears to be scheduled on convenience rather than integrated into the regular workflow. As such, educational function is treated as supplementary to the administrative function.

Support function

Participants shared their experiences in the support function of supervision. While supervisees stated that they do not experience the support function in their instances, supervisors indicated the contrary as reflected in the data below:

> Very poor, we don't have support to deal with emotional issues that may affect our work as the focus is always on administration. (Supervisee A)

> As the supervisor, I ensure that I observe my supervisee's performance and where need be, provide support. It is not always the case that a supervisee needs emotional support, but I am always available when such arises. (Supervisor A)

> As I am always rendering supervision, I always ensure that I support my supervisees emotionally and all the time they need that support. (Supervisor B)

> From my experience, our supervisors prioritise administrative functioning with particular focus on quantity that quality at any cost. There is no emotional support at all. (Supervisee C)

Responses suggest a disparity in the perception and delivery of emotional support. This inconsistency suggests that the support function is not uniformly integrated into the supervision process, leading to gaps in addressing supervisees' emotional needs. The emphasis on the administrative function and quantities in service delivery overshadows the supportive function of supervision which may, inadvertently impact on the quality-of-service delivery. This imbalance in the focus of supervision functions may also suggest a systemic issue where the organisational culture and structure negates the overall importance of a comprehensive application of supervision. A focus on quantifying outcomes and 'pushing numbers' is often seen as a neoliberal approach, which has a significant and frequently detrimental impact on social services (Engelbrecht, 2015a; Ornellas and Engelbrecht, 2020a; Tsui and Cheung, 2004).

In a similar study where issues of workload and preoccupation with quantities were highlighted, Ncube (2019) found that supervision was somewhat an inconvenience to both the supervisors and supervisees. This is largely due to a lack of appreciation of the science of supervision in enhancing service delivery. Mokoka (2016) emphasises the importance of fostering a close relationship between the supervisor and the social work supervisee to create a safe space where both can openly share any negative emotions triggered in their practice. Tsui (2005) highlights that supervisors and supervisees often have different expectations regarding the administrative, educational and supportive aspects of supervision. He stresses the importance of balancing and acknowledging these three functions, with the supportive function being the most crucial. Carpenter et al. (2015) further note that a lack of emotional support, inadequate supervision and feeling out of one's depth are key factors contributing to high burnout rates.

Methods, frequency and strategies of supervision

It has been indicated that the practice of supervision in social work is a vital process that enhances professional development and ensures that social workers deliver services effectively. Tsui (2005) highlights various supervision methods tailored to meet the needs of social workers. The DSD and SACSSP (2012) emphasise individual and group supervision methods, both of which must align with the ethical code for social workers. The choice between these methods is influenced by the nature of the supervisees' work, their goals and the proximity and frequency of interaction between the supervisor and supervisee.

Participants in this study shared experiences of both individual and group supervision, with a preference for individual supervision. This method allows for one-on-one interaction between the supervisor and supervisee, promoting professional growth and enabling the supervisee to gain deeper insights into the profession (DSD and SACSSP, 2012; Tsui, 2005). One participant noted that although both individual and group supervision are utilised, individual supervision tends to be more practical and structured, particularly given the high caseloads that can sometimes lead to unstructured individual sessions.

> . . . but the one type of supervision that I think is easy to implement is individual supervision. However, due to high caseloads it gets very unstructured as there is hardly time for formalities.

> In our office both the individual and group supervision are facilitated as there are aspects of our work that we discuss as a group while others require individual supervision. (Supervisee C)

Group supervision, on the contrary, focuses on collective discussions, skill development and professional growth, with the supervisor as the designated leader (Alschuler et al., 2015). This method allows supervisees to share experiences and information, fostering a collaborative environment. However, challenges, such as inconsistent attendance, can hinder the effectiveness of group supervision, leading to a preference for individual sessions where supervisees receive more focused attention.

The frequency and depth of supervision significantly impact the effectiveness of social work practice. Engelbrecht (2015a) posits that the frequency of supervision is often determined by the supervisee's experience and competency level. New employees may receive weekly supervision, while more experienced supervisees might have less frequent sessions. The depth of these sessions varies, with some being brief and unplanned, while others are more in-depth, addressing complex cases and issues that affect the supervisee's performance. Ncube (2029 refers to impromptu supervision as ad hoc supervision that is based on a specific need of the supervisee on a particular issue. This is what many social workers have become accustomed to, particularly in government offices.

Participants expressed the need for regular, structured supervision indicating that its absence or poor application impugns the integrity of the profession and affects the quality-of-service delivery, Similarly, Bogo and McKnight (2005) emphasise that the greater the frequency of supervision, the more satisfied supervisees are with their professional development. However, there is a lack of uniformity in supervision frequency across different offices, with the professionalism and experience of social workers guiding when and how often supervision occurs.

> The frequency of supervision is based on the supervisee's experience and competency level. New employees receive weekly supervision, while those with 3–5 years of service typically have monthly sessions. Supervisees with over 5 years of experience also receive monthly supervision, but some transition to consultations depending on the complexity of their cases. (Supervisor A)

> . . .supervision usually takes place at unplanned moments and sometimes it is touch and go where we de-stress and discuss a lot of cases and issues affecting our functioning. Yesterday we had a two-hour session, it was unplanned. (Supervisee D)

In essence, while both individual and group supervision methods are employed in social work, individual supervision is often preferred due to its structured nature and ability to cater to the specific needs of supervisees. The frequency and depth of supervision play crucial roles in the professional development of social workers, though inconsistencies in practice highlight the need for more standardised approaches.

Supporting strategies of supervision

Supervision in social work is enhanced by several supporting strategies, including mentoring, consultation, peer consultation, live supervision and online supervision. These strategies are crucial in adapting supervision to the specific environmental context where services are rendered (Engelbrecht,

2012; Scott, 2009). The implementation of these strategies varies depending on the needs of the supervisees and the conditions under which they work. These are some of the subthemes that emerged from the collected data.

Mentoring and consultation

Mentoring as a supporting strategy in social work supervision is characterised by a nurturing and supportive relationship between a seasoned, knowledgeable practitioner (mentor) and a less experienced individual (protégé or mentee). In this relationship, the protégé gains personal and career-related benefits through guidance and support from the mentor (Henry et al., 1994). It primarily focuses on professional development, accountability and investment in the learning relationship, addressing the supervisees' professional development needs. In corroboration, Gallacher (1997) notes that the need for mentoring and coaching in social work is driven by issues related to personnel development in early intervention. As Engelbrecht (2013) notes, mentoring enhances the purpose of supervision and work development.

Consultation, another key strategy, is a process within supervision that addresses challenges as they arise. According to the DSD and the SACSSP (2012), consultation encourages supervisees to work independently while maintaining the responsibility to seek guidance when needed. Although the use of the term consultation, among others, is contended by Engelbrecht (2012) as a neoliberal tendency, DSD and SACSSP (2012) define it as an activity in supervision for seasoned practitioners with no need for structured supervision. This approach allows for the timely resolution of cases, even when time for supervision is limited. One supervisor shared,

> I do not get mentorship in a formally arranged manner. I was only assigned a supervisor when I initially got employed and it ended there. I however learn from other senior practitioners that I look up to. That is the extent to which I related with mentorship. (Supervisee B)

> The supervision sessions that I render to my supervisees help because whether I am there or not, they are able to cope without me. The majority of my supervisees are on consultation, they have experience in the field and need not to be closely watched. (Supervisor C)

Setting the supervisory agenda and structure

Both the supervisor and the supervisee share the responsibility of setting up and structuring the supervision agenda. Munson (2002) emphasises that a clear, formal structure and agenda are crucial for the development of the supervisee. However, in many offices, this responsibility often falls predominantly on the supervisors. A supervisee explained,

> When I used to have supervision, I would put my cases on the agenda and submit them to my supervisor. If she felt something needed to be added, she would do so, but it was usually me. (Supervisee B)

Despite this, some participants indicated that supervisors typically take the lead in setting the agenda. This centralised control can limit the shared responsibility that is ideal for effective supervision. As Carpenter et al. (2012) suggest, without clear role specifications, the effectiveness of supervision practices can be compromised. The responses indicate a need for balance in decision-making to ensure that both supervisors and supervisees can demonstrate competency and contribute to the supervision process.

Variations in supervision practices and their impacts on professional development and effectiveness

Supervision practices vary significantly across different offices. Kadushin and Harkness (2002) stress the importance of regular supervision; however, some participants reported inconsistent or infrequent supervision. For example, participants stated,

> I have not received supervision since 2018; I receive feedback only through comments on files. (Supervisee B)

> Supervision happens only if there is a need; my supervisees can perform most duties independently. (Supervisor D)

These variations suggest that supervisees who receive regular supervision become more self-sufficient, addressing challenges on their own and gaining the necessary skills and knowledge to perform effectively. Prindle (2012) argues that such supervision fosters self-efficacy, as it builds the supervisor's trust in the supervisee's ability to handle challenging tasks. Reflecting on the role of supervision, one supervisor remarked on the challenges of stepping into the role unprepared:

> We were not properly prepared when we transitioned to new positions as supervisors. The lack of a proper background hit us hard. (Supervisor C)

This highlights the importance of a strong foundation and preparation in developing effective supervisory practices. It brings to question the level of training that supervisors get in their undergraduate studies and beyond in preparation for this middle-management function.

Supervision: Importance, implementation and attitudes

Supervision in social work plays a pivotal role in safeguarding service users, supporting practitioners and upholding professional standards. Noble and Irwin (2009) argue that supervision ensures social service users are protected; provides support for practitioners; ensures that practitioners maintain professional standards and good principles of professional practice and that work expected from the organisation is interpreted through a professional lens and delivered by professional and competent workers. This underlines the necessity of consistent and effective supervision in the social work field. Participants in the study echoed these sentiments, with some emphasising the critical nature of supervision in their daily work. One supervisor shared,

> I believe that supervision is highly important in my office, and I make it a priority to adhere to our supervision schedule, even though other commitments may sometimes take precedence.

This statement reflects a commitment to the supervisory process and highlights its importance in ensuring that social workers are well-supported and guided in their roles. However, not all experiences with supervision were positive. Some participants reported a lack of consistency, which they felt negatively impacted their work. A supervisee stated,

> I, personally, think the practice of supervision at my office is not at all important as it does not happen at all. I was last supervised when I arrived at the department as a new employee; other than that, it never happens at all, even though many times I personally see the importance of being supervised. Being in the field is challenging without supervision.

This contrast in experiences suggests that while the importance of supervision is recognised, its implementation varies significantly across different offices. For those who receive regular supervision, it is viewed as an essential tool that contributes to their professional development and effectiveness. On the contrary, the absence of supervision leaves some social workers feeling unsupported and ill-prepared to handle the complexities of their work. Despite these challenges, the consensus among participants was that supervision is a vital component of social work. When properly implemented, it ensures that social workers are managed, supported and developed, leading to more proficient and effective service delivery. Recognising the significance of supervision is the first step towards ensuring that it is consistently practised, ultimately benefitting both social workers and the clients they serve.

Attitudes towards supervision

The attitudes of social workers and supervisors towards supervision significantly influence its implementation and effectiveness. A sense of duty and responsibility is crucial for both parties to engage in meaningful supervision. However, the study revealed a range of attitudes, with some participants expressing a lack of enthusiasm or commitment to the process. One supervisor noted,

> I don't think we will be able to do supervision; it will now always be consultations. Most social workers (supervisees) no longer have a sense of duty, even when they are not at work and you call them, they tell you that they are off and not at work today, they don't answer their phones even when it's a case of emergency. When they come back to work, there are already a lot of cases that need to be dealt with, and there definitely won't be time for supervision.

This statement reflects a broader issue within the organisational structure, where heavy workloads and inadequate scheduling impact the feasibility of regular supervision. As Engelbrecht (2013) notes, structural and organisational issues, such as counterproductive working conditions, are significant factors that can hinder the implementation of effective supervision. Another participant highlighted a different challenge, stating,

> Social workers lie a lot to get out of the supervision appointment. Their attitude towards supervision is really worrying.

This response suggests a breakdown in trust and communication between supervisors and supervisees, which further complicates the supervisory process. These attitudes indicate that supervision is not always perceived as a positive or necessary part of social work practice. Instead, it is sometimes viewed as an additional burden or even a punitive measure, rather than a supportive and developmental tool. This misalignment of perceptions and attitudes can undermine the effectiveness of supervision and limit its potential benefits.

Understanding and application of the social development practice approach in social work

The study also explored participants' understanding of the social development practice approach, which is essential for social work practice in South Africa. Ncube (2019) indicates the importance of social workers' understanding of this practice approach as it operationalises the overarching approach of social welfare in South Africa. It informs the developmental social work practice, which all social work practitioners in the country should be conversant with. The responses varied

widely, reflecting different levels of knowledge and familiarity with the concept. One supervisee described the social development practice approach as

> a holistic approach to social work as it enforces sustainable development by ensuring active involvement/participation of community members in addressing their impediments or remedy their situations within families. It is aimed at improving the standard of living in society by ensuring equitable service delivery.

This understanding aligns with the principles of the social development approach, which emphasises people-centred and rights-based practices. However, not all participants shared this level of understanding. Another participant admitted,

> Please remind me what this social development practice approach is about. I have been in this field for too long. Please remind me as I have forgotten.

This lack of familiarity among some supervisors highlights a significant gap in knowledge that could impact the effective application of the social development practice approach in practice. As Bogo (2015) notes, it is essential for supervisors to have a strong theoretical foundation to guide their supervisees effectively. In the taxonomy of research gaps, Miles (2017) identifies knowledge gap, practical-knowledge conflict gap and theoretical gap among others. These apply in this case given the very limited knowledge and practical implications of social development as an overarching approach to practice.

The study indicated that a good number of participants were oblivious of the social development practice approach even though the services they provide are part of the multimodal intervention services of the social development practice approach. The approach allows for integrative programmes and various intervention methods, as Patel (2015) emphasises. One participant reflected, 'We ensure that individuals and communities are empowered through educational campaigns, dialogue, and providing skills' (Supervisor B). This aligns with Patel's multimodal approach to service delivery under the broader social development paradigm.

In addition to the available theoretical approaches that guide social work supervision, such as the strength-based perspective and systems theory, Ncube (2019) developed 'A Process Model of Social Development Supervision in Social Work' aimed at facilitating an understanding and adoption of the social development approach by supervisors. Nonetheless, in an environment where the practice of supervision is not essentialised, any approach to practice would be irrelevant. Those that were exposed to supervision remarked on the various approaches. Supervisor A noted,

> Some approaches which form part of supervision are strength-based approach, family-centred approach, ecological/system approach etc.

Engelbrecht (2010) and Zastrow (2010: 76) describe the strength-based perspective as focusing on 'strengths and abilities people already have'. Some participants indicated a mix of approaches, including the developmental approach, though not always consistently (Supervisee C). One participant said, 'I am still applying the skills that I learnt in my undergraduate studies' (Supervisee A). Another added, 'Supervision emphasised facilitating change, strengths, empowerment, and social justice' (Supervisee C).

However, not all participants felt supervision enhanced their understanding of the social development approach. One commented, 'I don't see it like that because the supervision is only focusing on the administration' (Supervisee A). This suggests a disconnect between supervision practice and any approach to supervision. In essence, it may suggest that whatever is deemed to be supervision has no scientific basis. On the contrary, Ornellas and Engelbrecht (2020b) contend that neoliberal

policies adopted by numerous governments, including South Africa, have significantly impacted social welfare spending. The reduction in welfare expenditure may also influence the priorities of social work supervisors, with effective supervision potentially being deprioritised, as observed in this study. These policies also entrench managerialism, the application of corporate management principles in social work that undermine the quality and processes of the profession (Engelbrecht, 2015b).

Conclusion

The findings reveal that social work supervision at the Gert Sibande District lacks alignment with the prescribed supervision framework for South African social workers. There is an absence of standardised structures and policies, leading to inadequate supervision practices. This misalignment between supervisory practices and broader social work frameworks, such as the social development approach, resonates with findings from studies in other developing contexts where systemic barriers hinder the implementation of theoretical approaches (Dominelli, 1997; Hugman et al., 2010; Lyons and Huang, 2012; Midgley, 1995).

The focus is more on the administrative function of supervision and less on the educational and supportive functions, which negatively impacts social work interventions. This is a significant challenge reflected in international literature especially in resource-limited contexts (Kadushin and Harkness, 2014). This finding corroborates what Sewpaul and Hölscher (2004) noted, stating that without adequate supervision and training, social workers struggle to operationalise developmental frameworks. While some supervisees understand the social development practice approach as an overarching approach to social welfare in South Africa better, others were oblivious to it. Nevertheless, supervisees generally showed a better understanding of the practice approach than their supervisors, who often lack specific training for supervisory roles and are burdened with managerial duties. This finding challenges traditional hierarchical models of supervision often reported in international studies, where supervisors typically possess advanced expertise (Bloom and Schaub, 2007; Kadushin and Harkness, 2014; Miers and Randle, 2004; Tsui, 2005). Supervision often defaults to ad hoc consultations rather than structured support, and planned supervision sessions frequently experience scheduling issues.

The current supervisory practices fail to foster the social development approach effectively, with minimal compliance to scheduled sessions and a lack of focus on the supervisees' needs. This misalignment is compounded by supervisors being promoted based on seniority in the workplace rather than supervisory expertise. As a result, the Gert Sibande District's supervision does not significantly enhance understanding or application of the social development approach, reflecting similar issues identified in previous studies (Nadesan, 2020; Ncube, 2019). An instrumental case study design was used to provide a glimpse on the phenomenon in each area.

The findings underscore the salience of structured, educational and supportive supervision, which aligns with global best practices but requires contextual adaptation. It is recommended that broader studies on social work supervision be undertaken to determine the kinds of interventions needed to recalibrate the practice as well as develop means to evaluate progress. The recommendation for broader studies and systemic reforms in South Africa contributes to international discussions on addressing supervision gaps in under-resourced settings, offering insights applicable to other regions facing similar challenges.

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Supplemental material

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Article

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Psychosocial and vulnerability factors affecting well-being of migrant mothers from Latin America: A scoping review

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Abstract
This scoping review examines the experiences of migrant mothers from Latin America, highlighting psychosocial and vulnerability factors affecting their well-being in migration contexts. Focusing on south-to-south migration and the gendered experiences of caregiving women, it

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addresses a significant gap in the literature. Findings reveal unique challenges such as acculturation stress, economic hardships, limited social support, and mental health issues exacerbated by marginalization due to caregiving roles. Practice implications for social work and policy include culturally competent interventions and the design of supportive policies tailored to migrant mothers' needs.

Keywords
Acculturation, cultural competency, mental health, policy, social work, transients and migrants

Introduction

Stress during childhood rearing years, related to parenting, predicts anxiety and depression among mothers. Living conditions and support from partners, family, and friends are significant predictors of mental health-related issues (Skipstein et al., 2012). Understanding how migrant mothers in different countries respond to these stressors is an emerging field of study. Migration introduces challenges exacerbating mothers' stress during childrearing, including disrupted social networks, precarious living conditions, and limited access to health care services (World Health Organization, 2017). Considering that childbearing is a major life-changing event, supporting mothers during the multiple transitions becomes paramount. Multiple studies have reported that the benefits of support during child-rearing years go beyond mothers' own well-being (Al Sager et al., 2024; Cucinella et al., 2022; Ekström-Bergström et al., 2022), impacting their children's health and development, as well as broader social and economic gains.

Global migration trends further underscore the relevance of these concerns. In 2020, 3.6% of the world's population were migrants, with 14.8 million residing in Latin America and the Caribbean. Europe is the primary destination for international immigrants, followed by Asia and North America, with the United States hosting 51 million (McAuliffe and Triandafyllidou, 2021). Countries such as Brazil, Argentina, Colombia, and Chile show significant increases in migrant populations, while Venezuela had 5.4 million emigrants as of mid-2020 (International Organization for Migration, n.d.).

As numbers of migrant women increase, caregiving stress and mental health challenges rise due to navigating stressors in a foreign country without support. Migrant mothers face risks, such as legal, social, and health barriers, adversely affecting their physical, mental, and social well-being (Van der Laat, 2017). Additional grief stressors for migrant mothers include loss of support networks and challenges in balancing work and caregiving responsibilities (Burin, 2008; Ramírez Ramos et al., 2020). These factors potentially affect both mothers and children, leading to health issues, work–family imbalance, changes in family functioning, reduced social networks, and anxiety transmission (Non et al., 2019). Limited access to health care leaves many migrant mothers to contend with mental health conditions that go untreated (Achotegui, 2020).

This review focuses on psychosocial factors (stressors and coping strategies) associated with the migratory process that impact women's well-being in the childrearing stage and can be amplified by vulnerability factors. Vulnerabilities are intrinsic characteristics that escape the control of people affected (Brown, 2011). They can be observed across various dimensions, including socioeconomic status, income, employment, health, education, housing access, crime, and environment (McLennan et al., 2011). These vulnerability factors contribute to stressors, amplifying their effect on people. Regarding stressors, acculturation – a significant post-migration challenge – involves cultural clashes, language barriers, and a lack of empowerment resources (Bernstein, 2011; Munyi Shea and Wong, 2022). Parental stress, due to perceiving the demands of parenting as surpassing

available resources, is high among mothers because of their caregiving roles, impacting their health and that of their children (Pérez-López et al., 2012).

Coping strategies have the potential to moderate the effects of stressors and vulnerabilities on mothers' well-being. Migrant women manifest resilience through techniques such as intrinsic motivation, positive perspective, spirituality, cultural traditions, social support, family welfare focus, self-belief, and valuing education (Aubé et al., 2019; Cabrerizo and Villacieros, 2019; Jeffers and Vocke, 2017). While existing literature explores migration and mental health, there is a lack of focus on gendered experiences, culturally specific coping strategies, and protective factors influencing well-being among migrant women from Latin America. Previous studies have primarily examined migrant populations in general and children's experiences (Andrade et al., 2023), neglecting the experiences of migrant mothers. This gap limits our ability to fully understand the nuanced ways motherhood intersects with migration, possibly leading to incomplete or non-specific interventions. Addressing this gap is crucial for developing targeted interventions that support migrant mothers' well-being, which is essential for maternal and child health outcomes and for culturally pertinent recommendations within national health and migration policies.

This scoping review explores the intersection of migration, caregiving roles, and mental health among migrant mothers. Specifically, it seeks to

1. Identify the psychosocial and vulnerability factors impacting the well-being of migrant mothers from Latin America,
2. Examine the coping strategies these mothers use to navigate migration-related stressors, and
3. Highlight gaps in existing literature regarding gendered experiences and culturally specific coping mechanisms among Latin American migrant mothers.

The review focuses on women from Latin America who have migrated within or outside of the American continent. Addressing this gap is crucial for developing targeted interventions that support migrant mothers' well-being. This is essential for maternal and child health outcomes and for culturally pertinent recommendations for research and interventions within national health and migration policies.

Methods

A scoping review is suitable for this study because knowledge about the research area is relatively scarce (Peters et al., 2015). This scoping review was conducted following the methodological framework outlined by Arksey and O'Malley (2005), which is appropriate for exploring complex and under-researched areas such as the psychosocial and vulnerability factors affecting migrant mothers from Latin America. This approach allows a comprehensive mapping of existing literature to identify key concepts, gaps, and evidence types relevant to social work practice and policy. Moreover, the review includes literature that reports country-specific experiences of human mobility, which can shed light on the childrearing experiences of mothers from Latin America more generally, providing cultural and historical-specific clues about key areas for further study (Munn et al., 2018).

Identifying the research question

The research question guiding this review was: How do psychosocial and vulnerability factors affect the well-being of migrant mothers from Latin America, and what coping strategies do they employ in migration contexts?

Identifying relevant studies

A systematic search was conducted across five databases: Google Scholar, EBSCO Host, PubMed, Scopus, and SciELO, covering literature from 2013 to 2023. Search terms included combinations of keywords in English and Spanish, such as

- 'madres' AND 'inmigrantes' AND 'América Latina' AND 'crianza';
- 'Latin American' AND 'immigrant mothers' AND 'vulnerability factors';
- 'Migrant mothers' OR 'Parenting migrant women' AND 'mental health stressors'.

Study selection

The initial search yielded 527 articles. After removing duplicates and non-relevant studies, 65 records remained. Two researchers independently screened titles and abstracts against predefined inclusion and exclusion criteria, resulting in 33 articles for full-text review. The inclusion criteria focused on

- Studies involving migrant mothers from Latin America;
- Discussions on stress, vulnerability, well-being, and coping strategies;
- Articles published in English or Spanish.

Two authors independently reviewed the full text of each article, extracted data, and analyzed it to identify key themes and findings related to the well-being of migrant mothers to reduce selection and confirmation bias. Discrepancies were resolved through discussion or consultation with a third researcher. A standardized data extraction form was used to minimize procedural bias. Figure 1 presents a Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA) flow diagram (Moher et al., 2009) detailing the search strategy.

Charting the data

Data extraction involved collecting information on study characteristics, participant demographics, and key findings related to psychosocial and vulnerability factors identified and reported coping strategies. Two researchers conducted this process independently to ensure accuracy and reliability. Table 1 shows the summary of the articles included in the scoping review.

Collating, summarizing, and reporting results

Following the recommendations of Braun and Clarke (2006), a thematic analysis was performed to identify and synthesize key themes. Two researchers experienced in qualitative research conducted the data analysis. Accordingly, with Guba and Lincon (1982) dimensions for rigor in qualitative research, they independently reviewed and coded the data generating initial codes organized into overarching themes, with regular discussions to resolve any discrepancies. This collaborative approach enhanced the credibility and trustworthiness of the findings. Themes were identified through an iterative process of coding and categorization. While the researchers looked for patterns and recurring ideas related to psychosocial stressors, vulnerability factors, and coping mechanisms from a deductive approach, they were mindful of allowing space for more inductive categories to emerge. Themes such as acculturation stress, economic struggles,

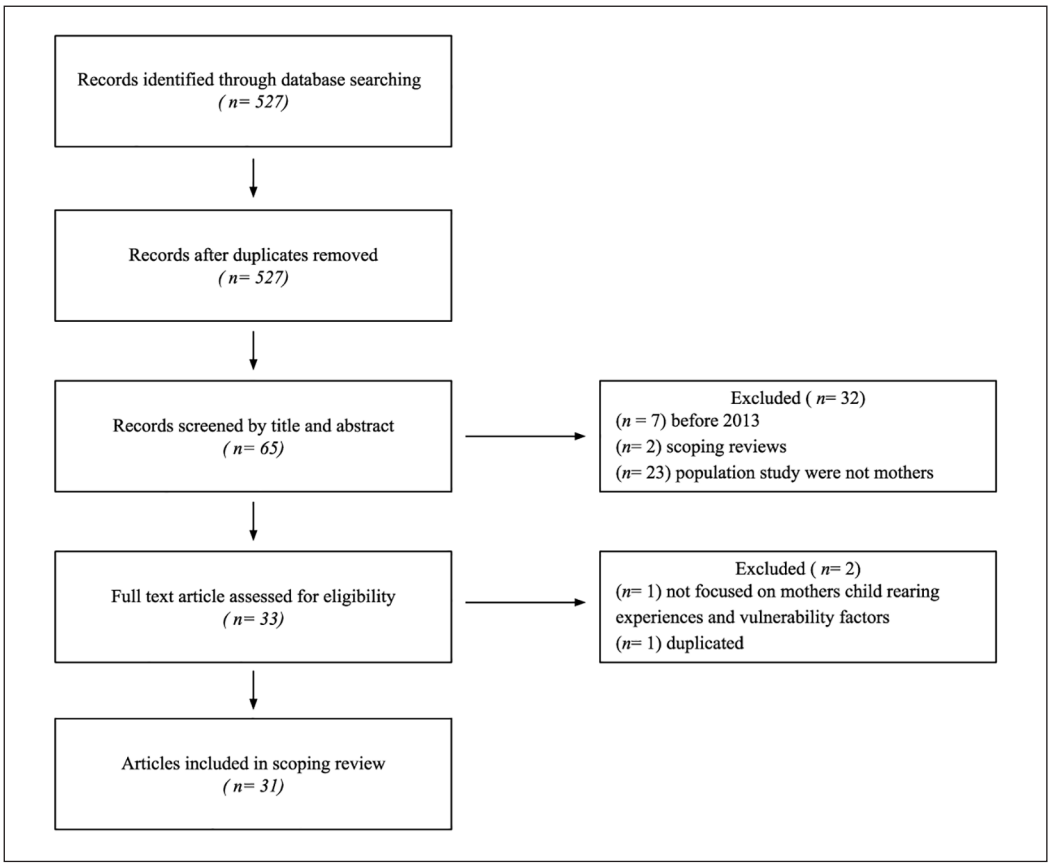

Figure 1. Article inclusion process using PRISMA flowchart.

social support networks, parenting challenges, mental health issues, and resilience emerged from the data.

Limitations

Within this scoping review, several barriers hindered the full inclusivity of information regarding the psychosocial and vulnerability factors affecting migrant mothers. The 10-year range of the review might overlook long-term cultural and socioeconomic trends impacting migrant mothers' well-being, necessitating an evaluation over a more extended period. In addition, most studies focused on specific countries, particularly Chile and the United States, which may have skewed the results, making them more representative of the conditions in these locations rather than providing a comprehensive regional perspective. The search strategy, which involved five databases, may have limited the initial pool of articles. Each database has unique search parameters, leading to variations in the generalization of search results. Differences in search terms and the way databases categorize results, some by country and others by region, could have influenced the breadth and diversity of the included studies. The specificity of the search terms yielded a smaller pool of articles, potentially excluding relevant studies that did not fit the exact criteria.

Table 1. Summary of the articles included in the scoping review.

Authors	Title	Study Design	Location	Sample	Objectives	Key Findings
Edward Johnn Silva Giraldo, Fredi Everardo Correa Romero, Luis Felipe García y Barragán	Social representations of child-rearing and education among Venzuelan migrants (Representaciones sociales de la crianza y educación entre migrantes venezolanos)	Qualitative, content analysis	Bogotá, Colombia	31 Venezuelan migrants (28 women and 3 men) living in the Unir II neighborhood of Engativá, Bogotá	Describe the social representations of parenting practices among Venezuelan migrants in Bogotá, Colombia	Migration significantly impacts family structures and dynamics. Venezuelan migrant families in Bogotá tend to maintain their cultural identity while trying to integrate into the new social environment. Economic conditions, social support, and the involvement of extended family are crucial factors affecting their well-being. Communication within the family and maintaining cultural values are central to their parenting practices.
María Constanza Gutiérrez Aldana	Transnational migration and its impact on parenting patterns (La migración transnacional y su incidencia en las pautas de crianza)	Mixed-methods, phenomenological-hermeneutic paradigm	Bogotá, Colombia	16 families with a parent who migrated for at least one year. Participants included parents who migrated to Spain, the United States, and Chile, as well as family members residing in Colombia	Identify aspects affecting family systems and changes in affective relationships and economic situations due to migration	Migration changes authority, decision-making, and parental roles; mothers take on new roles, including authority and provision. Fathers who migrate face challenges in maintaining authority and emotional connections with children. Economic improvement is often a motivation for migration, but it leads to complex adjustments in family dynamics and caregiving roles
Edward Johnn Silva Giraldo, Julián Gabriel Castaño Londoño, Geraldine Peña Galvis, Daniel Mauricio Sánchez Bohórquez	Narratives of upbringing and the schooling process in migrant families (Narrativas de la crianza y del proceso de escolarización en familias migrantes)	Qualitative, narrative analysis	Bogotá, Colombia	Venezuelan migrant families in Bogotá, particularly those participating in extracurricular programs provided by Fundación Casas de los Sueños.	Present research advances on parenting and schooling narratives in Venezuelan migrant families in Bogotá	Migrant families face challenges in caregiving roles and schooling; rely on networks for support; strive to maintain cultural traditions despite integration challenges
Sarah Bruhn, Gabrielle Oliveira	Multidirectional carework across borders: Latina immigrant women negotiating motherhood and daughterhood	Qualitative, ethnographic	Greater Boston metropolitan area, USA	63 Latina immigrant mothers from various Latin American countries, including El Salvador, Brazil, Guatemala, Peru, Colombia, Mexico, and Honduras. Participants included both undocumented women and those with various legal statuses	Examine transnational caregiving roles of Latina immigrant women as mothers and daughters across borders	Latina immigrant women engage in multidirectional carework, balancing caregiving roles for their children in the United States and their parents in their countries of origin. Immigration policies and legal status significantly impact their ability to perform these roles, leading to emotional stress and economic challenges. Despite these challenges, women find agency and pride in their caregiving roles, using them to maintain family cohesion and cultural identity.

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Authors	Title	Study Design	Location	Sample	Objectives	Key Findings
Elizabeth Berroca	Latin American immigrant mothers in Spain: Perceived challenges and opportunities	Qualitative, semistructured interviews	Asturias, Spain	13 Latina immigrant mothers and expectant mothers living in Asturias, Spain. Participants came from six Latin American countries: Brazil, Colombia, Dominican Republic, Ecuador, Guatemala, and Peru.	Investigate post-immigration perceptions, attitudes, and experiences of Latina immigrant mothers in Spain	Latina immigrant mothers face significant personal, economic, and social challenges in Spain, including single parenthood, economic hardship, and racism. Despite these challenges, they perceive greater opportunities in Spain for their children, including better educational prospects, increased safety, and more personal independence compared to their countries of origin. The women showed resilience and psychological empowerment in their determination to improve their lives and those of their children.
Colleen K. Vesely, Rachael D. Goodman, Marriam Ewaida, Katina B. Kearney	A Better Life? Immigrant Mothers' Experiences Building Economic Security	Qualitative, in-depth interviews	Washington, DC, and Northern Virginia, USA	40 low-income, first-generation immigrant mothers from Latin America (n = 21) and Africa (n = 19). Participants were enrolled in means-tested early childhood care and education (ECCE) programs in Washington, DC, and northern Virgini	Examine economic experiences and strategies of immigrant mothers for building economic security	Immigrant mothers face significant economic challenges and rely on a patchwork of informal and formal supports to build economic security. Government programs are crucial, but accessibility is limited by legal status, documentation issues, and anti-immigrant sentiments. Social networks play a vital role in providing emotional and logistical support. The concept of economic security is shaped by cultural values and the need to balance immediate financial needs with long-term goals.
Eileen Díaz McConnell, Aggie J. Yellow Horse	Vulnerable and Resilient: Legal Status, Sources of Support, Maternal Knowledge, and the Family Routines of Mexican and Central American-origin Mothers in Los Angeles	Quantitative, survey-based analysis	Los Angeles, USA	Mothers of school-aged children (Mexican and Central-American origin). Mothers provided data on family routines, maternal knowledge, and sources of support.	Examine how legal status, social support, and maternal knowledge affect family routines and functioning	Undocumented mothers had more frequent family dinners, consistent routines, and similar knowledge of children's activities compared to documented counterparts; social support linked to better family organization and maternal knowledge

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Authors	Title	Study Design	Location	Sample	Objectives	Key Findings
Axel Hernandez-Castro, Claudia M Toledo-Corral, Thomas Chavez, Rima Habre, Brendan Grubbs, Laila Al-Marayati, Deborah Lerner, Nathana Lurvey, Isabel Lagomasino, Sandrah P Eckel, Genevieve F Dunton, Shohreh F Farzan, Carrie V Breton, Theresa M Bastain	Perceived vulnerability to immigration policies among postpartum Hispanic/Latina women in the MADRES pregnancy cohort before and during the COVID-19 pandemic	Quantitative, cross-sectional survey	Los Angeles, USA	187 postpartum Hispanic/Latina women	Evaluate perceived immigration policy vulnerability (discrimination, social isolation, family threats) among postpartum Hispanic/Latina women before and during the COVID-19 pandemic	Higher perceived immigration policy vulnerability during the early COVID-19 pandemic compared to pre-pandemic; increased perceptions of discrimination, social isolation, and family threats; no significant differences in the later pandemic period
María Pineros-Leano, Nancy Jacquelyn Pérez-Flores, Katherine Damian, Natalia Piñeros-Leaño, Laura Yao, Kelli Rodrigues	Context Matters: A Qualitative Study About the Perinatal Experiences of Latina Immigrant Women	Qualitative, thematic analysis	Central Illinois, USA	30 Latina immigrant mothers living in rural and small cities in Central Illinois, all part of the WIC (Women, Infants, and Children) program.	Investigate how migration influences the perinatal experiences of Latina immigrant mothers	Context-independent themes: Cravings and body dissatisfaction. Context-dependent themes: Breastfeeding and loss of extended social ties; migration to the United States led to changes in breastfeeding behaviors and loss of familial support, impacting maternal well-being
Amy L. Non, Gabriela León-Pérez, Holly Glass, Emma Kelly, Nanibaa' A. Garrison	Stress across generations: A qualitative study of stress, coping, and caregiving among Mexican immigrant mothers	Qualitative, focus groups	Nashville, TN, USA	32 first-generation Mexican immigrant mothers	Investigate psychosocial stress exposures, coping mechanisms, and implications for the health of US-born children among Mexican immigrant mothers	Key themes include work–family tradeoff, limited freedom/mobility, reduction of social networks, and transmission of anxiety and fears to children; coping mechanisms involve the creation of new social networks and seeking support in religion and community resources. Stress exposures among immigrant mothers have significant implications for the caregiving environment and health of their children.
Jose Arreola, Lyric N. Russo, Breana R. Cervantes, Paulina Paredes, Hugo Sanchez Hernandez, Christina M. Marquez, Gloria Montiel, Francisca Leal, Nancy Guerra, Jessica L. Borelli	Más Que Palabras: More than words: Understanding the Mental Health and Behavioral Consequences of Sociodemographic Risk and Deportation Fears in Latinx Families	Quantitative, linguistic analysis	Southern California, USA	160 recent immigrant Latinx mothers and their children (ages 11-17) Predominantly from Mexico, with a few participants from El Salvador and Guatemala.	Examine how sociodemographic risk and deportation fears impact mental health and behavior in Latinx families	Deportation fears linked to higher depression in mothers and youth; sociodemographic risk moderates impact of deportation fears on mental health; higher risk decreases impact of deportation fears on depression

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Authors	Title	Study Design	Location	Sample	Objectives	Key Findings
Kara B. West, Molly E. Hale, Kathleen M. Roche, Rebecca M. B. White, Cynthia Suveg	Predictors of Latent Class Trajectories of Depressive Symptoms in Latina Mothers	Quantitative, longitudinal survey-based analysis	Southeastern USA	271 Latina mothers of early adolescents (average age 12.73 years) in a new immigrant area in the southeastern United States.	Examine culture-specific and general risk and promotive factors predicting depressive symptom trajectories in Latina mothers	Stress from anti-immigration actions, financial strain, and home–school dissonance were significant predictors of depressive symptoms, while social support was protective.
Saskia R. Vos, Christopher P. Salas-Wright, Gustavo Espinosa, Carolina Scaramutti, Tae Kyoung Lee, Maria Duque, Seth J. Schwartz	Perceived Discrimination and Posttraumatic Stress Disorder Among Venezuelan Migrants in Colombia and the United States: The Moderating Effect of Gender	Quantitative, cross-sectional survey	Florida, USA, and Bogotá, Colombia	647 Venezuelan migrant parents (62% female, average age 33) in the United States (primarily Florida) and Colombia (Bogotá).	Examine the association between perceived discrimination and PTSD outcomes among Venezuelan migrants and determine if this relationship is moderated by gender or country of relocation	Significant positive association between discrimination and PTSD; this relationship is moderated by gender, with stronger effects for women; no significant differences based on country of relocation
Alejandra Abufhele, Marigen Narea, Amanda Telias	The Covid-19 Pandemic and Maternal Mental Health: A Longitudinal Study of Chilean and Foreign-Born Mothers	Quantitative, longitudinal study	Santiago, Chile	985 mothers with children aged 24 to 30 months, residents in Santiago, Chile. 18.4% of the sample are migrant mothers (foreign-born).	Explore the effects of the pandemic on stress, depressive symptoms, and parenting practices among mothers with young children, comparing native-born and foreign-born mothers	Foreign-born mothers experienced higher levels of parental distress, difficult child interaction, and hostile-reactive parental behavior compared to native-born mothers; pandemic worsened depressive symptoms and stress across all mothers
Lígia Moreira Almeida, Cristina Costa-Santos, José Peixoto Caldas, Sónia Dias, Diogo Ayres-de-Campos	The impact of migration on women's mental health in the postpartum period	Quantitative, cross-sectional survey	Porto, Portugal	89 immigrant and 188 Portuguese native mothers. In the immigrant group, 48 women (54.0%) originated from Brazil, 23 (26.0%) from eastern European countries, and 18 (20.0%) from Portuguese-speaking African countries.	Assess the influence of immigration on the psychological health of women after childbirth	Immigrant mothers had increased risk of postpartum depression (OR = 6.444) and low satisfaction with social support (OR = 6.118); no significant differences in perceived stress and overall mental health between immigrants and natives

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Authors	Title	Study Design	Location	Sample	Objectives	Key Findings
Lucia Odette Castillo Lobos, Luis Patricio Contreras Vásquez, Elizabeth Yenny Hermosilla Aldea	Survival over the ideal of motherhood: experiences of migratory grief of migrant mothers in Chile (La supervivencia por sobre el ideal de maternidad: experiencias de duelo migratorio de las madres migrantes en Chile)	Qualitative, exploratory study	Santiago, Chile	39 migrant mothers (18 Venezuelan, 11 Peruvian, 9 Haitian) residing in Chile.	Investigate the experiences of migratory mourning among migrant mothers in Chile	Three main themes: loss of social ties and distance from the place of origin, expectations versus reality, and validation of overexertion. Migrant mothers experience migratory mourning with varying levels of intensity based on their country of origin. Feelings of sadness, loneliness, and frustration are common due to the absence of support networks and the need to prioritize material subsistence over ideal motherhood. Psychological and physical consequences of overexertion and stress compromise the mental health of both mothers and their children.
Abigail Weitzman, Katarina Huss, Matthew Blanton, Jeffrey Swindle, Gilbert Brenes Camacho, Arodys Robles	International Displacement and Family Stress in Latin America	Qualitative, in-depth interviews	Costa Rica	33 migrant mothers from Nicaragua, Venezuela, El Salvador, and Cuba, who recently relocated to Costa Rica.	The study explores how families adjust to the stressors of international displacement, focusing on the family stress adjustment process among migrant mothers in Costa Rica	Four stages of family stress adjustment identified: prioritization of safety, grappling with new circumstances, protracted uncertainty with children's divergent adaptation, and parental resolution and resettling. Strong social, emotional, and financial support networks are crucial for families to move from uncertainty to resettlement. Ongoing legal and economic uncertainties create significant stress for parents, while children tend to adapt more quickly. Families with stable support from extended kin or local institutions showed better adjustment and convergence of parent-child sentiments.

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Authors	Title	Study Design	Location	Sample	Objectives	Key Findings
Francisco Rios Casas, Daron Ryan, Georgina Perez, Serena Maurer, Anh N. Tran, Deepa Rao, India J. Ornelas	'Se vale llorar y se vale reír': It's okay to cry and it's okay to laugh: Latina Immigrants' Coping Strategies for Maintaining Mental Health in the Face of Immigration-Related Stressors	Qualitative, focus groups	Western Washington, USA	58 Latina immigrants recruited through local community-based organizations.	Describe mechanisms linking immigration-related stressors and mental health, and identify coping strategies	Latina immigrant women face numerous immigration-related stressors, including unsafe migration, fear of deportation, broken social ties, and limited access to services. Coping strategies include relying on transnational social networks, connections with other Latina immigrant women, and children as sources of support and comfort. Current social and political climate, including increased immigration enforcement and anti-immigrant discrimination, exacerbates stress and impacts mental health
Laura Itzel Ramírez Ramos, Dominga Austreberta Nazar Beutelspacher, Emma Zapata Martelo, Georgina Sánchez Ramírez, Benito Salvatierra Izaba	Women-mothers-migrants from Guatemala on the southern border of Mexico (Mujeres-madres-migrantes de Guatemala en la frontera sur de México)	Qualitative, biographical method	Southern border of Mexico, Chiapas	6 Guatemalan migrant mothers	Discuss the concept of motherhood as a gender device creating processes of disadvantage and vulnerability in the context of migration	Motherhood in the migration context is mediated, regulated, and sanctioned by institutions, leading to increased vulnerability and affecting quality of life; deep sadness from loss of social ties, material survival pressures, and psychological/physical consequences for mothers and their children
Elizabeth Sanchez, Sandy P. Philbin, Cecilia Ayón	Y el luto sigue: And the grief continues: Latinx Immigrant's Experiences of Ambiguous Loss in the Age of Restrictive Immigration Policy	Qualitative, in-depth semistructured interviews	California, USA	25 Latinx immigrant mothers (mostly undocumented or members of mixed-status families)	Examine Latinx immigrant mothers' experiences of loss associated with their immigration status and the restrictive immigration policy climate	Participants experienced loss at premigration, upon arrival, and long after settlement; feelings of ambiguous, anticipatory, and complicated loss; shared experiences of transnational loss impacted many undocumented immigrants and their family members; children vicariously experienced their parents' loss; need for psychoeducation and therapy to support immigrant communities
Alejandra Carreño, Baltica Cabieses, Alexandra Obach, Piedad Gálvez, María Eliana Correa.	Maternity and mental health of migrant Haitian women in Santiago, Chile (Maternidad y salud mental de mujeres haitianas migrantes en Santiago de Chile)	Qualitative, biographical method	Santiago, Chile	20 participants: 8 Haitian migrant parents (6 mothers, 2 fathers), 12 healthcare workers.	Understand the maternity experiences of Haitian women, focusing on factors that facilitate or hinder child healthcare in Chile.	Contradictions between health service-promoted motherhood models and Haitian practices; loneliness, loss of support networks, unwanted pregnancies, and domestic violence due to lack of access to information and services.

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Authors	Title	Study Design	Location	Sample	Objectives	Key Findings
María Olaya Grau Rengifo, Ximena de Toro Consuagra, María Elvira Cárdenas Sánchez	Meanings of respectful parenting in migrant families linked to the Chile Crece Contigo System (Significados de crianza respetuosa en familias migrantes vinculadas al Sistema Chile Crece Contigo)	Qualitative, semistructured interviews and discussion groups	Santiago, Chile	17 migrant families with children under 5 years old, using the Chile Crece Contigo (ChCC) Family Health Centers in the Metropolitan Region of Santiago.	Understand migrant families' perceptions and experiences with respectful parenting as promoted by the Chile Crece Contigo system	Migrant families perceive respectful parenting differently, often influenced by cultural beliefs and migration-related vulnerabilities; issues include tension with Chilean norms, need for support networks, and adapting to new parenting expectations
Akemi Matsumura	Motherhood at the crossroads of Peruvian migration in Aichi, Japan (Maternidad en las encrucijadas de la migración de peruanas en Aichi, Japón)	Qualitative, ethnographic	Aichi, Japan	Peruvian migrant mothers in Aichi Prefecture, Japan	Examine how Peruvian migrant mothers in Japan redefine motherhood in the context of migration	Migration challenges redefine motherhood; differences between gender roles in Peru and Japan; children serve as interpreters and emotional support; loneliness and lack of social support networks; difficulty balancing work and family; aspirations for a better quality of life and economic independence.
Ana L. Hernández Cordero	Caring is written in female: Family care networks in homes of migrant mothers (Cuidar se escribe en femenino: Redes de cuidado familiar en hogares de madres migrantes)	Qualitative, biographical method	Madrid, Spain	35 Guatemalan migrant mothers in Madrid and their families in Guatemala	Examine the strategies used by Guatemalan migrant mothers to care for their children left behind and the role of family care networks	Family care networks are crucial for migrant mothers, highlighting intergenerational solidarity; the mother's absence is compensated by other female family members; migration leads to new forms of motherhood and collective caregiving. Emotional support and material provisions, facilitated by ICTs and remittances, help sustain their familial relationships and ensure their children's well-being.
Yafza Reyes Muñoz, Karla Gambetta-Tessini, Vania Reyes Muñoz, Práxedes Muñoz Sánchez	Black motherhoods in Chile: intersectionality and health in Haitian women (Maternidades negras en Chile: interseccionalidad y salud en mujeres haitianas)	Qualitative, ethnographic	Maule, Chile	Veinte profesionales de centros de salud públicos y veinte personas haitianas (quince mujeres, de las cuales siete vivencian maternidad transnacional).	Analyze the transnational motherhood of black immigrant women, particularly Haitian women, focusing on discrimination and vulnerability in public health services	Painful and persistent burden of transnational motherhood; lack of knowledge by health professionals; patriarchal, classist, racist, and xenophobic biases; need for intersectional approach to improve health treatment.

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Authors	Title	Study Design	Location	Sample	Objectives	Key Findings
Lucía Castillo Lobos	'Raising as if we did not work and working as if we did not have children': Reflections on the labor integration of migrant mothers raising in Chile ('Criar como si no trabajáramos y trabajar como si no tuviéramos hijos': Reflexiones sobre la integración laboral de las madres migrantes que crían en Chile)	Qualitative, symbolic interactionism	Santiago, Chile	39 migrant mothers (19 Venezuelan, 11 Peruvian, 9 Haitian)	Analyze the influence of precarious labor conditions on the childrearing practices of migrant mothers in Chile	The precariousness of work and lack of social support networks significantly impact the well-being and child-rearing practices of migrant mothers. Migrant mothers in Chile face significant challenges due to precarious labor conditions, weak social support networks, and discrimination. These factors exacerbate the stress and emotional strain associated with balancing work and child-rearing responsibilities. Haitian mothers experience particularly severe discrimination and exploitation, highlighting the intersectionality of race, gender, and class in shaping their experiences.
Alejandra González-Mora, Maricelly Gómez-Vargas	Social relationships and mental health of migrant mothers, sons and daughters in Medellín, Colombia (Relaciones sociales y salud mental de madres, hijos e hijas migrantes en Medellín, Colombia)	Qualitative, constructionist	Medellín, Colombia	Participants: 20 Venezuelan migrant mothers in Medellín	Identify discursive practices on mental health from the perspective of migrant mothers in the La Iguaná neighborhood	Cultural belonging, community ties, and humor are significant coping strategies. The mental health of Venezuelan migrant mothers is deeply intertwined with their social relationships and living conditions. Positive mental health is seen in their resilience and coping mechanisms despite high vulnerability. The study challenges the pathologizing view of migrant mental health, emphasizing the need to see migrants beyond mere victims of mental health issues.
María Olaya Grau Rengifo, María Elvira Cárdenas, Nicolle Álamo, Luisa Tesch Cataldo	Emotions in the parenting process in the context of international migration (Las emociones en el proceso de crianza en contexto de migración internacional)	Qualitative, semistructured interviews and discussion groups	Santiago, Chile	17 migrant mothers from various Latin American countries	Explore and analyze the family relationships and emotions experienced by Latin American migrant mothers in the context of parenting and migratory grief	The migratory process generates various emotions, such as sadness, nostalgia, guilt, and stress, significantly impacting the parenting experience. Migrant mothers face cultural conflicts between their traditional parenting practices and those of the host country, which creates tension and adaptation challenges. Migratory grief affects mothers' emotional well-being, influencing their parenting style and interactions with their children. The lack of family support networks in the host country exacerbates feelings of loneliness and stress among migrant mothers.

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Authors	Title	Study Design	Location	Sample	Objectives	Key Findings
Lucía Castillo Lobos	Sweet and bitter: Transformations and resignifications of the precariousness of migrant mothers in Chile (De dulce y agraz: Transformaciones y resignificaciones de la precariedad de las madres migrantes en Chile)	Qualitative, symbolic interactionism	Santiago, Chile	39 migrant mothers (19 Venezuelan, 11 Peruvian, 9 Haitian)	Highlight transformations made by migrant mothers in adverse conditions, based on Nancy Fraser's empowerment theory	Resilience, empowerment, and emancipation are key themes; mothers transform difficult experiences into opportunities for autonomy; economic and cultural autonomy is achieved through resilience; experiences of discrimination and precarity are transformed into opportunities for resilience; creation of new, autonomous caregiving practices.
Magdalena Piñeyro	"We are less than people": the case of migrant women in an irregular situation, mothers of minors of Spanish nationality, on the island of Tenerife («Somos menos que personas»: el caso de las mujeres migrantes en situación irregular, madres de menores de nacionalidad española, en la isla de Tenerife)	Qualitative, in-depth interviews	Tenerife, Spain	7 migrant mothers from various countries (Brazil, Uruguay, Argentina, Colombia, Bolivia, Dominican Republic)	Analyze the experiences and vulnerabilities of migrant mothers in irregular administrative situations in Spain	Irregular status leads to severe vulnerabilities and exclusion; mothers face legal, economic, and social challenges; policies generate illegality and marginality; intersectional oppression from gender and migration status; critical need for policy changes and social support
Paulina Naudon	Migrant women in Chile: meanings about their role as mothers and raising children (Mujeres migrantes en Chile: significaciones sobre su rol de madre y la crianza de hijos)	Qualitative, symbolic interactionism	Santiago, Chile	Educators and parents from two public kindergartens in Santiago Centro and Estación Central, including 54 students (22 of foreign origin and 32 from Chilean families), two preschool educators, four assistants, two directors, two Peruvian mothers, and one Haitian father.	Explore the perceptions and constructions of motherhood and child-rearing among migrant mothers and educators in Chile	The cultural practices of migrant mothers are often viewed negatively. Mothers from Peru and Haiti are particularly scrutinized. Educators believe migrant mothers need to be 'educated' in Chilean norms. Eurocentric biases influence perceptions and integration challenges . Educators perceive Haitian parenting practices negatively and Peruvian practices positively. Cultural hierarchies and colonialist logic influence these perceptions.

Results

The review yielded 31 studies that comply with the inclusion criteria focused on the population of migrant mothers from Latin America. The studies discussed stress, vulnerability, well-being, and coping strategies in the context of migrant mothers. The studies were in Spanish and English and predominantly described migration experiences within the Americas, focusing significantly on South America. Six studies were conducted in Colombia, primarily in Bogotá (five) and Medellín (one). Chile featured most prominently, with nine studies conducted mainly in Santiago (eight studies) and one in the Maule region. In the United States, nine studies were distributed across various locations: the Greater Boston metropolitan area, Washington, DC, and Northern Virginia, Los Angeles (two studies), Central Illinois, Nashville, TN, Southern California, Southeastern USA, Western Washington, and Florida (one study overlapping with Bogotá, Colombia) one from Costa Rica, and one from the southern border of Mexico in Chiapas. In addition, five studies reported findings from Latin American mothers who migrated to Europe or Asia. Three studies were conducted in Spain (Asturias, Tenerife, and Madrid), one in Porto, Portugal, and one in Aichi, Japan.

Psychosocial and vulnerability factors

Acculturation stress: Adapting to a new culture

Stress by acculturation presents challenges in adjusting to a new culture and its manifestations, such as language barriers, different sociolinguistic codes, adapting to new cultural norms of host country while maintaining cultural identity and conforming to societal expectations of motherhood, and dissonance in cultural values. These stressors are significant difficulties that migrant mothers often face in the post-migration process. Studies in Colombia and Chile reveal that Venezuelan migrant families strive to maintain their cultural identity while integrating into new social environments while also facing cultural conflicts between traditional parenting practices and parenting expectations of host country (Grau Rengifo et al., 2022; Silva Giraldo et al., 2022). Redefining one's understanding of parenting practices to better fit the host country norms is an added pressure to everyday parental stressors, in Japan, Peruvian mothers must adjust due to differing gender roles and cultural expectations (Matsumura, 2019).

Economic and social vulnerability

Vulnerabilities related to socioeconomic status, compounded under economic challenges, precarious, often informal labor opportunities, having irregular migrant status, as well as facing high cost of living expenses and poor housing conditions, are prevalent in post-migration experiences of many migrant mothers. Examples from Chile, the United States, and Spain show migrant mothers facing economic hardships, working in low-paying jobs, and struggling to make ends meet (Berrocal, 2020; Lobos, 2023a; Vesely et al., 2015). In the United States, access to government programs is limited to certain legal statuses, documentation issues, and even anti-immigrant sentiments influence their availability. Despite qualifying for benefits, migrant mothers often miss out on benefits due to their fears of deportation and lack of information (Vesely et al., 2015). The irregular legal status of migrant mothers in Spain adds to their existing condition of vulnerability, leading to severe legal and economic challenges (Piñeyro, 2017). Similarly, in the United States and Chile, migrant mothers struggle with availability and cost of childcare, and precarious work

conditions. In Chile, they face additional stress, impacting their child-rearing practices and overall well-being (Lobos, 2023a; Piñeyro, 2017).

Social support and networks

How social support networks, or lack thereof, determine migrant mothers' post-migration experiences is a recurrent theme that connects to their well-being. Venezuelan families living in Colombia emphasize importance of building social support networks among migrant families and locals (Silva Giraldo et al., 2022). In some instances, access to social support is linked to better family organization and maternal knowledge (McConnell and Yellow Horse, 2021). Social support constitutes a protective factor against depressive symptoms in migrant mothers (West et al., 2022). For Latina immigrant mothers, ties with other Latina immigrants help alleviate social isolation and provide practical assistance (Rios Casas et al., 2020,). Families with consistent support systems are better able to cope with stressors and achieve a sense of stability despite ongoing challenges (Weitzman et al., 2023).

However, migrant families more often lack support networks, essential for implementing respectful parenting practices effectively (Grau Rengifo et al., 2022) Migration leads to a loss of extended family support, increasing feelings of isolation and making childcare and social support more challenging (Non et al., 2019) For example, migrant mothers from Haiti living in Chile experience significant loneliness and loss of support networks, crucial for raising children in their culture (Carreño et al., 2022). Loss of social ties due to migration is a source of profound sadness for migrant mothers (Lobos et al., 2023).

Parenting challenges

Migration significantly transforms authority, decision-making, and parental roles within families. Mothers often take on new roles, including authority and provision, while fathers face challenges in maintaining authority and emotional connections with their children (Aldana, 2017). Migrant families frequently rely on grandparents or other family members for childcare, leading to disputes over authority and caregiving methods. These families strive to preserve their cultural traditions and identity, particularly through food and traditional practices, while navigating integration challenges in their new environment (Silva Giraldo et al., 2020). Migration experience also impacts specific parenting behaviors, such as breastfeeding. In the United States, many migrant mothers perceive breastfeeding as less culturally accepted, resulting in decreased breastfeeding practices (Piñeros-Leano et al., 2023). Foreign-born mothers experience higher levels of parental distress, difficult child interactions, and hostile-reactive parental behavior compared to native-born mothers. The COVID-19 pandemic exacerbated depressive symptoms and stress among all mothers, highlighting the heightened vulnerability of migrant mothers (Abufhele, 2022).

Successful adjustment for migrant families often depends on stable social, emotional, and financial support from extended kin or local institutions (Weitzman et al., 2023). However, motherhood in the migration context is frequently mediated, regulated, and sanctioned by institutions, leading to increased vulnerability and adversely affecting the quality of life (Ramírez Ramos et al., 2020). Contradictions also arise between the motherhood models promoted by local health services and those practiced by migrant women, such as Haitian mothers in Chile (Carreño et al., 2022). Transnational family care networks are crucial for migrant mothers, emphasizing intergenerational solidarity. The mother's absence is often compensated by other female family members, leading to new forms of motherhood and collective caregiving (Hernández Cordero, 2016). For Haitian mothers in Chile, the burden of transnational motherhood is painful and persistent, exacerbated by the

lack of understanding from health professionals and the presence of patriarchal, classist, racist, and xenophobic biases (Reyes Muñoz et al., 2021).

In addition, the cultural practices of migrant mothers are often viewed negatively. Particularly, mothers from Peru and Haiti are scrutinized, with educators believing these mothers need to be 'educated' in local norms (Naudon, 2016). Finally, balancing work and family responsibilities is a significant source of stress for migrant mothers, as they often face long working hours, leaving their children with babysitters or alone, which adds to their stress and anxiety. Strategies to cope with these challenges include job abandonment, renouncing maternity rights, and forming global care chains to balance work and child-rearing responsibilities (Lobos, 2023a).

Mental health and well-being

Depression and anxiety are often found among the most common mental health issues affecting migrant mothers and hold a close relation to migration-related stressors. Migrants experience loss at premigration, upon arrival, and long after settlement, and these feeling often reach their children (Sanchez et al., 2021). During the early COVID-19 pandemic, elevated perceived vulnerabilities were linked to higher levels of stress, anxiety, and potential impacts on mental health and healthcare utilization among postpartum migrant mothers (Hernandez-Castro et al., 2022). At the same time, as anti-migration actions surged, higher stress responses, home-school dissonance, and financial strain predicted higher and increasing depressive symptoms, while higher social support functioned as a protective factor for migrant mothers (West et al., 2022). Intergenerational effects occur as mothers' stress and fears about deportation and economic stability are often transmitted to their children and linked to higher stress and depression, affecting their emotional well-being (Arreola et al., 2022; Non et al., 2019). Experiences of discrimination for migrant mothers have a significant positive association with PTSD (Vos et al., 2023). When it comes to parental distress, foreign-born mothers experience higher levels of complex child interaction and hostile-reactive parental behavior compared to native-born mothers, as well as significantly increased risk of postpartum depression (Abufhele, 2022; Almeida et al., 2016). The migratory process naturally generates various emotions, such as sadness, nostalgia, guilt, and stress, but those significantly impact the parenting experience of mothers. Migratory grief affects mothers' emotional well-being, influencing their parenting style and interactions with their children (Grau Rengifo et al., 2023). Migrant mothers experience deep sadness from the loss of social ties, material survival pressures, and psychological and physical consequences for themselves and their children (Ramírez Ramos et al., 2020).

Coping mechanisms and resilience

Migrant mothers employ various coping strategies to manage stress and build resilience. Examples from Costa Rica and Santiago, Chile, show us that immigrant mothers rely on transnational social networks, support from other immigrant women, and cultural values to cope with stress and adversity (McConnell and Yellow Horse, 2021; Rios Casas et al., 2020). Resilience is also demonstrated through adapting to new roles and responsibilities, maintaining strong emotional bonds, and effective communication within families (Aldana, 2017). Despite the challenges they face, migrant women find agency and pride in their caregiving roles, using them to maintain family cohesion and cultural identity (Bruhn and Oliveira, 2022). They create unique strategies to adapt to their new environment, balancing immediate financial needs with long-term goals like children's education. These women show resilience and psychological empowerment in their determination to improve their lives and those of their children (Berrocal, 2020). In the migration context, coping mechanisms employed by migrant mothers include the creation of new social networks, where they treat

friends as family and rely on each other for emotional and material support. Also, religion provides comfort and practical support, such as financial aid and emotional solace (Non et al., 2019). Mothers transform difficult experiences into opportunities for autonomy. Economic and cultural autonomy is achieved through resilience, as experiences of discrimination and precarity are transformed into opportunities for resilience, leading to the creation of new, autonomous caregiving practices (Lobos, 2023b). Finally, positive mental health in migrant women is seen as a coping mechanism despite high vulnerability, challenging the pathologizing view of migrant mental health and emphasizing the need to see migrants beyond mere victims of mental health issues (González-Mora, Gómez-Vargas, 2023).

Discussion

After completing the review, acculturation stress emerges as a significant challenge for many migrant mothers, as they must adapt to unfamiliar cultural norms and practices, often with limited guidance or support. This process can become especially burdensome when compounded by economic and social vulnerabilities, such as precarious employment, inadequate housing, or lack of access to public services, that aggravate their sense of instability. Social networks and familial ties have the potential to buffer these stresses, offering both emotional and practical support that can help individuals navigate post-migration life. However, the experience of migration frequently disrupts these existing supports and contributes to isolation or loneliness. In response, policies and interventions should not only promote stable labor opportunities for migrant mothers but also encourage community-oriented programs that strengthen social cohesion, thus providing reliable avenues for parenting support. When these resources remain inadequate, mental health and overall well-being deteriorate, underscoring the importance of early detection of psychological distress and the provision of culturally attuned mental health services.

There is evidence that effective coping mechanisms and resilience are critical tools to develop with this population, and social workers are equipped to address the intersection of these issues. Through their lived experiences in the profession, social workers have developed an approach to policy and interventions that contemplates the social context, the value of relationships, and value-driven policy-making (Miller et al., 2017). This perspective uniquely positions them to pursue culturally sensitive interventions that respect and integrate migrant mothers' cultural identities. Moreover, social workers, by virtue of their advocacy skills and community-level engagement, are well-positioned to raise public awareness about structural factors such as xenophobia and insecure labor markets, helping to spotlight the broader systemic inequities that shape migrant mothers' experiences. When social workers offer guidance, disseminate information about rights, and create spaces for community engagement, they can help mitigate acculturation stress, alleviate socioeconomic hardships, and reinforce support networks.

Conclusion

Our scoping review fills a gap in migration research focusing on the psychosocial and vulnerability factors affecting Latin American migrant mothers, particularly within south-to-south migration contexts. The findings reveal that migrant mothers face unique challenges such as acculturation stress, economic hardships, limited social support, and negative perceptions of their caregiving roles and cultural practices, which impact their mental health and overall well-being.

The review provides valuable insights into social work practice and policy, identifying culturally specific stressors and coping mechanisms. It emphasizes the importance of cultural identity, familial structures, and resilience strategies in influencing the well-being of migrant mothers. With

this knowledge, social workers and policymakers could develop culturally competent interventions and tailor support services that address the unique needs of this population, including advocating for policy changes to improve access to social services, reduce economic vulnerabilities, and enhance social support networks.

The challenges identified could potentially reflect the experiences of migrant mothers globally, especially in regions with similar socioeconomic conditions. Therefore, the insights from this review have broader implications for international social work practice and policy.

While current literature often focuses on the effects of migration on general populations or children, this review focuses on the psychosocial and vulnerability factors most closely tied to caregiving and well-being, emphasizing the mothers' perspectives and accentuating the necessity of recognizing and addressing their specific challenges. We also recognize that broader political contexts, including immigration policies and legal frameworks, can significantly shape migrant mothers' stress levels, social isolation, and access to services. Future research should integrate political dimensions to provide a more comprehensive understanding of migrant mothers' experiences, as well as explore the long-term effects of these stressors on both migrant mothers and their children and examine how policies influence access to social services.

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This project was approved by the Scientific Ethical Committee of Social Sciences, Arts and Humanities of the Pontifical Catholic University of Chile.

Statement on the use of AI

The authors have not confirmed whether any of this article was created with the assistance of generative or translational AI.

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Data availability

Data are deposited and can be accessed at https://datosinvestigacion.repositorio.uc.cl/.

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Article

Utilisation of a cultural perspective in child welfare expert assessments in Norway

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Abstract
In Norway, legislation requires consideration of a child's culture in all phases of child welfare work. Through a quantitative content analysis of 285 child welfare expert assessment reports, we explored experts' utilisation of a cultural perspective, comparing reports concerning immigrant and non-immigrant background children. We found that experts were rarely instructed to employ a cultural perspective but do so more frequently in reports concerning immigrant than non-immigrant background children. We found little evidence of critical reflection and interpreters were used rarely. The article discusses the possible explanations for and implications of a limited cultural perspective in child welfare expert assessments.

Keywords
Child welfare inequality, child welfare services, culture, expert assessment, immigrant children

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Introduction

People with an immigrant background make up approximately 20 percent of the population in Norway, comprising individuals from 223 countries (Statistics Norway, 2023). Although there is variation according to national background, as a group, children with an immigrant background are overrepresented in Norwegian child welfare services (CWS) (Statistics Norway, 2024). Both children who have themselves migrated to Norway and those born to immigrant parents are subject to higher numbers of referrals than children without an immigrant background (64 per 1000 and 52 per 1000 compared to 33 per 1000) and in 2022, 29 percent of children receiving CWS interventions had an immigrant background (Statistics Norway, 2024). While there is evidence that these discrepancies narrow when the socio-economic conditions are controlled for (Kojan et al., 2021), they persist. Disproportionate representation of minority children in CWS is not unique to Norway. Similar 'child welfare inequality' (Bywaters, 2015) is found in the United States (Maguire-Jack et al., 2020) and in the United Kingdom (Bywaters et al., 2017). Understanding how CWS responds to cultural diversity can provide a valuable addition to socio-economic understandings of these differences (Bywaters et al., 2017; Sawrikar and Katz, 2014).

In Norway, legislation allows CWS to commission independent child welfare experts (hereafter 'experts') to conduct additional assessments of children and families to inform decision making (Child Welfare Act, 2021: para. 2–2). Experts, usually psychologists (Bufdir, 2021), tend to be commissioned in particularly complex cases or where an application for a care order is considered (Greve et al., 2023). Experts are issued with a mandate from the commissioning body which details the issues their assessment should consider. Particular requests can also be made about how the work should be conducted, e.g. that the assessment should include an observation of contact (Melinder et al., 2021). Expert assessment reports are reviewed by the Commission for Child Welfare Experts before they are employed in child welfare decisions. The Commission does not approve reports but instead assigns them a category (no significant remarks, remarks or serious deficiencies) which decision makers can use to inform the way in which they use the report. In 2023, 61.5 percent of all reviewed reports received no significant remarks (Civil Law Administration, 2024). Note that experts themselves express concerns about the Commission as a quality assurance body (Nordanger et al., 2024). In practice, expert reports are highly influential in child welfare decisions (Agenda Kaupang, 2015; Augusti et al., 2017; Greve et al., 2023). Considering their influence, this article considers the extent to which experts consider culture in their assessments.

In the Norwegian child welfare field, the term 'cultural perspective' is commonly used to describe approaches that acknowledge and respond to cultural diversity (Norwegian Board of Health Supervision, 2019). A cultural perspective is relevant in assessments of children and their families because parenting norms vary between cultures (Harkness and Super, 2020; Lansford, 2022; Lin et al., 2023; Mesman et al., 2015, 2016; Ren et al., 2023). Studies have shown how failure to consider families' cultural context can compromise the quality of assessments. Keipert and Bastian (2024) have highlighted how caregiver engagement can be hindered, and others have warned that key information can be overlooked or misinterpreted (Aarset and Bredal, 2018; Laird and Tedham, 2019; Van der Weele and Fiecko, 2020a). Thus, assessment which does not address culture may be incomplete or incorrect and provide an unsound foundation for subsequent decisions about how to support children and families. The Child Welfare Act (2021), with which experts must comply, requires that consideration is given to a child's ethnic, cultural, language and religious identity in all phases of child welfare work. This reflects the UNCRC specification that a child's identity is a critical factor in respect of Article 3, which concerns child's best interests decisions (UN Committee on the Rights of the Child, 2013). Experts are also subject to specific guidelines (Bufdir, 2022) which require that they explore families' culture as part of their assessments.

However, neither the legislation nor guidelines offer direction regarding what might constitute a consideration of culture or how such a consideration should be documented.

What employing a cultural perspective entails, in practice, is much discussed (see Danso, 2018; Dean, 2001; Rugkåsa and Ylvisaker, 2021). However, for Norwegian practitioners, some direction is offered by leading authors in the field who contend that a cultural perspective requires additional time and demands high levels of critical self-reflection. Families may have a different first language and/or communication style than the expert assessing them (Aarset and Bredal, 2018; Berg et al., 2017; Fylkesnes et al., 2018). Families from some cultural backgrounds also describe mistrust of CWS (Fylkesnes et al., 2015). Accordingly, additional time for rapport building, use of qualified interpreters and additional observation may be necessary to respond to these challenges. A cultural perspective in child welfare assessment also requires critical self-reflection regarding how one's own culture, norms and values and theoretical/disciplinary positioning can shape assessment. Such reflections can help to ensure that areas of uncertainty, incomplete knowledge and alternative explanations for observed child or parent behaviour are addressed (Aarset and Bredal, 2018; Van der Weele and Karlsen, 2021).

Research indicates that such a cultural perspective is limited in child welfare assessment and decision-making in Norway. In a review of care proceedings cases concerning ethnic minority children, Aarset and Bredal (2018) concluded that there was a striking absence of reference to culture and a lack of cultural sensitivity. This is in accord with a later review of CWS cases which concluded that it was common that culture was not an important theme in the cases (Norwegian Board of Health Supervision, 2019). A 2019 study of CWS assessments of immigrant and non-immigrant children revealed that while according to some measures (number of meetings with fathers) more time was afforded to assessments of immigrant children, according to other measures (number of observations and number of conversations with children) assessments did not differ (Christiansen et al., 2019). The same study found that interpreters were used in 31.9 percent of assessments of children with an African/Asian background but only in 13.8 percent of assessments of children with a European background (Christiansen et al., 2019). A 2008 survey of CWS employees revealed an underuse of interpreters with 16 percent of municipal CWS staff reporting not using interpreters when needed and 48 percent of CWS institution staff reporting the same (IMDI, 2008). One Norwegian study explored the consideration of culture in child welfare tribunal decisions identifying such a consideration in 29 percent of all decisions and 57 percent of decisions concerning children with an immigrant background (Løvlie and Skivenes, 2021). In respect of expert work particularly, research has shown that the mandates that commissioners issue to experts rarely require them to consider culture in their assessments (Melinder et al., 2021). Insufficient consideration of a family's culture has been highlighted by the European Court of Human Rights in judgements against Norway regarding violations of Article 8 (right to respect for family life) in child welfare cases (*Jansen* v. *Norway* 2018, 2822/16; *Abdi Ibrahaim* v. *Norway* 2021, 15379/16). Norwegian child welfare practice, including expert assessment practice, has also attracted criticism regarding its handling of culture and cultural diversity in professional debate (Van der Weele and Fiecko, 2020a, 2020b) and in national and international media (for example Ali, 2019; Whewell, 2016). An account of a cultural perspective in Norwegian child welfare work is incomplete without reference to culturalisation. Culturalisation describes the tendency to understand minority children and families' situations and challenges only in terms of culture and cultural difference, to the neglect of individual, structural and institutional factors, which has been identified (Križ and Skivenes, 2010) and criticised (Rugkåsa and Ylvisaker, 2021) in research.

The current study is a part of the 'Expert Reports' research project (www.hvl.no/expert) which has been granted access to the Commission for Child Welfare Experts archive. Data from the project provide quantitative information about the assessment approaches of experts. While quantitative

measures cannot capture the complex entirety of what employment of a cultural perspective in child welfare contexts may entail, certain key elements lend themselves to such analysis and can provide valuable knowledge to the field. Drawing on guidance for experts about assessment work in a cultural perspective (Bufdir, 2022; Van der Weele and Fiecko, 2020a) we explore the time afforded to assessments, the frequency with which experts explicitly describe consideration of culture, demonstrate critical self-reflection and doubt, and consider alternative hypotheses and the frequency of the use of interpreters as measures of utilisation of a cultural perspective, comparing reports concerning children with immigrant and non-immigrant backgrounds.

Method

Sample

The sample comprised 300 expert report files from the Commission for Child Welfare Experts archive, selected by an administrative consultant employed there. The stratified sample included equal numbers of report files concerning children with an immigrant (n = 150) and a non-immigrant background (n = 150) and of older (2010–2015, n = 150) and newer (2016–2022, n = 150) report files. The latter stratification was to support the overarching project's research questions. From within these stratification criteria, files were randomly selected and uploaded to the Western Norway University of Applied Sciences secure research server where they were accessed digitally.

Measures

The reports were coded according to a quantitative codebook, developed for the Expert reports research project. The codebook comprises 125 variables, under five information domains: demographic details; content of report mandate; methods of assessment; foci of assessment; and recommendations/conclusion. Inter-rater reliability (IRR) across all variables was 83 percent. IRR was also calculated at the variable level. For a detailed account of the process of codebook development and IRR testing procedures see McGinn et al. (in press). Expert reports can include assessments of more than one child. In these cases, coding followed the assessment of a single child. Children in the report were assigned a number according to their order of appearance and one of these numbers was selected at random, by digital dice toss. All reports were coded by the first author with every 10th report double coded by one of the other authors to protect against coder drift, and secure reliability. The final sample size for coding was 285 expert reports. Two of the files sent from the Commission for Child Welfare Experts included no content. A further 14 files were excluded from the dataset because the reports they held fell outside the study focus. Reasons for exclusion were as follows: report concerned a child over 18 (n = 1); report regarded an assessment other than a child welfare expert assessment (n = 2); report was not completed by an expert (n = 1); report addressed a legal question regarding which paragraph the child should be placed under (n = 4); report concerned the question of frequency of contact (n = 6). One file contained two expert reports both of which were included for analysis, giving a final sample of N = 285.

We identified and analysed codebook variables that responded particularly to the aims of this study. From the demographic details domain, we included 'child's immigrant background' and 'use of interpreter'. From the content of the report mandate domain we included 'assessment of the child's care situation in a cultural perspective'. From the methods of assessment domain, we included 'consideration of cultural or religious context' and variables that provided a measure of

the time allocated to the assessment: 'number of conversations with the child', 'number of conversations with the caregiver(s)' and 'number of observations'. We also included variables from the recommendations/conclusion domain: 'expression of doubt, reservation or uncertainty', 'presentation of alternative hypotheses' and 'consideration of how the expert themself may have influenced the assessment'. All included variables had a level of IRR of between 74 and 100 percent.

Children were coded as having an immigrant background if they or one of their parents were not Norwegian born, which mirrors Bufdir's (n.d.) definition. Use of interpreter was coded as 'not required/required but not used/required and used/use unclear' where these were mutually exclusive. Coding of the report mandate variable 'assess the care situation in a cultural perspective' was binary 'yes/no' and coding 'yes' reflected its inclusion in the mandate issued to the expert. The 'number of conversations with the child' was coded as the total number of reported conversations between the expert and the assessed child including telephone and face to face conversations. 'Number of conversations with the caregiver(s)' encompassed six variables which each captured the number of reported conversations, telephone and face to face, between the expert and six caregiver constellations: mother and father together; mother alone; mother with partner (not father); father alone; father with partner (not mother); and any other daily caregiver, respectively. These six variables were added to give a sum score for the total number of conversations between expert and caregiver(s). Similarly, 'number of observations' encompasses three variables which capture the number of observations of child and caregiver(s): at home, in another home-setting and out of the home. These three variables were added to give a sum score for the total number of observations of child and caregiver(s). Where the number of conversations or observations conducted was unclear in the report this was coded as such. These data were excluded from statistical analyses. 'Consideration of cultural or religious context' was a binary 'yes/no' reverse coded variable, i.e. coders coded 'yes' if cultural or religious context were *'Not referred to beyond case details about the family's ethnicity, culture or religion*'. The included Recommendations/Conclusion variables were also binary 'yes/no' and coding reflected whether these themes could be identified in the report's conclusion.

Statistics

Data were exported to and analysed with IBM SPSS Statistics for Windows (version 28.0). Descriptive statistics were calculated for all variables for the whole sample and immigrant and non-immigrant background subsamples. Chi-square tests were conducted to compare the frequency with which a request to employ a cultural perspective was included in the experts' mandate, the use of interpreters and the frequency with which culture and religious context, doubt, alternative hypotheses, and expert influence were considered between immigrant and non-immigrant background samples. For binary variables, we adjusted the chi-square test statistic according to Yates' continuity correction. Independent t-tests were conducted to compare mean numbers of conversations with children, mean numbers of conversations with caregiver(s) and mean numbers of observations, between immigrant and non-immigrant background samples.

Ethics and data security

Expert reports contain sensitive information about the children and families they concern and other contributors. Approval for access to the report archive without children's or parents' consent was granted by Norwegian Council for Confidentiality and Research, and Bufdir. A Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) was approved by the privacy ombudsman of Western Norway

Table 1. Cultural perspective variables in whole sample and reports concerning immigrant and non-immigrant background children.

	Whole sample (n = 285)		Immigrant background (n = 143)		Non-immigrant background (n = 142)	
	frequency	%	frequency	%	frequency	%
Care situation in a cultural perspective (mandated)	31	10.9	30	21.0	1	.7
Interpreter not required	193	64	52	36.4	141	99.3
Interpreter required but not used	18	6	18	12.6	-	-
Interpreter required and used	49	16.3	48	33.6	1	.7
Interpreter use unclear	23	7.7	23	17.5	-	-
Consideration of cultural or religious context	82	28.8	79	55.2	3	2.1
Expression of doubt, reservation or uncertainty	108	37.9	59	41.3	49	34.5
Presentation of alternative hypotheses	54	18.9	33	23.1	21	14.8
Consideration of expert influence	45	15.8	25	17.5	20	14.1
	M	SD	M	SD	M	SD
Total number conversations (child)	.74	.90	.71	.85	.78	.94
Total number conversations (caregiver(s))	4.10	2.35	3.97	2.41	4.23	2.28
Total number observations	2.15	1.55	2.11	1.51	2.19	1.59

University of Applied Sciences in March 2021. The Norwegian Centre for Research Data (SIKT) has been notified of the project (project number 228593).

Results

Table 1 offers an overview of the descriptive statistics of all cultural perspective variables in the entire sample and in reports concerning immigrant and non-immigrant background children. Chi-square tests showed that a request to employ a cultural perspective in the assessment was found significantly more frequently in mandates of reports concerning children with an immigrant background than reports concerning children with a non-immigrant background (χ^2 (1, N = 285) = 28.18 (with Yates' continuity correction), $p < .001$). We also found use of interpreters to be significantly more frequent in reports concerning children with an immigrant background (χ^2 (3, N = 285) = 129.12, $p < .001$). Finally, we found that experts considered cultural or religious context significantly more frequently in reports concerning children with an immigrant background (χ^2 (1, N = 285) = 95.57 (with Yates' continuity correction), $p < .001$). There were no significant differences in the prevalence of expression of doubt, reservation or uncertainty; presentation of alternative hypotheses or consideration of how the expert themself may have influenced the assessment between reports concerning children with immigrant and non-immigrant backgrounds. A series of independent t-tests showed no significant differences in the mean number of conversations with children, mean number of conversations with caregiver(s) or the mean number of observations between reports concerning children with immigrant and non-immigrant backgrounds.

Discussion

The objective of this study was to explore the extent to which a cultural perspective is employed in expert assessment in Norway. We analysed the prevalence of key features of a cultural perspective, comparing reports concerning children with an immigrant background and children with a non-immigrant background. Our results showed that experts' mandates rarely included a request to employ a cultural perspective, though this was more common in reports concerning immigrant background children than non-immigrant background children. In our sample interpreters were used in about a third of reports concerning immigrant background children and on just one occasion in reports concerning non-immigrant background children. Overall, experts considered families' cultural or religious context in about one-third of assessments. Comparing subsamples showed that experts considered culture in about half of reports concerning immigrant background children and in just three reports concerning non-immigrant background children. Considering experts critical self-reflection, we found that experts identified doubts and areas of uncertainty in under 40 percent of all reports. More rarely did they present alternative hypotheses or reflect upon their own influence on the assessment. When we compared reports concerning immigrant and non-immigrant background children we found similar patterns in expression of self-reflection. We also found that experts conducted similar numbers of observations and conversations with children and caregivers.

We found that, overall, in just 10 percent of reports was a request to employ a cultural perspective included in the expert's mandate. This is a far greater proportion than the 1.5 percent reported by Melinder et al. (2021) in their study of expert assessment mandates. However, considering our finding of significant differences between the prevalence of this mandate request in reports concerning immigrant background children (21%) and non-immigrant background children (7%) the discrepancy is likely attributable to the stratified nature of our sample. The rarity with which commissioners request that experts employ a cultural perspective may in part be explained by a general lack of understanding regarding cultural differences in caregiving, and the challenges these might pose for some families, as Melinder et al. (2021) conclude. An alternative explanation may lie in misplaced confidence among commissioners that given the legal requirements to consider a child's culture (Bufdir, 2022; Child Welfare Act, 2021; UN General Assembly, 1989) it is unnecessary to specify this in the mandates they issue to experts. It is noteworthy that a UK study found that child welfare social workers highly value tools that prompt them to explore families' heritage and background (Laird and Williams, 2023).

We found interpreters were used in 34 percent of reports concerning children with an immigrant background. This is in accordance with the rates of interpreter use that Christiansen et al. (2019) found in assessments of children with an African/Asian background but much higher than the rates of interpreter use they found among assessments of children with a European background (Christiansen et al., 2019). It may be that our aggregation of children of all immigrant backgrounds conceals differences in the use of interpreters according to families' region/country of origin in expert assessment.

In our study, in 12.6 percent of reports concerning immigrant background children, experts described needing interpreters but not using them. Our results support the findings of the survey by IMDI (2008) which also identified reasons for the underuse of interpreters: overestimation of families' Norwegian proficiency, families' own preference to not use interpreters and difficulties with securing interpretation services. Van der Weele and Karlsen (2021) warn particularly about the risk of overestimating people's language proficiency, particularly children, whose understanding may be less than their expressed language might suggest. Ethnic minority parents describe high-quality interpretation as decisive to good communication with CWS practitioners and communication

without interpreters as pointless (Stang et al., 2023). Failure to use interpreters where required can mean that people are excluded from meaningfully participating in decisions, which can lead to feelings of discrimination (Buzungu, 2021; Stang et al., 2023). It can make it difficult to establish working relationships and compromise information exchange, threatening the quality of assessment (Bernard and Harris, 2019; Buzungu and Rugkåsa, 2023; Van der Weele and Karlsen, 2021). The law is clear and states that interpreters must be used in communication with all individuals with whom communication may be compromised without the use of interpreters (Interpreter Act, 2022). Interpreters were rarely used with non-immigrant background families. Interpreters also have a role to support communication between CWS and national minorities in Norway who do not speak Norwegian as a first language, as well as members of the Deaf community (Stang et al., 2023). The rights of non-immigrant children and families are also threatened if interpreters are not used when required.

We found consideration of a family's cultural or religious context in 29 percent of all reports and 55 percent of reports concerning children with an immigrant background. Our findings align with those of Løvlie and Skivenes (2021), suggesting that experts demonstrate a similar level of consideration of culture or religion to other practitioners in the child welfare field. That said, a consideration of culture or religion in just over half of reports concerning immigrant children is surprising considering the legislative and practice requirements for experts in this matter (Bufdir, 2022; Child Welfare Act, 2021). From an ecological understanding of child development (see Bronfenbrenner and Evans, 2000), which is central to Norwegian CWS work (Halvorsen and Halvorsen, 2023), this finding raises concerns. Research is clear that parenting norms, both in terms of child rearing goals and practices, vary between cultures (Harkness and Super, 2020; Lansford, 2022; Lin et al., 2023; Mesman et al., 2015, 2016; Ren et al., 2023). Failure to consider the cultural context of a child's development, behaviour, or relationship with their caregiver can result in gaps and misunderstandings in assessment of a family's functioning, which in turn may threaten the legitimacy of any subsequent child welfare decisions. The level of influence of expert assessment reports is highly relevant here.

Practitioners' failure to consider culture has been attributed to a lack of experience working with cultural diversity (Laird and Tedham, 2019; Sawrikar and Katz, 2014). This may be particularly pertinent in the Norwegian context given the small number of immigrants in the Norwegian population until recently (Statistics Norway, 2023). Others contend that failure to consider culture arises from a discourse of colour-blind universalism which disregards culture completely, and instead stresses neutrality, fairness, and equality (Eliassi, 2015; Sawrikar and Katz, 2014). It may also be that the dominance afforded to individual developmental psychology in Norwegian child welfare work, including expert work (Aarset and Bredal, 2018; Lorentzen, 2018), serves to eclipse considerations of culture and religion.

The three critical reflection variables varied in prevalence. Experts expressed doubt and uncertainty in 37.9 percent of reports while alternative hypotheses were expressed in 18.9 percent of reports. Experts considered their own influence on the assessment in 15.8 percent of reports. There was no significant difference in the prevalence of these variables between reports concerning immigrant background and non-immigrant background children. Taken together these findings can be understood to indicate low levels of critical reflection among experts, the implications of which are relevant for both immigrant and non-immigrant children. Critical (self) reflection is a cornerstone of good assessment practice as it provides some protection against the raft of biases which shape human decision making and threaten assessment quality (Backe-Hansen et al., 2023; Van der Weele and Karlsen, 2021). Where evidence is incomplete or complex, judgement is particularly vulnerable to such biases, especially those anchored in cultural norms (Munro, 2019). In light of this knowledge, one might anticipate elevated levels of critical reflection in expert work, and

particularly that concerning immigrant background children. A recent government review of the expert role noted it to be a lonely one, with experts commonly self-employed, working independently and without ready access to a network of professional colleagues (Bufdir, 2021). In the absence of peer discussion and supervision experts may lack opportunities to engage in critical reflection.

Our results showed no significant difference in the amount of time experts afford to assessments of immigrant and non-immigrant background children. This is discordant with practice guidance that extra time should be afforded to the assessment of immigrant background children and families (Bufdir, 2022; Van der Weele and Fiecko, 2020a). The rationale for this is multifaceted. Experts and assessed families may not share a first language and/or communication style (Aarset and Bredal, 2018; Berg et al., 2017; Fylkesnes et al., 2018). Families may also lack trust in children's services (Fylkesnes et al., 2015; Tembo, 2022). Accordingly time may be required for the use of interpreters, information sharing and rapport building. Limited use of interpreters in our study may provide some explanation for our findings here. Christiansen et al. (2019), who found a mixed picture when they compared different measures of time spent on CWS assessments of immigrant and non-immigrant children, noted that underlying differences between the two groups, beyond their immigration background, may be relevant for the way in which assessments are conducted. This is a valid observation where both the nature of the concern regarding the child and family composition may shape decisions about assessment approaches and should be considered in any interpretation of our findings. Furthermore, experts may afford additional time to their preparation for assessment of immigrant families which goes unrecorded in their reports.

Understood in their entirety, our findings can be understood as evidence for a limited cultural perspective in expert assessment, which is significant for both immigrant and non-immigrant children. Without a cultural perspective, intervention decisions, including care order decisions, are grounded in assessment conclusions reached on the basis of incomplete information and potentially invalid understandings of children's needs (Aarset and Bredal, 2018; Brophy et al., 2003; Laird and Williams, 2023; Van der Weele and Fiecko, 2020a, 2020b). This can be understood as child welfare inequality, the consequences of which can be fatal (Bernard and Harris, 2019). These risks apply equally to non-immigrant families. The rarity with which experts in our sample considered culture or religion in their assessments of non-immigrant children indicates an invisibility of Norwegian culture in expert assessment. The diverse cultural belongings of non-immigrant children, which include class, religion, and indigenous heritage, also influence parenting practice and children's development (Fævelen et al., 2023; Fauske et al., 2018; Nergård, 2011) and lack of attention to culture can result in the incomplete or invalid assessment of these children too. The limited extent of a cultural perspective in our sample would suggest that culturalisation is not widespread in expert assessment practice.

Strengths and limitations

To our knowledge, this is the first empirical study to explore a cultural perspective in Norwegian expert assessment. Given the influence of experts in child welfare decision-making, knowledge about how experts consider children's culture is crucial to understanding how child welfare services meet their legal obligations to children in this respect. Although the experiences of immigrant and non-immigrant background children are compared, the inclusion of children of all backgrounds in this study ensures the cultural belongings of all children are included in professional discussion.

Another strength is our quantitative approach. From our knowledge of the field much of the existing research that considers culture in Norwegian child welfare work is qualitative. Drawing on

actual case data, our study provides a valuable adjunct. Our quantification of key elements of assessment practice from a cultural perspective offers a baseline against which future research can evaluate any developments and changes in expert assessment according to these measures over time and supports replication studies in other areas of child welfare work.

However, a limitation of the study is the loss of context that results from quantifying elements of a complex concept such as cultural perspective. The measures included can in no way be understood to capture the entirety of what it is to employ a cultural perspective. The binary coding of variables means that reports that include lengthy discussions about the relevance of a family's cultural heritage are treated equally to those that include a brief paragraph on the topic. Similarly, a dichotomous division of families into immigrant and non-immigrant background does not allow for more nuanced understandings of differences in consideration of culture according to country of origin. Other limitations follow from the study's reliance on expert assessment reports to measure the extent to which they consider culture. These reports are written in response to a mandate that rarely requests that the expert employ a cultural perspective. Consequently, experts' consideration of culture may go undocumented. Moreover, experts' accounts of their work are subjective and might not reflect the experience of the children and families.

Conclusion

Expert assessments hold significant power in child welfare decision-making in Norway. How experts respond to legal requirements to consider children's culture in their assessments is critical to securing the rights of children and caregivers and ensuring appropriate interventions. This is essential for all children but is particularly relevant for those belonging to minority cultures, including children from immigrant backgrounds. Such knowledge can inform responses to the criticism lobbied at the way Norwegian child welfare responds to minority families.

We find limited evidence of a cultural perspective in expert assessments, both in terms of assessment approaches and conclusions, and this is almost absent in assessments of non-immigrant children. This study contributes to the knowledge base regarding the role of culture in child welfare decision-making and can serve as a starting point for discussions on how experts can be supported to improve this aspect of their practice. Teamwork and regular supervision to support critical reflection and a coherent procedure for the use of interpreters, as stipulated by the recent Interpreter Act, represent key areas for further development. Consideration might be given to a role for the Commission for Child Welfare Experts to monitor experts' compliance with their legal requirement to consider children's culture.

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Ethical considerations

Norwegian Council for Confidentiality and Research, in conjunction with the Norwegian Directorate for Children, Youth and Family Affairs approved access to the Commission for Child Welfare Experts report archive for the analysis and publication of the retrospectively obtained and anonymised data for this non-interventional study. A Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) was conducted in collaboration with, and the project was approved by, the Privacy Ombudsman of the Western Norway University of Applied Sciences. The Norwegian Centre for Research Data (SIKT) has been notified of the project.

Consent to participate

The Norwegian Council for Confidentiality and Research, and Bufdir waived consent for the analysis and publication of the retrospectively obtained and anonymised data for this non-interventional study.

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Data availability

Due to the nature of the research and the sensitive data in the project, supporting data are not available.

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The potential value of home visits as experienced by social workers belonging to the minoritized Arab population in Israel

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Abstract
The study joins the calls for the 'authentication' of social work interventions in 'real-life contexts', investigating the potential value of home visits as perceived by minority group social workers in Israel. Data were collected from in-depth semi-structured interviews with 15 Arab social workers employed by local authority welfare bureaus. Beyond the home visit's universal potential, the interviews revealed authentic ways to utilize the home visit's positive potential. The findings can encourage professionals in practice, policy design, and training to explore the variety of opportunities offered by home visits for service users' benefit.

Keywords
Authentication, home visit, minoritized, professionalization, real-life context, social work

Introduction

Home visits are a core component of social work. They have been described in the literature as an intervention technique, a site of intervention or a service provision strategy (Ferguson, 2018). Yet, despite their prevalent use, their potential value has received limited consideration in social work research and its literature. Saar-Heiman et al. (2018a) explain that this fundamental daily social work practice is largely taken for granted, so that in some countries, scholars have overlooked the need to describe and analyze its benefits. Muzicant and Peled (2018) found that this neglect also extends to professional training.

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Although at its inception social work reached out beyond the agencies in which it was practiced into the service users' living space, different trends and processes that the profession underwent relegated extramural activities to the margins of professional discourse and practice (Mahajne, 2023). Hegemonic neoliberalism and modern management dictate formalization, documentation, and supervision that increasingly necessitate the maintenance of in-office social work practice (Murphy et al., 2013). Thus, today, in some countries like Israel, social workers' main service provision space is within their agency (Krumer-Nevo, 2022). This trend can partially explain the fact that the sparse literature on social work home visits in different countries is mostly outdated. Contrastingly, for example, in the United Kingdom, most social work is conducted during home visits (for a comprehensive review see Eyal-Lubling and Krumer-Nevo, 2016).

Currently, there is a reawakening and revival of the tradition of home visits in social work (Marlow, 2023). Following calls for authentication, social workers have been encouraged to return to intervene 'in real-life contexts' such as the welfare users' natural life spaces, including their homes (Saar-Heiman et al., 2018b). Authentication necessitates the development of social work training and interventions that are appropriate for different local lifestyles in multicultural societies (Carleen Paul, 2007; Wong, 2014). The process has been conceptualized in innumerable ways, using terms such as indigenization, cultural competence, ethnic sensitivity, cultural awareness, cultural safety, and context-informed perspective (for a comprehensive review see Elias and Even-Zahav, 2022: 36–37).

Many previous publications cover a single visit guided and structured according to a protocol using standard checklists for target population, goals, and the procedure before, during, and after the visit (Harel, 2009; Levi and Karniel, 2011), and expressing concern for the worker's safety (Lyter and Abbott, 2007). Some of this literature also reduces the role of the 'authoritarian' social worker to collection and verification of information, supervision, or assessment of the service users (Murphy et al., 2013), and broadens the role to para-professional personnel and volunteers who are expected to guide, support, advise, accompany, and assist during a series of visits (Zakai, 2019).

The study described herein joins the calls for authentication of interventions (Mahajne and Bar on, 2023) 'in real-life contexts' in the form of home visits (Eyal-Lubling and Krumer-Nevo, 2016; Saar-Heiman et al., 2018a, 2018b) alongside the agency's other activities (Reamer, 2018; Winter and Cree, 2016). It partially fills the literary vacuum concerning description and explanation of the realization of the home visits' potential as experienced by minoritized social workers in Israel.

Following a short description of the research context, a literature review discusses different types of extramural interventions and the added value of service provision in a real-life context. The home visit is explained as seen by Arab tradition and the Sharia. The next section explains the study's methodology followed by a description of the four themes that emerged from the interviews.

Research context: Arab minority population social workers in Israel

The Palestinian–Arab population in Israel constitutes an indigenous national-ethnic minority, numbering approximately 1.6 million citizens or 21 percent of the country's population. The overwhelming majority of this minority (92%) lives in Arab localities, with the remainder residing in mixed Jewish–Arab cities. Palestinian–Arabs differ from the Jewish majority in their religions (83% Muslims, 9.2% Druze, and 7.8% Christians) and language (Arabic not Hebrew) (Central Bureau of Statistics, 2024) and culture. They also differ in their culture that is mainly a semi-traditional (presently undergoing an accelerated transformation and fluctuating between traditionalism and modernity) as distinguished from the Jewish population's mainly modern culture (Mahajne, 2020).

Since the state's inception in 1948, grossly deficient government investment in the country's Arab society, in contrast to investments in Jewish society, has hindered its development (Allassad Alhuzail and Mahajne, 2021). This society's social work development has also been delayed due to insufficient budgeting for the infrastructure and maintenance of Arab welfare bureaus that serve severely disadvantaged populations as most Arab communities (95%) fall in the lowest socio-economic strata (1–2 out of 10). Only 41.1 percent of Arab women and 71.6 percent of men aged 24–64 years are employed, and 45.3 percent of Arab families and 57.8 percent of Arab children live below the poverty line (Mahajne, 2024a). However, budgets for Arab welfare services are significantly lower per service user than those for Jewish welfare services (NIS6, 360 and NIS10, 898 respectively) (Gal and Tarabeih, 2024).

Uniform and culturally inappropriate social work training programs and government-sponsored interventions mostly omit consideration for the Arabs' mother tongue, cultural heritage, and narrative (Mahajne and Meler, 2022) and fail to consider appropriate adaptation to the minority's three religions (Mahajne and Bar on, 2023). National welfare reforms over the years have done little to change this situation (Mahajne, 2024b).

Types of extramural interventions

There are three types of interventions that social workers can employ to meet their service users' needs outside the agency. The first involves reaching out to form initial connections with people who do not apply on their own initiative for assistance, aiming to bring them to the agency where the intervention can take place. Reaching out to populations such as alienated youth, men, or women engaged in prostitution, or the homeless may take place in public places such as the street, public buildings, clubs, or parks. Encounters in these spaces usually serve as an initial stage in forming contact, although some approaches see these spaces as the place for the intervention itself (Lavie-Ajayi and Krumer-Nevo, 2013).

The second type is the in-home intervention that developed from family therapy approaches. This intervention is usually applied in the context of a unique program for a family considered 'hard to reach', that is, the family has not cooperated with 'traditional' intervention methods. Such programs are especially prevalent in health services (physical, mental, and cognitive) and child welfare services (Waisbrod et al., 2012; Zakai, 2019).

The third, and most prevalent, type of extramural interventions is the one-time home visit in which a social worker arrives at the service user's home to fulfill narrow, focused goals. This intervention enables evaluation, supervision, and follow-up, but does not envisage the visit as an integral part of a change process. In these cases, the goal is not only just therapeutic but more generally to meet people's unmet needs (Winter and Cree, 2016). In contrast, the study reported herein adopts an approach that regards this type of home visit as a continuous intervention process, based on the particular characteristics of the service users' specific home environment.

The added value of the home visit as an intervention in real-life contexts

Carleen Paul (2007) emphasized that 'a home visit, if not conducted correctly and with good intentions, can actually cause more harm than good' (p. 4). Therefore, she suggested, putting on 'strengths glasses' that would allow the social worker to 'see the glass as half full'; to visit the real-life context frequently; and to treat service users according to their codes. She envisaged that this strategy would ensure that home visits would become empowering experiences for service users rather than causing harm.

Extensive literature indicates four general contributions of the home visit for the service user: (1) it facilitates service provision for people who are difficult to reach (Lavie-Ajayi and Krumer-Nevo, 2013); (2) it enables direct acquaintance with the social worker outside the formal office structure that might be a block to the intervention (Ferguson, 2018); (3) it allows the social worker to provide immediate assistance and support in emergencies or acute crises (Eyal-Lubling and Krumer-Nevo, 2016; Harel, 2009); and (4) it offers an opportunity for intervention in a safe, natural environment in which the service user can feel more control, thus increasing the power he or she experiences in relations with social workers (Khodari, 2018).

Home visits create a substantially opposite situation from that created in agency service provision settings since they are replete with the service user's chaotic life circumstances. The service user's natural location reduces the distance between what is internal and external and between the professional and the service recipient (Reamer, 2018). Thus, intervention in real-life contexts enables the creation of more effective relations that can mobilize change in both the user's internal and external life realities (Zakai, 2019).

The home visit process relies on two assumptions. The first assumption is that it creates visibility, which is a significant component of any intervention. Visibility is significant against a background of the strong social invisibility that most service users endure: that invisibility of their daily struggle to overcome oppression and the difficulties they suffer. Intervention in the real-life context is a practice that opposes this invisibility (Krumer-Nevo, 2022).

The second assumption is that reaching out from the agency when it is appropriate and adapted to the users' needs enables the real-life context to become the optimal environment for professional intervention. This assumption stems from the qualitative research belief that phenomena can best be understood in the context where they occur (Saar-Heiman et al., 2018a). Interventions in real-life contexts are not performed in an artificial space such as an office, but within the natural life environment (Eyal-Lubling and Krumer-Nevo, 2016). The different arenas of these spaces alter according to the target population, meaning that the intervention is not enclosed within a single, fixed space, such as an office, but is dynamic, moving between various components encountered during a home visit (Saar-Heiman et al., 2018b).

Home visits in Arab culture and the Sharia

According to Arab traditions, strangers have the canonical right to be hosted in any home for 3 days without being asked for the reason for their visit. The host is obliged to welcome and respect the visitor. On crossing the home's threshold, the host is motivated to forgive the visitors for any sins they may have committed against the host, and even protect the visitor from any external threat. Arab culture is full of proverbs, wise sayings, and anecdotes concerning the virtues of strangers visiting a home (Khodari, 2018).

Sharia laws adopted Arab traditions and consider home visits as having supreme religious importance. They encourage Muslims to visit each other in all circles of affinity, from the extended family (as an obligation) to visits by strangers, especially those in acute or chronic distress (bereavement, sickness, disasters) in order to be entitled to desired rewards in this life and the next. Islam determines rules of etiquette relating to the altruistic intention of the visit, and the frequency, timing, and ending of the hospitality, from receiving permission to enter the home (Kurd, 2017).

Research describing the intervention patterns of civil society organizations for distressed Arab families found that the consideration of boundaries, privacy, and secrets was tolerant and flexible because of the following three factors, in order of importance. First, the Arab tribal and clan structure usually leads hundreds to thousands of people belonging to the same extended family to live in the same geographic area. In Israel, this means living in overcrowded housing due to policies

that hinder building planning permission in Arab localities (Mahajne, 2024a). Second, Arab society is essentially collectivist, sacrificing the different expressions of individualism (Mahajne, 2020). Third, implications of the Nakba (catastrophe) that befell the Palestinian citizens in Israel with the establishment of the state, is passed down through the generations, reinforcing a sense of a common destiny (Allassad Alhuzail and Mahajne, 2021).

Zakai (2019: 42) found that 'professional boundaries are a "Western"' concept that is less familiar in traditional societies. Thus, for example:

> despite professional recommendations to avoid responding to invitations to a meal during a home visit, it is worthwhile considering [the practices of] certain cultures, such as Arab culture, where to refuse a meal would offend the host, and be considered rude and alienating.

Professional authentication that gives due consideration to Arab tradition can support interventions within the service users' real-life context. It is therefore interesting to examine the professional potential offered by home visits in this context. The fact that roughly 60 percent of all Arab social workers in Israel are employed in local authority welfare bureaus (Mahajne, 2024a) constituted a central consideration for the selection of welfare bureau social workers as best placed to address the studied issues.

Methodology

Purpose and approach

The research enabled the researchers to describe and explain minority social workers' perceptions of the potential contribution of home visits to their interventions in assisting service users.

Qualitative-constructivist methodology (Lincoln and Guba, 2016) was employed, enabling the interviewees' descriptions to be elicited according to their original meaning while considering the structural and social circumstances of the studied issue (Appleton and King, 1997).

Method

Research participants were selected in a purposive sample (Etikan et al., 2016) from the Forum of Arab Welfare Departments list that details all Arab welfare departments, their contact details, geographical location, and the statistical distribution of different religions in their locations (Muslims, Christians and Druze). Between March and April 2024, all 74 listed departments (excluding East Jerusalem and Golan Heights departments where service users are not Israeli citizens) were asked to post the call for participants on the bureau's internal email, WhatsApp lists, or bulletin board. Potential interviewees who according to the social workers' own assessment had conducted valuable home visits as part of their intervention process with service users were invited to contact the researchers directly by phone or email without knowledge or mediation of their managers.

Participants

In all, 15 social workers consented to participate and were interviewed: 12 women and 3 men. Nine held bachelor's degrees and six master's degrees. Their ages ranged from 25 to 44 years, and their years of professional experience ranged from 2 to 20 years. The sample reflected the geographical distribution of Arab localities throughout Israel (nine from the north, two from the Triangle region, two from the central region, and two from the south) and the different religions (11 Muslim, two Christian, and two Druze).

Generating data

Data were elicited from a two-part semi-structured in-depth interview (Lincoln et al., 2011). Part 1 collected interviewees' personal and professional characteristics: gender, age, region, religion, education, years of experience, and role in the welfare bureau; Part 2 consisted of a key questions that were composed after reviewing the relevant literature, such as: (1) 'Please describe home visits to service users that you conducted that you assessed as having realized their potential?' and (2) 'What did these visits contribute to the intervention plan beyond your activity with the service user, if at all, within the welfare bureau?'

Interviews were conducted in Arabic (the mother tongue of the researchers and the participants) between April and June 2024, and lasted between 30 and 40 minutes. The participants chose the location: about 60 percent at their home through Zoom and the remainder in their offices. All interviews were audio-recorded with the participants' consent, entirely transcribed by the researchers, and later translated into English by a professional translator. In the e-interviews, participants confirmed their informed consent orally, while those interviewed in offices signed a consent form. The interview testimony reached saturation point when there was substantial repetition (Dushnik, 2011). Participants did not receive any incentive for their participation. Responses appeared to be expressed openly and sincerely after a detailed explanation of efforts to protect their anonymity, such as changing some of the details of cases that might disclose their identity. The interviewees noted that the interviews were an opportunity to voice their experiences concerning the realization of the potential of home visits.

Data analysis

Thematic analysis of the transcripts was conducted in three stages suggested by Strauss and Corbin (2015). The main researchers initially read the interviews several times to deepen acquaintance with the texts. In this stage, words that implied or indicated answers to the research questions were marked, such as positive results, satisfaction, advantages, possibilities, benefits, and opportunities offered by the home visit for the interventions. In the second stage, significant phrases were identified and sorted according to units of meaning (Strauss and Corbin, 2015). Later, the texts were reread, checking what was said before and after the words marked in the first stage to identify the main issues. Finally, similar statements were grouped to create the themes that provided the conceptual outline of the study (Creswell, 1998). Special attention was paid to contrasts or arguments where an interviewee argued with her/himself about a certain topic or topics that were frequently repeated, or a change in language used during the interview. The interviewees' testimonies were found to be consistent.

Trustworthiness of the research

Two tools fortified the data's trustworthiness: (1) member checking with interviewees to ensure their testimony had been correctly understood. Where necessary the researchers clarified their explanations and reflections by repeating the interviewees' words in the researchers' own words (Lincoln and Guba, 1985); and (2) as an ethical, respectful step, and to avoid the risk of bias, the findings chapter was sent to four interviewees representing different genders, ethnicities, education levels, and regions to affirm that they presented their authentic voices. All four interviewees confirmed the findings without reservation.

Ethical considerations

The Ethics Committee of the academic institution where the first author is employed approved the research and interviewees were informed about the research goals, and told that they could choose what to answer and could stop the interview at any point.

Findings

Due to constrictions of length, it should be noted that the citations in the following section represent the dominant voices expressed by the interviewees. The text presents the social workers' input with as little interference as possible by the authors' whose interpretations are presented in the discussion chapter.

As an introduction, the first voices focus on the four main benefits of home visits for service users in comparison with their visits to the welfare bureaus.

First, *home visits improve the service users' access to the service*:

> A home visit saves the elderly or infirm from having to cope with mobility limitations due to the lack of accessible public transport, and allows access to service for those who would otherwise have to find carers for bedridden dependents while visiting the office.

Second, *service users' homes provide venues for deep private conversations*:

> [At home] they can experience privacy, even when there is sometimes a noisy television or the presence of children, neighbors or other family members who arrive uninvited. Home visits were experienced by [battered] women as permitting privacy that was impossible at the office. The women's complaints about the conditions in the office are justified. I began work with my colleague in an office separated by a thin plaster wall from the waiting room. During the conversations, most women whispered, fearing they would be heard, telephones rang, and all sorts of people knocked on the door.

Third, *the home invites the social workers to adopt a new attitude toward the service users*, because it creates a change of the familiar positioning in the helper–helped relations:

> The home forces me to see the inaccessibility of the apartment with my own eyes and the real lack of basic equipment for those with special needs. It also exposes me to their efforts to cope with deficiencies. I can see their heroism and not just the difficulties.

Fourth, *the service users are freed from the need for an escort*:

> As an intaker, I noticed that it is not pleasant to leave the person accompanying service users outside in the waiting room. The escort's presence interferes in the intervention. In the home sphere, the applicants are freed from this burden of these companions.

Data concerning the potential embodied in the home visit were collated in four themes that are presented according to the frequency of mentions by the participants:

1. Successful mobilization of service users by confronting oppressive community and establishment agents

Five voices related to this theme. Some home visits were initiated by the service users, sometimes at short notice, to represent them before community and establishment agents. Two representative anecdotes were:

A home visit to neutralize the influence of the Committee for Reconciliation and Mediation – a patriarchal community agent

I was suddenly called to a home to meet the local Committee for Reconciliation and Mediation. I arrived late. They pleaded with my client to give her violent husband another chance. They imposed the responsibility for domestic peace on her, for the sake of her daughters. Her facial expressions called for help. I confronted the committee members by demanding that they respect her rights as the victim of a violent husband who did not work to improve himself. In the end, we conditioned the conciliation on the husband signing a commitment to give [custody of] the daughters to his wife if he hit her again. The committee members said I had exaggerated. I insisted, and we overcame the patriarchal committee.

Confrontation with an Employment Office placement worker as an arm of the establishment

In a meeting with an Orthodox Jewish regional placement worker in the home of a woman receiving income maintenance who was defined as 'refusing work', I explained that he was ignorant of local culture. He claimed that she knew Hebrew and refused to be persuaded that she was forbidden to work in a bar for religious reasons, especially during the afternoon when there was no public transport to take her home after work. At the end of the meeting, I hinted that I was going to appeal against his decision to the regional office. He understood that this was a [justified] complaint and rescinded his insistence.

2. The interviewees visited homes to offer help to particular potential service users

The second theme, highlighting discrimination and barriers faced by minoritized populations when applying for services, was heard from five participants. Because of their professional and ethical commitment, social workers reached out to people who had not previously turned to the welfare bureau for religious reasons (in mixed religion Arab localities), due to their social or academic status, sexual preferences and so on. Two exemplary anecdotes were:

Religious reasons

An imam (Islamic leader) asked me, one day in a shop, whether the welfare bureau subsidizes transport for dialysis. An imam's minimal salary is public knowledge, so I decided to visit his home where I was exposed to the economic, emotional and social distress of all his family members following the recent illness of the mother. As a family social worker, I opened a file for the family and collected donations for them. The imam told me that he would not come to the bureau. He reminded me of the Koran's Surah Al-Baqara, a verse relating to the pride of the impoverished: 'Those unfamiliar with their situation will think they do not need charity, because they do not beg people persistently'.

National security background

A Christian social worker in a town with mixed religions shared a story concerning a Druze teenager, aged 16 years:

As a Pan-Arabist he ensured shelter and meals after the Ramadan fast days for Palestinian (Muslim) workers without permits to stay in Israel. When his arrest on suspicion of aiding the enemy was published on Facebook, I phoned him and offered to help him. He investigated my connections with the police and hung up. After that he refused to answer my calls. I initiated home visits to offer help. At first, he was sure

that the welfare bureau was an establishment institute and collaborated with the police. My frequent home visits convinced him that I was truly on his side and insisted on helping him. We traced his file and transferred it from the probation officer who was a [Jewish] settler, who apparently didn't support him. Eventually, the court appointed me to be responsible for him in the community.

3. Home visits as the solution for conflicts and disputes

Home visits can facilitate the delivery of an apology following failure or to settle issues appearing in a complaint to superiors in order to help the sides reach a compromise in a dispute concerning an intervention for service users.

Apology following failure

I told a woman that there was an old report about a suspicion that her husband might be retarded. I thought this information could be useful since it was advisable to claim a disability pension instead of income maintenance, which is often temporary. I understood that I had breached his confidentiality. Since then, he stopped the intervention. I initiated a home visit to admit my failure, to apologize, and to explain my motives to the husband. This was my first visit. He rightly interpreted that I am *lafia aleeh*. i.e., that I entered the gate of his house with a request. The visit symbolized a change in the balance of power in his favor. He accepted my apology.

Settling issues involved in a complaint

I supported the position of a teenager whose parents managed her life very strictly. The parents complained to my superior that I incited their daughter to rebel against them. They stopped their daughter's intervention, and even refused to answer my phone calls. I chose to visit them to explain my professional viewpoint concerning the severe education that was leading to paradoxical results. The father asked me in surprise 'How is it that your name is Georgette [a Christian name], but you are a Muslim with a hijab? You are one of us'. I was helped by the [Arab] custom of coffee drinking on a request from the hosts, and asked the parents to come to the office for conversations concerning the girl. The father told my superior that we had settled the matter and opened a new page.

Compromise in a dispute concerning an intervention

I had a dispute with a released prisoner who was accepted to work in a workplace owned by a criminal family that operated a money laundering operation. He didn't believe that a normative workplace would accept him because of his criminal background. He and his wife stubbornly maintained this position. As a last step, I initiated a home visit with the couple's families. I really couldn't invite everyone to the office. His wife's family suggested he should look for work with rehabilitated criminals. My client's family suggested a compromise: until he found new work, I would visit the workplace without coordinating the visit to find out what was going on there. That was a great compromise.

4. Home visit to bring in additional support for service users

Some home visits were conducted together with an external entity to bring in additional support for service users. Here are three examples.

Home visit with a rehabilitated drug addict and his wife as models for imitation

A newly rehabilitated drug addict left the office while slamming the door and threatened to return to drug abuse, claiming that I had supported his wife's suspicions against him. I initiated a home visit together with

a 'supporter' [a rehabilitated drug addict] and his wife who I specially invited to advise the couple. Most of the meeting was devoted to convincing the user that he needed to be able to trust others to continue the length of his rehabilitation period . . . the supporter couple contributed to the continuation of the rehabilitation period.

A visit for reconciliation with a key figure in a community project

One of the key figures in a project to integrate Palestinians who had in the past been collaborators [with the Israeli security forces] into the local community, wanted to bring back to the project his right-hand man [deputy]. The deputy felt slighted because he had not been delegated enough powers. So, we paid him a visit together. This marathon meeting enabled ventilation and redistribution of their roles. The deputy felt honored that we visited him, pleased that his status was reinforced, and devoted himself to completing the project.

A visit with a religious cleric to open up sensitive issues

I enlisted a mufti (religious judge) for a home visit to explain to an elderly man's wife that he had a marital right to sexual relations. As a man, I was embarrassed to talk about this subject with her. The mufti quoted verses from the Koran – *Ahadeeth* (the Prophet's words) and traditional Islamic stories. The visit was in the winter. Towards our departure, the wife asked her husband with a shy smile to repair the boiler (so she could purify herself from *aljanabah* after sexual relations).

Discussion

The research described above investigated the extension of the boundaries of the authentication process in social work to interventions in the service user's home. It was found that the home, as part of a real-life context, added value that is missing in the welfare bureau's offices (Eyal-Lubling and Krumer-Nevo, 2016; Saar-Heiman et al., 2018a, 2018b). The interviewees clarified that service provided in the home, the service user's castle, or 'comfort zone' (Carleen Paul, 2007), can benefit service users in general, and especially peripheral populations (Krumer-Nevo, 2022) in heterogeneous societies, like minoritized communities. The Palestinian population in Israel can represent other minoritized populations. Estimates suggest that 20 percent of the world's population are members of minorities (United Nations, 2018), who are usually the most disadvantaged and vulnerable groups in society, enduring discrimination, injustice, and exclusion, and requiring special care to protect their rights (United Nations Refugee Agency, 2022). This means that using real-life contexts during interventions is a critical strategy to benefit them.

The anecdotes presented above illustrate the importance of understanding the special context in which social workers work (Lavie-Ajayi and Krumer-Nevo, 2013; Wong, 2014). A context-informed perspective involves recognizing the potential embodied in-home visits described in the four emergent themes (Elias and Even-Zahav, 2022). This includes, for example, recognition of Arab traditions and the Sharia that open the door to welcome strangers (Khodari, 2018; Kurd, 2017). In socio-cultural circumstances such as these, in the home, boundaries and secrecy become more flexible compared with the traditional social work boundaries discussed in the international literature.

The interviewees spoke extensively about the advantages of the home for service users. Some voiced universal aspects mentioned in the literature (Ferguson, 2018; Muzicant and Peled, 2018; Waisbrod et al., 2012) that focused on three main benefits of home visits compared with visits to the welfare bureaus: improved accessibility of the service; suitability for deep, private conversations; and inviting social workers to adopt new attitudes toward the service users. We decided not

to group these universal benefits into a theme but to present them as an introduction to our other findings.

The following four themes were found, arranged according to their frequency of their being mentioned: reaching out to form new relations with potential service users; renewing disrupted professional – service user relationships; improving relations; and representing users against oppressive agents. These themes were new. The added value of home visits for any of these purposes addresses a single criterion: they provide a beneficial contribution to the intervention for the user. The themes illuminate the real potential of home visits within the unique political, socio-economic, and religious context of the minoritized Arab population in Israel as perceived by social workers who are well acquainted with the service users' needs and know the appropriate responses.

The findings challenge the four reasons that pushed social work to be agency-based. In all the cited cases, the social worker's presence complied with the requirements of a professional relationship (Harel, 2009), therapeutic conversations about failure, complaints and disputes (Lyter and Abbott, 2007), standing by the users to support them against oppressive agents (Mahajne, 2023), and not endangering the practitioners (Murphy et al., 2013).

These findings can encourage social workers to reconsider how they can further exploit the potential of home visits for the service users' benefit (Marlow, 2023). For welfare bureau social workers to implement this intervention practice in real-life contexts, the professional training institutions need to educate social workers appropriately, and national and local policymakers need to promote home visits. Realizing the potential of home visits also depends on resources of time, appropriate support, and regular mentorship.

The study's contribution, limitations, and recommendations for future research

This study partially fills an academic lacuna concerning minoritized social workers' realization of the home visit's potential. The findings should stimulate further exploration of different professional uses of home visits for particular groups in heterogeneous societies. A limitation of the study is that the sample was small and related solely to public sector social workers, so future research should include social workers from the private and voluntary sectors. Also, it would be informative to investigate home visits' potential in social workers' interventions from the service users' viewpoints.

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Conceptualizing anti-Asian bullying faced by East Asian adolescents in Canadian schools arising from the COVID-19 pandemic: The roles of social workers

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Abstract
East Asian adolescents have been facing increasing bullying in schools as a result of anti-Asian racism emerging from the COVID-19 pandemic. In this article, we adopt Canadian multiculturalism, scapegoat theory and dominance theory to understand this social issue in the macro-Canadian social context, mezzo intergroup interactions and micro-individual adolescents' experience. A conceptual model that integrates these three levels of theories and the roles of social workers on these levels is also presented. This conceptualization aims to help social work researchers and practitioners better understand bullying faced by East Asian adolescents in schools and to protect them amid anti-Asian racism.

Keywords
Anti-Asian racism, bullying, Canada, COVID-19 pandemic, East Asian adolescents, social workers

Introduction

Racism has been a systemic issue in Canada and can significantly impact the well-being and integration of racialized communities (McElhinny, 2016; Thobani, 2007). Particularly, anti-Asian racism that re-emerged from the COVID-19 pandemic has resulted in unprecedented effects on East Asian communities in Canada (Zhang et al., 2024). Individuals of East Asian descent or originally from East Asian countries such as China, Korea and Japan were regarded as 'virus carriers and

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spreaders' during the pandemic (Zhao et al., 2022). Numerous reports have documented rampant verbal and physical attacks targeting East Asian communities in Canada (e.g. Chau, 2021; Premji, 2023). Vancouver Police Department also disclosed that anti-Asian racism incidents in 2020 increased by over 800 percent (Kotyk, 2020). Discriminatory remarks such as 'China virus' from politicians further exacerbated anti-Asian racism experienced by East Asian communities in Canadian society (Larsson, 2020). With this large-scale and unprecedented influence, anti-Asian racism can be seen as a collective trauma faced by East Asian communities in Canada (Wu, 2022). In addition, East Asian adolescents face anti-Asian racism and experienced bullying, including racial slurs, name calling or even physical attack (*CBC Kids News*, 2021; Wong, 2022). As adolescence is an important stage of identity development, race-based bullying may have detrimental consequences on their sense of belonging and identity building in the long term (Chen et al., 2021). It may also put victimized adolescents at heightened risks for poor mental health, lower academic achievement and increased risk of delinquency (see Sapouna et al., 2023 for a review). For example, Huynh et al. (2023) found that Asian adolescents' mental health was affected by anti-Asian racism incidents during the COVID-19 pandemic, as some participants reported feeling less safe and experiencing depression. East Asian adolescents also experienced identity issues amid anti-Asian racism such as self-doubt and fear (*CBC Kids News*, 2020; Chen et al., 2021). These potential consequences show how severe anti-Asian racism in schools can be and underscore the urgent need to address this social issue.

Despite the fact that anti-Asian racism faced by East Asian adolescents is a serious concern for East Asian parents and schools (Liu et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2023), empirical research on the Canadian context is still limited, as most of the studies were conducted in the American context. Cheah et al. (2020) found that 76.5 percent of Chinese American youth (between 10 and 18 years old) experienced racist incidents related to COVID-19 either in-person or online. In terms of parents' perspectives, Wang et al. (2023) found that in their interviews, out of 40 Chinese American parents, 12 reported direct bullying associated with the COVID-19 pandemic experienced by their children, and 28 worried about race-based bullying faced by their children in schools. Some parents also pointed out how vulnerable adolescents can be when transitioning to secondary schools, as they started to be more aware of racial differences and were likely impacted by race-based discrimination and bullying (Liu et al., 2024). Compared with the literature on anti-Asian bullying in the American context, research in the Canadian context, especially on how schools should understand anti-Asian bullying, has been lacking. Available studies indicated that Asian youth in Canada already experienced forms of anti-Asian racism in their elementary years before the pandemic (Fang et al., 2024). The prevalence of such racism also increased during the COVID-19 pandemic, particularly in its earlier stages (Fang et al., 2024; Wong, 2022). Building onto this limited body of work is important for informing school policies and improving school environment to better address anti-Asian bullying in the Canadian context.

To guide future research, we propose a theoretical framework by first adopting Canadian multiculturalism as a macro-contextual lens to uncover how anti-Asian racism, embedded in Canadian society, has been hidden under the policy of multiculturalism. We then use scapegoat theory as a mezzo-level theory to understand how anti-Asian racism escalated during the COVID-19 pandemic, as COVID-19 has been used to stigmatize East Asian communities. Building upon these contextual theories, dominance theory is utilized as a micro-individual level theory to understand how anti-Asian racism has permeated schools and is expressed through bullying targeting East Asian adolescents. In the meantime, how social workers can participate at each level and promote the well-being of East Asian adolescents is not widely discussed either. We thus consider the roles of social workers on the macro, mezzo and micro levels in supporting future prevention and interventions that aim to reduce anti-Asian bullying in the long term. Through this theoretical analysis,

schools can also better understand the formation of anti-Asian bullying and further design policies to address such bullying.

Canadian multiculturalism and hidden racism

Canadian multiculturalism was officially incorporated into Canadian legislation in 1988 to ensure that racialized individuals and communities in Canada can practise their own cultures without discrimination and prejudice (Lee and Johnstone, 2021; McElhinny, 2016). It was a step forward compared with Canada's racist immigration policies over half a century ago that only allowed Caucasian immigrants from Europe to enter the country (Chakraborty, 2022). However, Canadian multiculturalism has been considered as a convert form of settler colonialism and racism (Thobani, 2007). Specifically, it was the white English and French settlers who ultimately designed and implemented the multiculturalism policy (Lei and Guo, 2022), as a response to the independence movements worldwide and the shortage of the labour force in Canada (Kenyeres, 2015; Thobani, 2007). Therefore, this reform in Canada's cultural policy does not seem willing, but rather a forced reaction to the dramatic global transformation in that historical context. The settler colonialism is often perceived as crafty, as the corresponding policy not only helps Canada preserve its 'whiteness' without damaging its relations with those newly independent countries (also former British and French colonies), but also profits from human capital and economic benefits exported from those countries through immigration (McElhinny, 2016; Zhao et al., 2022). Under these circumstances, a multicultural hierarchy that features the 'top' position of white Canadian cultures is formed (Fleras, 2014). When immigrants and migrants from non-Western countries settled in Canada, they were automatically incorporated into this hierarchical multiculturalism (Fleras, 2019). For example, although immigrants and migrants to the country can maintain and practise their cultures, white English and French cultures are still recognized as a standard to evaluate their integration in Canada (Lei and Guo, 2022; Li, 2003).

Perpetuating settler colonialism, the multiculturalism policy in Canada further severs the connection between Indigenous cultures and racialized immigrants by degrading the distinct status of Indigenous cultures and categorizing them as one of other cultures (McElhinny, 2016). Immigrants and migrants are required to acquire English and French, learn more about white Canadian cultures and live in Canada as expected by the white settlers, so that they can contribute to Canadian society as stable social capital while maintaining the system designed by settler colonialism (Kwak, 2018). Immigrants' 'incapacity' to acquire English and French languages and cultural values upheld by white settlers is often ascribed to immigrants' own problem (e.g. unwilling to fit in), rather than the limitation of the multiculturalism policy (Li, 2003). This policy thus creates a docile image of racialized immigrants that are easily governed by the Canadian government (Lee and Johnstone, 2021). This inequity between white Canadian cultures and racialized immigrants' cultures, combined with the nature of integrating racialized immigrants into the 'mainstream' white Canadian cultures, further becomes a hotbed for racism to exist and grow (Chen and Wu, 2021; Fleras, 2014). Sugarcoated by multiculturalism, racism in Canada is also justified as sporadic and as happening mainly on the interpersonal level, as this policy has already 'reframed' Canada institutionally as a welcoming and equal society to immigrants from different cultural backgrounds (Simpson et al., 2011). Nevertheless, the constant re-emergence of anti-Asian racism throughout Canadian history (e.g. from SARS in 2003 to COVID-19 in 2020), uncovers how multiculturalism never addresses racism. The roles of contagious diseases in stigmatizing Asian groups and exacerbating anti-Asian racism can also be clearly seen in these re-emergences, as these diseases are often used to justify how racialized communities' cultures are 'inferior' (e.g. unhygienic lifestyles) and there is still a distance between them and the mainstream cultures (Larsson, 2020). Facilitated by the

stigmatization of infectious diseases, anti-Asian racism during the COVID-19 pandemic is an example of how multiculturalism, which is supposed to protect East Asian minorities in Canadian society, can be easily shattered, due to the fundamental power differentiation between white settlers and East Asian communities exposed by the stigma attached to these communities during the pandemic.

To sum up, multiculturalism disguises the ongoing racism in Canadian society and allows racism to operate in a more covert manner (Thobani, 2007). This hidden racism has been waiting for the 'proper' time (e.g. the SARS epidemic, the COVID-19 pandemic) to re-emerge (Lam, 2020; Larsson, 2020; Zhao et al., 2022). The following section further analyses the COVID-19 pandemic and anti-Asian racism through scapegoating theory, so that problematic intergroup interactions in this multicultural hierarchy leading to anti-Asian racism can be better understood.

Scapegoating theory and anti-Asian racism

The APA Dictionary of Psychology (n.d.) defines scapegoating theory as a theoretical analysis that helps us understand aggressive and violent conducts committed by individuals who deliberately blame other individuals or groups for bringing unpleasant experiences in social events. Similarly, the racial prejudice that one ethnic group expresses to the other groups in these negative social events can also be considered as scapegoating (APA Dictionary of Psychology, n.d.). Originating from atonement in the biblical context (i.e. goats were sacrificed to atone for humans' sins) (Schaefer, 2015), scapegoating was further developed and elaborated based on the work of scholars such as Emile Durkheim and Rene Girard (Denike, 2015; Mestrovic, 2019). This theory explains how societal members often attribute the misfortune associated with disastrous social events to the presence of other groups to express their frustration or anger, and to minimize the harm caused to social stability (Bashaw, 2023; Goldberg, 2008; Stowe, 2012). In addition to scapegoating on the group level, it is also common for scapegoating to happen on the individual level in which some individuals intentionally blame other innocent individuals for tragic events (e.g. death). These baseless accusations are made to help perpetrators re-obtain the sense of integration when experiencing those tragic events (Lulat, 2022; Stowe, 2012). Scapegoating theory has been gradually applied to understand how intergroup interactions, particularly in a multicultural society, can be problematic. In essence, scapegoating shows the 'otherness' of racialized minority groups in multicultural societies (Denike, 2015). This 'otherness' reflects a systemic barrier for racialized minorities to be truly integrated into a white settler society and can constantly emerge to damage the integration of these minorities (Ahmed, 2000). The image of racialized immigrants being the 'perpetual foreigners' is thus created, and when this image is being attached to diseases that are seen as exotic, immigrants will also be connected to these diseases and seen as a menace (Williams et al., 2023). Heidt (2018) elaborated on the relationship between scapegoating and racism and shared that the rhetoric used by Donald Trump during his presidential campaign to scapegoat minorities in American society undoubtedly contains racist undertones.

Similar to this scapegoating process in the United States, anti-Asian racism in Canada has also long been a product of scapegoating. The 'yellow peril' myth has emerged since the first generation of Chinese immigrants came to Canada (Leung, 2008). The residential areas of Chinese communities such as Chinatown were often regarded as 'filthy' and 'disease-ridden' (Chakraborty, 2022; Leung, 2008). The SARS epidemic that happened over two decades ago is also an example of how Chinese communities are scapegoated and dehumanized whenever there is a disease that can be related to them (Keil and Ali, 2006). Similarly, the anti-Asian sentiment arising from the recent COVID-19 pandemic and its consequences (e.g. death, economic recession) 'justifies' and 'solidifies' the scapegoating of East Asian communities in Canadian society (Zhao et al., 2022). The

fundamental power differentiation between white settlers and East Asian communities, combined with the complicity of other cultural groups, exacerbates the scapegoating faced by East Asian communities (Chen and Wu, 2021; Zhao et al., 2022). Discourse such as 'Chinese virus', 'China virus' and 'Kung flu' exemplifies the scapegoating process, as the Chinese descent is blamed for the disastrous consequences brought by the COVID-19 pandemic and is targeted by other groups through their frustration and hostilities (Omori and Stitt, 2023). It is also worth noting that this scapegoating process can be catalysed through the ongoing tensions between China and Canada and illustrated through the political hostility towards Chinese communities in Canada (Angus Reid Institute, 2023), which shows how scapegoating has also been evolving based on the contemporary geopolitics.

These problematic intergroup interactions that result in anti-Asian racism can permeate into school settings and impact how adolescents perceive and react to race-based bullying. For instance, Dixon (2007) found that scapegoating affected bullying in groups and can be a significant cause of bullying. This empirical evidence provides a possibility of connecting scapegoating to race-based bullying in schools. The following section further introduces dominance theory and aims to elaborate on how anti-Asian bullying, shaped by the scapegoating during the COVID-19 pandemic and the problematic Canadian multiculturalism, is operated on the individual level.

Dominance theory and anti-Asian bullying in schools

Dominance theory provides a theorical analysis to understand how the power imbalance between perpetrators and victims can ignite and accelerate bullying among adolescents (Mishna, 2012; Rigby, 2022). This focus on power imbalance between adolescents provides a flexibility of understanding anti-Asian bullying in both online and in-person settings. Although bullying often takes place in schools and is influenced by the school climate (Asțor and Benbenishty, 2019), the rapid changes during the pandemic (e.g. online education) have shifted bullying contexts, as adolescents may receive misinformation on COVID-19 and conduct anti-Asian bullying in online settings (Wong, 2022). In addition, despite the emerging literature on the important role of school climate in addressing anti-Asian racism (Gee et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2023), its exact role is still not clear. Dominance theory can help schools better understand how interactions between adolescents lead to anti-Asian bullying, and provides valuable insights into the improvement of the school climate to address such bullying, especially when there is still a lack of policies on handling anti-Asian bullying after in-person learning has resumed in schools (Eizadirad et al., 2025).

Dominance as a social hierarchy is typically applied to understand bullying among individuals, particularly adolescents, especially when the group has just formed or there are new members joining the group (Kolbert and Crothers, 2003; Long and Pellegrini, 2003). It focuses on power dynamics among individuals within their social groups and aims to find out the cause of bullying based on the interactions of group members (Mishna, 2012). It is worth noting that in addition to dominance theory, there is also a social dominance theory. Particularly, social dominance theory believes that there are different kinds of social hierarchies because of power imbalances between different groups such as gender and social class in the macro social context, and socially dominant groups usually impose oppression on other more vulnerable groups (Evans and Smokowski, 2016; Volk et al., 2021). Bullying, according to social dominance theory, can reflect this oppression caused by these social hierarchies within social groups (Nishina, 2004). Hence, social dominance theory focuses more on the macro social and group contexts that possibly shape bullying, whereas dominance theory focuses more on the interpersonal context and its influences on bullying (Evans and Smokowski, 2016).

In order to help us form a comprehensive understanding of bullying dynamics, dominance theory is reframed as an overarching theoretical framework in this discussion that includes both. Previous research has validated social dominance theory and suggested that there is a strong relationship between school bullying and social dominance (Long and Pellegrini, 2003; Volk et al., 2021). For example, Goodboy et al. (2016) found that social dominance significantly related to four types of bullying (i.e. attacks on property, physical victimization, social manipulation and verbal victimization). While validating the relationship between school bullying and dominance, dominance theory also indicates three characteristics of bullying. The first one is social control, as group members tend to compete through bullying in order to obtain the control of their groups (Long and Pellegrini, 2003). The second one is access to resources, since the most powerful members often aim to obtain extra resources through bullying to maintain their leadership of the group (Reijntjes et al., 2013). The third one is power hierarchy, as the ultimate result of dominance is to form a hierarchy that features the most powerful group members (Long and Pellegrini, 2003). In addition, Evans and Smokowski (2016) suggested that perpetrators often commit school bullying to increase their social dominance in schools. The hierarchical school context also increases the chance of perpetrators conducting school bullying and enhancing their dominance (Pan et al., 2020).

Dominance theory offers important insights into understanding anti-Asian bullying among adolescents in multicultural Canada. In the Canadian context, the hierarchy in Canadian multiculturalism that features white settlers already lays the ground for the potential power imbalances in Canadian schools (Ng, 2022). Amid the anti-Asian racism that emerged from the COVID-19 pandemic, adolescents might receive misinformation on social media and be exposed to anti-Asian attitudes and remarks that are rampant in the Canadian social context (Wong, 2022). Adolescents from other cultural backgrounds may be instigated in this ongoing scapegoating of East Asian communities for the spread of COVID-19, and when this notion is brought by them to schools, adolescents may tolerate the scapegoating and justify anti-Asian bullying as it seems to be 'tolerated' by society (Wong, 2022). During this process, the ingrained power imbalances between white settlers and East Asian communities in Canadian multiculturalism are exposed and other cultural groups might become complicit in anti-Asian racism in schools (Ng, 2022; Wong, 2022). In these circumstances, degrading East Asian adolescents to obtain more power in the groups of adolescents and maintain the power hierarchy within the groups can emerge, as depicted by the characteristics of bullying in dominance theory and social dominance theory (Long and Pellegrini, 2003; Mishna, 2012; Nishina, 2004). Perpetrators might believe that they have more power when interacting with East Asian adolescents and by implementing scapegoating, they might be able to obtain more power. Conversely, East Asian adolescents, who are also exposed to the large-scale scapegoating of Asian communities for the COVID-19 pandemic, might feel powerless to fight back when facing anti-Asian racism. Their identity issues (e.g. self-doubt) (*CBC Kids News*, 2020) emerging from this process may put them in a more disadvantageous situation (e.g. escalated frequency or severity of bullying events) for bullying victimization. Overall, both social dominance theory and dominance theory help us understand different contexts that result in anti-Asian bullying on the individual level.

Discussion

Based on the theoretical analyses of Canadian multiculturalism on the macro level, scapegoating theory on the mezzo level, as well as dominance theory on the micro level, a conceptual model that integrates these theories and the roles of social workers engaging with each context to protect East Asian adolescents from anti-Asian bullying is put forward. This type of integration that aims to

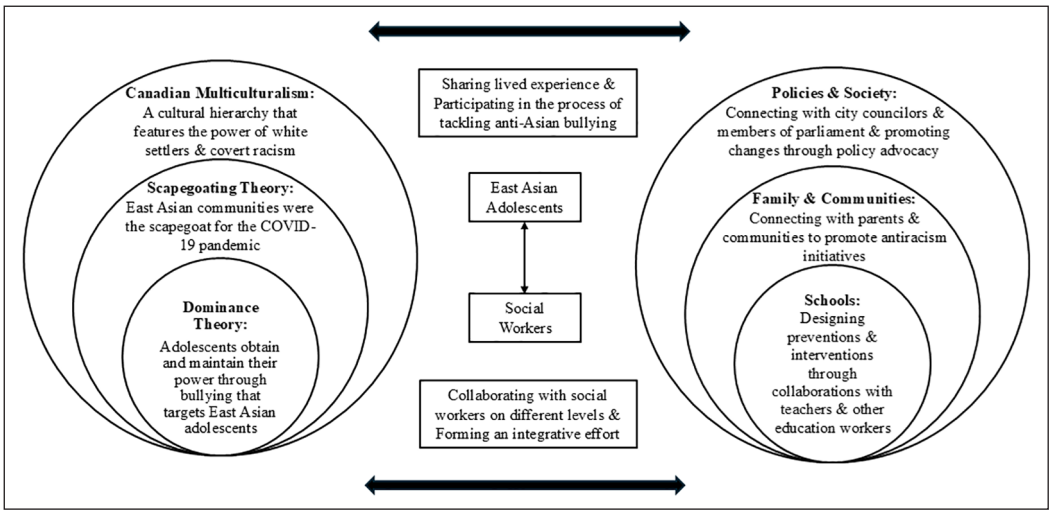

Figure 1. The conceptual model to understand and address anti-Asian bullying in Canadian schools.

view and solve social issues in a holistic manner has been widely discussed in the social work literature (e.g. Zhao and Bhuyan, 2024; Zhao et al., 2024) and provides a direction for social workers to better understand and address anti-Asian racism in schools.

In this model (see Figure 1), the concentric circles on the left visualize how three theories form a comprehensive understanding of anti-Asian bullying faced by East Asian adolescents in schools. Anti-Asian racism is embedded in Canadian society and is cloaked in the multiculturalism policy (Lei and Guo, 2022). When the COVID-19 pandemic emerged, the covert racism faced by East Asian communities was expressed overtly and became rampant (Chakraborty, 2022). Propelled by the scapegoating of East Asian communities that happened during the COVID-19 pandemic (Omori and Stitt, 2023), racial bullying targeting East Asian adolescents can intensify and impact their well-being. East Asian adolescents might also internalize the scapegoating, reinforce the stereotypes about their own identity (e.g. they are responsible for the pandemic) and be in a more disadvantageous situation when dealing with bullying in schools (Chen et al., 2021; Trent et al., 2019). These three levels of theories also match the specific contexts on each level (e.g. schools, communities, policies) that influence adolescents, and social workers can make efforts to reduce anti-Asian bullying faced by East Asian adolescents on each level. Particularly, social workers need to realize the central role of East Asian adolescents in tackling anti-Asian bullying, as these adolescents have their own lived experiences of facing and dealing with anti-Asian bullying. This acknowledgement of clients' voices in the interactions between social workers and clients has been emphasized in social work practice and shown improvements in services provided by social workers (e.g. Lee and Bhuyan, 2013; Lee et al., 2019). This central role of East Asian adolescents has thus been displayed in the centre of the model, and how social workers can collaborate with them to reduce bullying on each level is further introduced in the following sections.

The three levels that social workers can work on are visualized in the concentric circles on the right. At the micro level, schools are the primary setting where anti-Asian bullying takes place. By building a rapport with East Asian adolescents and understanding bullying experienced by them, school social workers can work with teachers and other education workers to design and implement preventions and interventions to reduce the frequency of anti-Asian bullying. For example,

they can deliver workshops that introduce anti-Asian racism, strategies for East Asian adolescents to speak up when facing anti-Asian bullying incidents, and suggestions for adolescents from other cultures to form solidarity with East Asian adolescents. Social workers can also design and distribute brochures to raise adolescents' awareness of addressing anti-Asian racism and promoting diversity, equity and inclusion in schools. In terms of interventions, school social workers need to take the initiative to conduct various interventions to address anti-Asian bullying. For example, they can utilize Cognitive Behavioural Therapy (CBT) to intervene in race-based bullying victimization, as CBT has been proved effective in tackling mental health issues (e.g. suicidal intent, trauma) emerging from bullying from the client-centred and developmental perspectives (Ferraz De Camargo et al., 2023; Lydecker, 2022). At the school-wide level, the transformative social-emotional learning (SEL) approach could be adopted as it invites students and adults to critically examine the underlying causes of inequity and ways to address them (Jagers et al., 2019). This approach highlights the importance of cultivating a healthy sense of identity, exercising agency, fostering a sense of belonging, engaging in collaborative problem-solving, and nurturing curiosity to pursue knowledge and diverse perspectives (Jagers et al., 2019). Previous research also indicates that adolescents with greater social-emotional capacities are less likely to engage in bullying (You et al., 2023).

Expanding from schools, families and communities can be seen as the mezzo level for social workers to work on to reduce anti-Asian bullying. Connecting with East Asian adolescents and school social workers, social workers who work with families can reach out to East Asian parents to understand their concerns about anti-Asian racism in schools and explore possible ways of reducing anti-Asian racism in schools with them. This outreach has been supported by the empirical evidence. For example, Wang et al. (2023) found that Asian parents hope to see more outreach efforts from schools to help them and their children better navigate racism in schools during the pandemic. Social workers also need to reach out to parents who are from other cultural backgrounds to raise the awareness of reducing anti-Asian racism in schools and seek the collective support from these parents to address not only anti-Asian racism but also other types of racism in schools. This initiative is crucial, as family has been found to be one of the major contexts that shape children's bullying behaviours in schools (Wang et al., 2021). Bearing in mind East Asian adolescents' experiences of dealing with bullying, community social workers can brainstorm possible programmes and advocacy projects to reduce problematic intergroup interactions in Canada that shape anti-Asian bullying in schools. This type of community work has shown the effectiveness of promoting justice and equity for racialized communities. For example, community rallies across Canada that helped Asian communities voice their concerns about anti-Asian racism have raised the public's awareness of this serious social issue (Tsekouras, 2021). In terms of anti-Asian racism in schools, by organizing events such as townhall meetings and conversation circles that feature East Asian adolescents' struggles with anti-Asian bullying in schools, social workers can guide the communities to reflect on the negative influences of systemic racism on the younger generation and form alliances with parents to promote equity and justice for their children.

Society and policies are the macro level that social workers can engage with to reduce the influence of anti-Asian racism on East Asian adolescents in schools. Informed by East Asian adolescents' experiences, social workers who have been engaging with policy change and advocacy can delve deeper into Canadian multicultural and educational policies to identify potential limitations that lead to anti-Asian racism in schools. They can then put forward positive changes in the current policies by incorporating feedback from East Asian adolescents, social workers on other levels, parents and teachers, derived from activities such as writing open letters to school boards, seeking media exposure, as well as connecting to city councillors and members of parliament. The previous literature has also indicated the important role of policy analysis and advocacy in solving social

issues and facilitating positive changes in the long term (Cummins et al., 2011; Zhao and Bhuyan, 2024). The efforts on these three levels reflect the perspective of person-in-environment that features the central role of the clients to guide social work practice (Green and McDermott, 2010; Kondrat, 2002); these efforts can further be integrated to form a dynamic and comprehensive circle to understand and tackle anti-Asian bullying in schools.

However, this model also has limitations. For example, the sustainability of addressing anti-Asian racism in schools needs to be explored. Although COVID-19 is no longer a global pandemic (Roknuzzaman et al., 2024), anti-Asian racism arising from it might still have a lasting influences. Hence, the effort of addressing anti-Asian racism in schools should not be a one-time attempt, but rather a sustainable force that delves deeply into Canadian society to investigate and reduce systemic inequity that causes anti-Asian racism in schools. Future research and practice should explore possible ways of maintaining this sustainability. In addition, the ways to maintain the dynamics of these initiatives and implement the principles of diversity, inclusion and equity in different contexts (e.g. schools, communities) need to be constantly explored. Overall, this model provides a solid theoretical foundation to understanding and reducing anti-Asian racism faced by East Asian adolescents. It also provides an important reference for future research and practice to better understand different cultural, social and individual factors that shape racism faced by different racialized communities.

Conclusion

The well-being of East Asian adolescents, as racialized minorities in Canadian schools, needs more attention from the public, especially amid anti-Asian racism. Considering the unprecedented damage caused by the COVID-19 pandemic in Canadian society, the negative impact of anti-Asian racism may last for a long time and dramatically change the public's perceptions of intergroup relations. Under these circumstances, East Asian adolescents might also be profoundly affected by race-based discrimination and bullying in schools. Given the importance and urgency of this topic, this conceptual analysis delves into this social issue and shows that anti-Asian bullying is not simply formed on the individual level, but rather shaped by the Canadian social context. In order to better understand and tackle such bullying in schools, social workers who practise on different levels need to collaborate with adolescents and forge joint efforts with parents and teachers to facilitate positive changes in schools, so that adolescents from racialized backgrounds can be better protected.

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AI statement

The authors declare that AI was not used in this work.

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Article

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A study into the HIV/AIDS knowledge of social workers and social work students in Kyrgyzstan and their attitudes towards people living with HIV

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Abstract
The level of HIV awareness among social workers in Kyrgyzstan is still low, which negatively impacts on the quality of the services they provide. The study examines the knowledge of social workers and social work students about HIV, attitudes towards people living with HIV, and willingness to provide social services. The study used an HIV knowledge survey (n = 314). The percentage of correct answers to knowledge questions was 70.3% among social workers and 64.5% among students. Only 50.1% of students and 40% of social workers are willing to provide services. The study found that the participants lacked adequate knowledge about HIV.

Keywords
Attitudes towards people living with HIV, HIV/AIDS knowledge, professional competencies, psychological readiness, social work students, stigma

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Introduction

Since the beginning of the epidemic, social workers have played a crucial role in the response to HIV/AIDS (Kaplan et al., 2004). They have developed care and support services, set up educational programmes and information campaigns, and contributed to the response at a more structural level by developing policy recommendations and improving the quality-of-service delivery. Social workers have been particularly important in addressing the needs of people living with HIV and overcoming HIV-related stigma and discrimination. However, despite their key roles in the response to the epidemic, HIV/AIDS knowledge among social workers and other caregivers has remained low. Social work courses only marginally cover the topic of HIV/AIDS, which means that students are barely prepared for the field of work (Labra et al., 2023). This especially holds true for post-Soviet transition countries such as Kyrgyzstan, where social work is still in the process of becoming an academic discipline and professional field of work. Adequate knowledge about HIV/AIDS and intervention strategies is a necessary prerequisite for the development and implementation of social services for people living with HIV and enables the dissemination of anti-stigmatisation approaches.

This study examines the level of information held about HIV/AIDS and the attitudes towards people living with HIV among professional social workers and social work students enrolled in university programmes in the Central Asian Republic of Kyrgyzstan. The findings are based on a systematic analysis of degree curricula at Kyrgyz University and an online survey conducted among social work professionals and students.

The development of social work and the response to HIV/AIDS in Kyrgyzstan

Social work is an emerging discipline in Kyrgyzstan. After the country gained independence from the Soviet Union in 1991, social work developed as an independent profession, a process that took place in the context of economic hardship, decreasing levels of well-being, and a growing need for social support throughout the population (Musaeva, 2012). The institutionalisation of social work in Kyrgyzstan was carried out in a similar way as in other post-Soviet countries, going through certain stages of development. Social work was institutionalised, and regulations for the professional tasks of social workers were developed. An important step was the adoption of the 'Regulation of the Social Workers' on 29 February 2012, No. 157. The first university to establish a course in social work was the State University in Bishkek.

HIV/AIDS treatment, prevention, care, and support is an important field of work for social workers in Kyrgyzstan. As of 1 January 2024, the cumulative number of registered HIV-infections in Kyrgyzstan was 12,054 (7571 men and 4473 women), of which 3193 people have already died. Over the past 10 years, the nature of the HIV/AIDS epidemic in Kyrgyzstan has changed: the percentage share of parenteral transmissions has decreased from 27.6% in 2016 to 4% in 2021. There has also been an increase in the rates of sexual transmission of HIV: the number of HIV infections due to sexual transmission increased from 263 registered cases in 2013 to 812 registered case in 2022 (Kyrgyzstan HIV/AIDS Center of Kyrgyz Republic, 2023). This increase indicates that the HIV/AIDS epidemic has spread beyond key groups and is now affecting the general population.

HIV/AIDS requires professional care, not only from medical workers but also from social workers who deal with socio-economic, psychological, and legal support for people living with HIV. The role of social workers is extremely important, as they conduct a wide range of programmes to provide social and psychological assistance to people living with HIV, including programmes focusing on psychosocial assistance, rehabilitation, legal protection, prevention and

reduction of disease risk, work with the social environment, promotion of healthy lifestyles, etc. (Hall, 2007).

The involvement of social workers in the response to HIV/AIDS is linked to the overall development of social work as a profession. In the first few years after Kyrgyzstan gained independence in 1991, the social work profession was primarily seen as providing social and domestic services to persons with disabilities or to vulnerable elderly citizens. Today, social work in Kyrgyzstan is understood as an integrated activity that aims to achieve positive social change – a profession that involves creating conditions for the social adaptation and reintegration of people in difficult life situations, and ensuring the successful socialisation and integration of each individual into society (Musaeva, 2018). Kyrgyzstan has created a legal framework that forms the basis for the tasks and obligations of social workers. The most important regulations include the Law 'On the Fundamentals of Social Services in the Kyrgyz Republic' and the 2012 Regulation on Social Workers. The State Programme on Family Support and Child Protection for 2018–2028, adopted in 2017, sets out the general policy guidelines.

Based on these general regulations for social work services, specific state support programmes were developed for key populations, including sex workers, men who have sex with men, transgenders and people living in prison (Government of the Kyrgyz Republic, 2017). These programmes include HIV prevention, treatment, care, and support. The role of practising social workers is particularly important in the prevention of drug use disorders as well as in drug treatment and rehabilitation programmes. However, despite the importance of social work in the field of HIV/AIDS, most social workers in Kyrgyzstan are not trained and are thus psychologically unprepared to work with people living with HIV and their families. In practice, social workers often stigmatise people living with HIV (Ruziev et al., 2018), out of fear for their own health and the health of their relatives, and due to a lack knowledge about HIV-infection (Taenkova et al., 2019) or a clear understanding of their professional role in providing social assistance.

In this regard, it is of particular importance to train social workers to become sufficiently aware of HIV/AIDS and competent to provide professional and comprehensive medical, social, psychological, pedagogical, and legal assistance to people living with HIV. At the same time, the training programme should contain the necessary information about methods to reduce stigma and the social isolation of people living with HIV (Bowen, 2013).

Therefore, the purpose of this study is to analyse the levels of HIV/AIDS knowledge among social work students and practising social workers, their attitudes towards people living with HIV, and their readiness to provide services to people living with HIV/AIDS as part of their professional activities. The objectives of the study include gaining national and international experience of training social work specialists in dealing with people living with HIV; developing the methodology and principles of the study; conducting a field study; collecting and processing data; and analysing and summarising the results of the study.

Understanding HIV knowledge and attitudes among social workers

The profession of social work has been important in the international response to HIV/AIDS (Bowen, 2013). Since the 1980s, social workers have been involved in designing and implementing direct services for those affected by the epidemic (Rutledge et al., 2011). Although social workers play an important role in service delivery, the profession is not free from stigmatising attitudes towards people living with HIV and key populations and at times perpetuates stigmatisation in social work practices (Labra at al., 2023).

Stigma and discrimination often result from fear, lack of information and education, lack of contact with infected individuals and non-premeditated behaviours (Labra et al., 2023) therefore it is important to address knowledge and attitudes among social workers and include a basic training on HIV/AIDS in the curriculum for social work students. This study combines two objectives. It studies both the level of knowledge about HIV/AIDS among social workers and social work students as well as their attitudes towards people living with HIV and key populations.

This study builds upon the HIV Stigma Framework (Earnshaw et al., 2013) that shows that stigma both negatively affects the mental and physical well-being of people living with HIV and is a significant barrier to HIV prevention and treatment efforts (Ferguson et al., 2022). HIV-related stigma consists of a number of mechanisms, including prejudice, stereotypes, and discrimination that impact the psychological, behavioural, and health outcomes (Earnshaw and Chaudoir, 2009). In this study, the focus is on social workers and social work students. The level of HIV-related knowledge and attitudes among social workers shed light on the extent to which people living with HIV in Kyrgyzstan can access social services without stigma and discrimination.

Methods

The study applies a mixed-methods design, consisting of (1) an online survey of the HIV/AIDS knowledge of social workers and social work students and their attitudes towards people living with HIV and (2) a document analysis of educational regulations regarding the inclusion of the issue of HIV/AIDS in social work degree programmes.

The online survey was conducted to identify the level of HIV/AIDS knowledge among social workers and social work students, their attitudes towards people living with HIV, and their psychological readiness to provide services to people living with HIV as part of their professional activities as social workers. The online survey was conducted among two groups of respondents: social workers and social work students. The beginning of the online survey contained a description of the purpose and nature of the study, as well as a statement of informed consent to participate. In the event of a student's refusal to participate, access to the questionnaire was limited, which ensured voluntary participation and respondents' awareness of the nature of the study, as well as guarantees of confidentiality and anonymity of their data.

The *first group* of respondents consisted of 146 professional social workers, employed at district and city departments of the Ministry of Labour, Social Security and Migration of the Kyrgyz Republic and covered six oblasts across the country: Chui oblast (61 respondents), Issyk-Kul oblast (three respondents), Naryn oblast (15 respondents), Jalal-Abad oblast (37 respondents), Batken oblast (9 respondents), Talas oblast (21 respondents). The average length of service among these social workers was 8 years and 6 months. The survey was conducted between April and May 2023 and covered six regions. In April and May 2023, by prior agreement with the heads of district departments, a link to the online questionnaire was sent to the work chats of social workers. To simplify the organisation and calculation of survey data, a Google questionnaire was created and Microsoft Excel was used.

The *second group* of respondents consisted of 153 third- and fourth-year students studying social work. In April 2023, a link to the online questionnaire was sent to the students' group chats after prior agreement with course advisors. As with the first group, the questionnaire was created in a Google Form. The online survey was conducted among students at the following universities across the country: Bishkek State University (BSU; Bishkek, 42 students), Osh State University (Osh, 35), Kyrgyz National University (Bishkek, 20), Kyrgyz State University (Bishkek, 20), Kyrgyz Economic University (Bishkek, 16), International University of Kyrgyzstan (Bishkek, 7), and Jalal-Abad State University (Jalal-Abad, 13). In total, 153 students took part.

We designed the questionnaire for social work students and social workers to reveal two elements of professional competence: cognitive (HIV knowledge) and behavioural and value orientation (readiness to provide professional services in the field of HIV/AIDS). The first part of the questionnaire is intended to assess the formation of cognitive competences, as laid down in the State Educational Standards of Higher Professional Education for the degree programme Social Work. We calculated HIV knowledge by using the following formula based on the methodological recommendations for conducting studies to assess the level of public awareness of HIV-infection issues (FGBU, 2017):

$$\frac{\mathbf{A} = \sum^{1-20\ 100}}{\mathbf{N\,x\,29}},$$

where **A** – HIV knowledge among social workers (in %), **N** – overall number of answers, **29** – maximum number of correct answers).

The second part of the questionnaire is intended to determine the behavioural and value orientation of social workers and social work students.

In total, 314 people (46 men and 268 women) took part in the study.

To study the features of the development of the education system in the field of training social workers in Kyrgyzstan, a comparative analysis of state standards and available educational programmes of seven universities in Kyrgyzstan that train social workers was conducted. Statistical data, university reports for the past 5 years, university websites, and all available publications on this research topic were also analysed.

Ethical considerations of the study

The ethical approval was received on 3 March 2023 (Protocol No. 2) before conducting the study and as a result of discussing the design of the study. The Ethical and Scientific Council of BSU scientists, which consists of 14 scientific experts, discussed and gave ethical approval to the study and recommended the further publication of a scientific article. We also obtained consent from all participants of the study to voluntarily participate in the study.

The theoretical framework

The research was based on fundamental theoretical principles, approaches and concepts that explain the features of professional development among social work students and the influence of social, psychological, pedagogical and other factors on the educational and professional motivation of social workers and their level of psychological readiness to work with key populations. The main ideas and reflections of the authors are grounded in such theories as: theories of stigma and discrimination, concepts of social justice, theories of behavioural change, theories of emotions and motivation, theories of professional socialisation, and concepts of self-efficacy and personal growth.

Results

HIV/AIDS knowledge among social work students and social workers

The first part of the questionnaire included questions on HIV/AIDS knowledge of social workers and social work students, including modes of transmission and prevention. Table 1 shows

Table 1. The overall percentage of correct answers given by respondents to questions about HIV.

No	Total respondents	Female	Male	Correct answers to HIV knowledge questions
Social worker		21	124	70.3%
Social work student		17	136	64.5%

HIV/AIDS Knowledge among Social Workers and Social Work Students. The percentage share of correct answers to the knowledge questions was 64.5% among social work students and 70.3% among social workers. One hundred and thirty-four students (87% of participants) and 123 social workers (86% of participants) were able to answer the general question about what HIV/AIDS is correctly. However, more than 13% of the survey indicated that they were not aware of the epidemiological situation of HIV in Kyrgyzstan.

The level of information regarding the routes of HIV transmission also varies. In response to the question 'How can HIV be transmitted?', the majority of respondents (students – 79.7%, social workers – 89%) answered 'unprotected sexual contact'. The second most popular answer was 'use of non-sterile syringes for injections' – 68% and 81.4% respectively. Some survey answers reveal common misconceptions: 21.6% of students and 15.2% of social workers thought that HIV can be transmitted 'through kissing', 11.8% of students and 11.7% of social workers 'through the sharing of cigarettes', and 13.1% of students and 8.3% of social workers 'through blood-sucking insects' (mosquito bites). Overall, social workers were better informed about HIV transmission routes than social work students. The answers show that, despite information campaigns, there are still many people in Kyrgyzstan who do not have correct information on HIV/AIDS.

We also asked about the sources of information that people use to inform themselves on HIV/AIDS: 70% of students and 80.7% of social workers indicated that mass media and Internet were their main sources of information; 51% of students and 80.7% of social workers stated that they obtain information from their social environment, the people around them. It should be noted that these sources do not always provide reliable information on HIV/AIDS. Around 53.6% of students and 35% of social workers answered that they gained information from university lectures, and 41.2% of students and 64.1% of social workers from medical institutions.

Attitudes towards people living with HIV

Empathy, professional tolerance, humanity, and ethical values are basic principles of social work (Jaoko, 2014). The ability to establish contacts and to build trusting relationships with clients are among the most important professional skills for social workers. Ethical values and a tolerant attitude also help social workers to strengthen their psychological stability and their ability to cope with emotional stress and overload.

Table 2 shows attitudes towards people living with HIV among Social Workers and Social Work Students, in response to the question 'What would your attitude be towards a classmate upon finding out that he or she was HIV-positive?', 16 students (10.5%) answered that they would break off contact, 31 students (20.3%) replied that they thought that students with HIV should not study at an educational institution with people who are not HIV-positive, 26 students (17%) answered that their attitude would change and that they would feel sorry for the person. Only 40.5% (62 students) answered that their attitude would not change.

Table 2. Respondents' attitudes towards a person after they find out about their HIV status.

No	The question asked in the questionnaire 'What would your attitude be towards a colleague upon finding out that he/she was HIV-positive?'	Respondents' answers	
	Answer options	Social workers' answers	Social work students' answers
1	I think that will change, I will feel sorry for him	24.1%	17%
2	I think that will change, I will minimise all contacts with him	9%	10.5%
3	No, it won't change	44.8%	40.5%
4	Employees/students who are HIV-positive should not work/ study in our organisation	9%	20.3%
5	Difficult to answer	13.1%	11.7%

A similar question was also asked to social workers: 'What would your attitude be towards a colleague upon finding out that he or she was HIV-positive?' – 44.8% of social workers answered that their attitude would not change, 9% answered that employees who are HIV-positive should not work in their organisation, 9% answered that their attitude towards that person would change, 24.1% answered that they would feel sorry for him or her, and 13.1% found it difficult to answer. These results indicate the presence of hidden stigmatisation of people living with HIV, both among students and social workers.

The survey also showed that social workers had objections to working with someone who is HIV-positive. In 67.4 ± 5.1% of cases, social workers stated that when hiring for a job related to people, an employee must be asked to disclose his or her HIV status.

Psychological readiness to work with people living with HIV

The psychological readiness of a social worker to work with people living with HIV includes mobilisation of cognitive and emotional skills (empathy) aimed at providing social services to people living with HIV and their families. If a social worker is psychologically attuned and ready to work, this can increase their ability to successfully fulfil their professional duties (Strug et al., 2002).

We asked the respondents the question 'Are you ready to work with people living with HIV as a social worker?' The majority of students – 77 of them (50.1%) – said they are ready to work in the field of HIV/AIDS prevention. Among social workers, only 58 (40%) responded positively. By comparison, 41 students (26.8%) and 38 social workers (26.2%) answered negatively, while the rest of the respondents – 35 students (22.9%) and 49 social workers (33.8%) found it difficult to answer.

Based on these data, it can be seen that half (50.1%) of students are ready to link their professional activities with social services for people living with HIV and HIV/AIDS prevention. At the same time, only 40% of social workers showed readiness to provide social services to people who are HIV-positive. It can be seen that students demonstrated a relatively positive attitude towards people living with HIV.

HIV-related stigma is a key issue that affects quality of life, access to healthcare, and the quality of social and psychological care. In a study conducted among women living with HIV in the Kyrgyz Republic, it was also noted that almost every one of the study participants had at least once

experienced stigmatising attitudes from the staff of medical institutions. Also, out of fear that their HIV-status might be disclosed, some women refused state social services (social benefits, breast milk substitutes, etc.).

The role of social workers in HIV/AIDS prevention

Social workers play an important role in providing psychosocial support to people living with HIV. As Michel Sidibé noted in the report *Getting to Zero: Global Social Work Responds to HIV:*

> Around the world, social workers are making a huge contribution to the HIV response through their creativity and genuine commitment. They work with the most vulnerable populations and help them regain dignity, solidarity, social justice and hope. (Henrickson et al., 2007)

Social workers are directly involved in the process of treating and rehabilitating people living with HIV, performing an unlimited variety of functions.

In Kyrgyzstan, social workers, employed in state institutions (clinics), are sufficiently involved in HIV/AIDS prevention. They are involved in identifying families and children in difficult life situations; providing social, legal, psychological, and pedagogical support; raising the level of public awareness about HIV; organising educational events for young people; and raising awareness. However, it should be noted that of the 146 social workers who took part in our online survey, only 11.7% of them have experience in working with people living with HIV.

Furthermore, non-governmental organisations (NGOs) are very active in providing services to key populations. In Kyrgyzstan, NGOs are among the first to respond to HIV/AIDS by facilitating access to counselling and healthcare for people living with HIV (Ancker and Rechel, 2013). Since the early 2000s, in the context of Kyrgyzstan's economic difficulties, most HIV prevention activities have been carried out by NGOs, with the support of international donors. In 2004, an association of harm reduction programmes called the 'Partner Network' was established, which at that time united 48 NGOs.

Discussion

To study the need for training in social work degree programmes for students to become competent to work with people living with HIV(PLHIV) and their families, we studied the educational standards of social work degree programmes in Kyrgyzstan. At present, the degree programmes (specialised secondary education programmes and bachelor's and master's degrees) do not specify any categories of social work clients. The government educational standards define the types of professional activities, professional competencies, and learning outcomes that provide the guidelines for the degree programmes at the universities in Kyrgyzstan.

However, this competency-based learning approach is still poorly implemented in practice. Many pedagogical ideas regarding the goals, content, and methods of training students in the field of social work are mostly of a private nature (Sizikova, 2011).

The professionalisation of education in the field of social work with people who are living with HIV requires a revision of the structure and content of social work degree programmes education, but also of the forms and methods of professional training, based on best practices of social work education.

Having studied the state educational standards for higher and secondary educational programmes we can conclude that Kyrgyz universities lack specialised training programmes for social workers to work with people living with HIV and their families. Apart from BSU, which trains

social workers, none of the educational programmes of the higher education institutions in the country includes courses in which students could increase their knowledge about HIV/AIDS. There is only one general course, 'Medical and Social Basics of Healthcare', which provides basic information on human health.

As a result of collaboration between the Department of Social Work of BSU and AFEW Kyrgyzstan, a training course 'Social Work with PLHIV Women' was developed in 2019. Several expert training sessions and meetings were also held. Based on this course, the authors of this article have created a comprehensive course, 'Social Work with PLHIV', which includes four credits, which was tested during the 2022–2023 academic year. As a result, this course was approved by the Academic Committee of the University and included in the curriculum for the Bachelor's degree in social work (dated 25 May 2024) and is currently being taught to third-year students.

We argue that at present, both students and social workers lack important knowledge about regulations and social services that are needed in the field of HIV/AIDS. Within the walls of the university, social work students do not receive the necessary theoretical and practical training to work in the field of HIV/AIDS prevention, which requires an interdisciplinary approach. In addition to mastering the basic methods and approaches of social work (such as crisis intervention, a problem-oriented approach, situational work, etc.), students need to acquire knowledge and skills in the wide range of sociological, psychological, and legal disciplines needed to work with people living with HIV and their families.

That is why the course includes discussions of complex ethical dilemmas and analysis of specific examples, and the study of the legal aspects and issues of professional ethics of social work. Guest speakers and experts who work with PLHIV will also be invited. Students will be sent to practice in organisations that work closely with PLHIV and their families. In addition, students will receive psychological training to help them reduce internal barriers and fears.

Next to a lack of HIV knowledge, the findings revealed the presence of stigmatising attitudes towards people living with HIV, which suggests it is necessary to raise the level of HIV awareness among social workers and students. Attitudes towards people living with HIV largely depend on the general public's awareness of HIV, social stigma in the community, and most of all, on the quality of the professional services and organisations that conduct preventive and educational work among the general population. A low level of knowledge about HIV infection leads to stigma, self-stigma, and the social discrimination of people living with HIV in society. The social isolation of population groups also contributes to a general decrease in social cohesion. In turn, as a result of social stigmatisation, people living with HIV may develop self-stigma, which affects their quality of life, behaviour, and adherence to treatment.

We can conclude that social work degree programmes in Kyrgyzstan do not address HIV/AIDS in an adequate way. The gaps in the training of social workers can have negative consequences for the development of social work with key populations. This is very important in the context of the shortage of competent professional social workers available to work with people living with HIV and their families. A lack of knowledge and awareness of HIV/AIDS is a significant factor in the reluctance of social work graduates to work with key populations. An adequate level of HIV knowledge significantly improves social workers' attitudes towards people living with HIV, their emotional perception and understanding of people living with HIV, and their ability to effectively communicate with them.

NGO specialists who work directly with people living with HIV understand their needs very well, show empathy, and express responsiveness and willingness to provide social services. In this regard, it is necessary to continue efforts to increase practising social workers' and students' knowledge about HIV, including the risks of infection, prevention methods, access to modern methods of

diagnostics, treatment of HIV infection, and social support and counselling services (Chernyavskaya et al., 2014).

Social workers in NGOs are actively involved in organising various activities, especially at the community level; in protecting vulnerable groups of the population; and in providing social support to individuals with a preliminary positive HIV test result. In Kyrgyzstan, social work with key population groups, including people living with HIV, people who inject drugs, prisoners, sex workers, men who have sex with men, and migrants, is at approximately the same stage as in other Central Asian countries. All social work with key populations shares the following characteristics: the active involvement of representatives of NGOs in the treatment and prevention process, the same algorithm for the social support of key populations in difficult life situations, and an acute shortage of professional social workers competent and willing to work with this special population, which is a key component and priority area for the development of professional social work as a whole (Michels et al., 2021).

We identified the following responsibilities of social workers in the field of HIV/AIDS: reaching out to new clients, conducting counselling (motivational, psychosocial, supportive, crisis, etc.) and pre- and post-test HIV counselling (ensuring the completion of HIV testing; conducting rapid HIV testing; when a preliminary positive HIV test result is detected, ensuring that further testing is done and providing motivational counselling; upon confirmation of a positive result, ensuring that the client is registered with a dispensary at an AIDS centre); and providing psychosocial support for clients for the timely initiation of antiretroviral therapy.

NGO social workers work with people living with HIV on adherence to antiretroviral therapy and achieving a suppressed viral load and implement social support programmes (case management) depending on the client's needs. It is also important to ensure that clients undergo screening for sexually transmitted infections and tuberculosis. Social workers refer and accompany clients to medical services and provide psychosocial support to clients in order to develop and maintain their adherence to treatment for transmitted infections and tuberculosis. The social and legal assistance consists of helping clients with obtaining social services, the restoration of documents, the receipt of social benefits.

Carrying out motivational work aimed at changing the behaviour of clients is one of a social worker's most important tasks. They conduct socio-psychological trainings, participate in advocacy events, and protect clients' rights by ensuring confidentiality.

All these functional roles require profound HIV knowledge but also a broad range of professional skills and competencies. Social workers at NGOs have repeatedly emphasised the importance of attracting professional social workers who are competent in the fields of social law, psychology, and the social protection of people living with HIV, their families, and those in their immediate environment, and who are able to apply a multifunctional approach to their work.

Conclusion

We have explored the level of knowledge about HIV held by social work students and social workers in Kyrgyzstan; their attitudes towards people living with HIV and their families; and their readiness to provide professional assistance to people living with HIV.

Almost all respondents have a basic level of knowledge about HIV, but this knowledge is not enough to reduce stigma or to enable them to interact succesfully with people living with the virus. Social workers admit that they lack knowledge about HIV and are not clear about their professional role in providing social assistance, which reduces their motivation to work with people living with HIV.

This issue in Kyrgyzstan arises due to the lack of close collaboration with practising organisations and the lack of employer involvement in improving educational programmes, which casts doubt on the formation of necessary competencies among students of social work. At the same time, it should be recognised that the concept of social workers' competence is a complex one, encompassing both skills and knowledge, and abilities acquired through specific practical experience (Malmberg-Heimonen et al., 2016).

One of the main barriers is also the low quality of education at universities. Due to the fact that teachers are not familiar enough with the problem of HIV/AIDS, education programmes may not adequately address social work with PLHIV (Natale et al., 2009). It would be beneficial for Kyrgyzstan to adopt a supervisory approach to education, which promotes an egalitarian approach that encourages the development of critical thinking among students. Some studies have noted the importance of communication between supervisors and students (Yeung et al., 2024). Supervision is one of the important factors in the development of social workers' professional competence (Malmberg-Heimonen et al., 2016). As the experience of some countries shows, it is possible to make significant improvements in education based on international best practices (Hines et al., 2015).

One of the significant challenges in training personnel to work with PLHIV is the low level of psychological readiness of students to deal with this vulnerable group. This also requires an increase in HIV/AIDS knowledge, development of empathy and emotional intelligence, as well as the study of legal and ethical aspects of work, etc. One study has pointed out that there is an urgent need to educate not only social work students about HIV, but also their teachers (Natale et al., 2009). Training a future social worker to be psychologically and professionally ready to work with people living with HIV is a long and complex process and consists of developing cognitive, motivational, and value-based attitudes towards the profession.

Weiner (1990) emphasises the importance of developing the entire curriculum, rather than just one course. Liakh (2014) highlights ways to overcome contradictions in the training of social workers. Both sources can serve as a guide for the development of similar training programmes for social students in Kyrgyzstan.

We can conclude that understanding the problem and increasing awareness about HIV are important factors in reducing stigmatisation towards people living with HIV. It can improve social workers' and social work students' attitudes towards people living with HIV if they have direct interaction and communication with them and if students also gain practical work experience. This combination is the key to ensuring that social workers are psychologically ready to provide professional assistance to people living with HIV.

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Ethical approval

The ethical approval was received on 3 March 2023 (Protocol No. 2) before conducting the study and as a result of discussing the design of the study. The Ethical and Scientific Council of BSU scientists, which

consists of 14 scientific experts, discussed and gave ethical approval to the study and recommended the further publication of a scientific article.

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Supplemental material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

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Voices of postgraduate social work students: Reflections on fertility and reproductive decision-making in the UAE

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Abstract
Low fertility is a growing concern in the UAE, yet theory-based research on fertility intentions is scarce. This qualitative study examines beliefs shaping fertility decisions among 29 Emirati postgraduate social work students. Findings highlight the influence of religion, culture, economics, and gender and stress the vital role of social workers in informing policies that reflect youth realities. These insights also enrich global understanding of how professional and sociocultural factors affect fertility in modernizing societies.

Keywords
Beliefs, fertility intention, qualitative, social worker, UAE

Like many other countries, the United Arab Emirates (UAE) has witnessed a notable decline in fertility rates, with the current rate falling below the replacement level of 2.1 children per woman (United Nations, 2025). Despite the government's pronatalist policies and the desire among young Emiratis to build large families (Shukla et al., 2023), the fertility rate remains low. While this trend may gradually lead to an aging population, it also highlights the importance of developing comprehensive social policies and a supportive infrastructure for families. By adopting a proactive

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approach, the UAE can manage these demographic shifts in a way that ensures social stability and the sustainability of economic development.

Extant research on this phenomenon has predominantly focused on socioeconomic factors. For example, delayed marriages and higher levels of female education have been cited as key factors contributing to the decline in the UAE's fertility rate (Al Awad and Chartouni, 2014). Becoming a parent, nevertheless, involves a series of individual decision-making processes. Without a grassroots understanding, bridging the gap between government policy and individual action becomes challenging.

Social workers have a long-standing tradition of addressing fertility-related challenges in a changing society; they play a crucial role in helping individuals navigate these issues and in shaping and advocating for effective public policies (Holbrook, 1990). In the Middle East, social workers focus on supporting women and children within a value-laden social milieu (Soliman, 2013). In the UAE, dedicated institutions such as the Ministry of Community Development, financial and social support programs, maternity leave policies, and the National Family Policy (Gueraiche, 2025) highlight the country's commitment to addressing these issues comprehensively. Despite these efforts, there is limited research on how Emirati social workers themselves perceive and contribute to these areas. Owing to their professional expertise, age appropriateness, and insider status, the perspectives of local social workers provide important insights into how young Emiratis make fertility-related decisions.

In this study, we used a classroom-based discussion among postgraduate social work students to explore young Emiratis' perspectives on low fertility in the UAE. The research addresses a pressing social issue – declining fertility – and fills a gap in the literature by applying the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB; Ajzen, 1991) in a Gulf context, where cultural and structural influences on reproductive decisions require further in-depth exploration. It also offers insights from a group uniquely positioned to reflect on both personal and professional implications of fertility trends. As future social workers, these participants are not only navigating their own reproductive choices but are also likely to engage with individuals, families, and communities facing similar dilemmas. Their perspectives offer grounded and experience-based understanding of how cultural beliefs and values surrounding fertility intersect with structural and societal challenges in everyday life. They also highlight the potential role of social work in delivering culturally sensitive support and contributing to thoughtful policy development.

Theoretical background

To guide our investigation of individual perceptions of fertility, we use the TPB (Ajzen, 1991) as the theoretical framework. As an established theory in social science, the TPB posits that a behavior is determined briefly by three types of underlying considerations: behavioral beliefs, normative beliefs, and control beliefs (Ajzen, 1991). In the context of childbearing intentions, behavioral beliefs refer to the perceived advantages and disadvantages of having a child; normative beliefs pertain to the important social referents – such as family members or close friends – who approve or disapprove of having a child; and control beliefs involve factors that either facilitate or hinder the decision to have a child (for a complete theoretical elaboration, see Ajzen and Klobas, 2013).

As demonstrated by Ajzen and Klobas (2013), the TPB is highly applicable to the study of childbearing intentions. This is particularly relevant in contexts like the UAE, where cultural and religious norms shape fertility behaviors that are more deliberate and within marriage. However, to our knowledge, TPB-based studies on childbearing have not been undertaken in the UAE.

Analyzing behavioral and control beliefs concerning fertility intentions allows us to understand the specific enablers and barriers that influence Emiratis' decisions to have children.

Methodology

Our study used a qualitative design in the form of a classroom-based focus group. We chose focus groups as an efficient qualitative approach to generate sensitive themes aligned with our research focus (Guest et al., 2017). Twenty-nine master's degree students (24 women, 5 men; mostly unmarried) in social work participated in the discussion at the University of Sharjah, UAE. Participants were informed 1 week in advance about the purpose of this focus group and their participation; no incentive was involved. The session was facilitated by the first author, a native Arabic speaker, with the assistance of a female doctoral student – the third author – who is also a native Arabic speaker.

The discussion was held in a classroom on 9 April 2025. Participants were free to express their opinions, provided they showed respect for others – for example, by refraining from interrupting while someone else was speaking. As part of the educational experience, participants also learned about and observed the process of conducting qualitative research. Although the session took place in a classroom setting, the atmosphere was supportive and informal. Students expressed their enjoyment of the experience and appreciation for being involved. Participants were informed about the research purpose, anonymity, and confidentiality, again, before the data collection. Each participant gave verbal consent and willingly participated in the focus group discussions.

Following previous TPB-based belief-elicitation studies (e.g. Zhao et al., 2018), we used nine questions to elicit the following beliefs:

- **Behavioral beliefs**. What are the expected *benefits* and *drawbacks* of having a child within the next 3 years?
- **Normative beliefs**. Who are the people or organizations that would *support* or *oppose* this choice?
- **Control beliefs**. What factors may *facilitate* or *hinder* this decision?

In addition, we also gave space to participants to discuss any other worries or thoughts around childbearing, if not covered by the TPB beliefs. We deemed that data saturation had been reached when no new thoughts or themes emerged in the focus group.

All discussions were undertaken in Arabic. To mitigate potential biases related to procedural design and researcher influence, we employed open-ended and neutral questions to encourage authentic and uninfluenced participant responses. A mixed-gender discussion format also served as an informal form of member checking, allowing participants to hear and reflect on diverse perspectives in real time. Moreover, reflexive dialogues were conducted throughout the research process by the three co-authors – who represent different nationalities, genders, and marital and fertility statuses – to critically examine their positionalities and challenge potential assumptions or biases in data interpretation. The third author translated the data into English and thematically coded the data (Peel, 2020). The first author double-checked the translations to make sure they were conceptually equivalent and semantically accurate to the original responses. Both first and second authors verified the themes according to the English translation. As shown in the next section, we observed gender and extended family as a salient theme beyond the TPB domains; thus, they were coded in a separate theme. Participants were informed about the purpose of this study and agreed to partake in the focus group. The study has been approved by the university's ethics committee (ref.: REC-25-02-19-01F) before data collection.

Table 1. Salient beliefs based on the Theory of Planned Behavior.

Domain	Specific content
Behavioral beliefs	**Advantages:** Emotional fulfillment and companionship Meeting family expectations Long-term care and support by offspring **Disadvantages:** Concerns about financial burden, career disruption, parenting burnout, and emotional readiness Fear of disability and reduced life enjoyment
Normative beliefs	Perceived expectations from parents, family elders, siblings, spouse, friends, and work circle Social influence from both personal and professional networks
Control beliefs	**Enablers:** Financial incentives (e.g., monthly incentives), religious motivation, government support (healthcare, education), maternity leave, and emotional benefits like avoiding loneliness **Barriers:** High costs, poor childcare support, lack of parental help, cultural influences, and life responsibilities

Results

TPB domains

As summarized in Table 1, a range of specific beliefs within the TPB domains have been identified in the focus group. Childbearing in the UAE is widely regarded as a key means of fulfilling family duties, religious values, and cultural traditions, as shown in advantages and enablers. 'Children infuse the home with energy and joy'. This quote from one informant highlights the value of child members in Emirati families. Even for participants who already had a child, increasing children is believed to bring companionship for existing family members, as demonstrated in the following quote, 'My daughter needs a sister'. It is also noteworthy that participants pointed to a variety of incentives supporting childbearing, including financial support, healthcare, as well as maternity leave and breastfeeding hours during the first 2 years after childbirth.

In contrast, constraints and concerns were also reported, as disadvantages and barriers. The financial burden regarding childrearing costs was highlighted. Lack of support for domestic work from other family members and related parental burnout were also mentioned, as one participant said, 'there's no one to help me'. Another type of concerns centers on the conflicts with individual development. An informant simply said, 'I can't stop my studies'. Many participants resonated with the concern that childrearing could lead to potential career disruptions, which was frequently reported during the discussions.

In terms of normative beliefs, participants identified a broad range of individuals who supported their decision to have children, including family members, friends, and colleagues. Few disapproving voices were mentioned during the focus group discussions. For instance, disapproval was only noted when childbearing led to work-related inconveniences, such as the need for colleagues or managers to adjust schedules.

Other findings: Gender and extended family

Gender has been a central issue throughout the discussion. First, women are expected to fulfill both domestic and professional roles. 'Women should stay home with the baby' – as demonstrated in this quote from a male informant, the Emirati society assigns domestic affairs to mothers rather than fathers, which contradicts some women's career developments. As a female participant said, 'Even if I have a long leave, I'll return to work'. This quote clearly emphasized the importance of maintaining a professional identity and returning to work postpartum – even if she had the option to take a long maternity leave. Second, while participants often expressed a preference for gender-balanced families with both sons and daughters, male children were generally perceived as having greater value. Some hoped to have another child specifically if their first child is a girl. This perception is partly influenced by cultural and social considerations, including the common belief that land and resources may be allocated preferentially to male offspring, even though this does not reflect any formal government policy.

In addition, given the polygyny system in the UAE, where a man may marry up to four wives, some female participants viewed childbearing as a strategy to strengthen their marital bonds. 'I'll have as many children as it takes – just no second wife'. As this quote illustrates, for some women, having children is seen not only as a personal or familial goal but also as a means of securing their position within the marriage and discouraging their husbands from taking additional wives.

Discussion

With theory-based focus group discussions, our study identified important beliefs underlying fertility intentions among young Emiratis. A clear pro-child norm has been identified across beliefs: a family with multiple children is the ideal structure in the UAE, consistent with their religious and cultural values, as well as family expectations. While prior research has shown that Emiratis often report high ideal numbers of children – prompting scholars to emphasize the need to strengthen and expand existing child-friendly policies to better support families and reduce the gap between these ideals and actual fertility rates (Karabchuk et al., 2022; Shukla et al., 2023) – our findings reveal more systematic concerns related to parenting, financial stability, and personal development.

A noticeable value-behavior gap exists between young Emiratis' cultural ideal of having large families and their delayed or limited reproductive practices. While they continue to affirm traditional familial ideals in principle, their lived experiences are increasingly shaped by modern lifestyle constraints. As our findings indicate, individualistic choices – such as the pursuit of higher education, career advancement, and personal well-being – often take precedence over collective family expectations. This shift is further reinforced by a consumer-oriented culture that emphasizes autonomy and quality of life. These lifestyle changes are also reshaping expectations around childbearing and parenting. For example, participants expressed concerns about the quality of domestic childcare, particularly regarding the reliance on foreign nannies, reflecting anxieties over cultural transmission.

Women's individual agency in childbearing emerges as a significant finding. While Muslim culture traditionally encourages large families, reproductive behaviors are increasingly shaped by a range of socioeconomic factors, including national economic conditions, state policies, and women's access to education (Goldstone, 2010). As Hughes (2011) observes, modern women in Arabic societies are increasingly prioritizing the quality of their children's lives over the quantity, often reinterpreting and integrating traditional religious values into their reproductive decision-making. Similarly, our participants expressed concerns about the potential burdens of parenthood, particularly the disruption it may pose to their personal and professional aspirations. Emirati

women, with access to higher education and employment, are now able to secure social resources outside the institution of marriage. In contrast, marriage and motherhood are often perceived as entailing significant sacrifice and responsibility. Notably, the participants – who are highly educated – also voiced concerns about the health risks associated with consanguineous marriage, a long-standing practice rooted in Arab cultural traditions (Al-Gazali et al., 1997; Alfeel et al., 2025).

Conclusion

The TPB proves to be a suitable framework for examining childbearing decisions among young Emiratis, aligning with the insights of Ajzen and Klobas (2013). The findings reveal a clear ambivalence embedded within individual reproductive beliefs. On the one hand, participants express symbolic affirmation of traditional familial ideals; on the other, they exhibit structural reliance on modern lifestyles. This tension does not signal an abandonment of tradition, but rather an adaptive response to shifting lifestyle patterns and contemporary socioeconomic realities.

Building on the three categories of salient beliefs outlined in the TPB, pro-childbearing policies in the UAE could be further refined to address the nuanced factors shaping reproductive decision-making. Parenthood is often perceived by young Emiratis as both emotionally and practically burdensome. Therefore, public messaging should emphasize the long-term emotional and practical benefits of having children, such as intergenerational care and family continuity. Given that contemporary social networks increasingly support individual development and delayed family formation, it is essential to foster a more family-friendly workplace culture that better supports young parents.

While the UAE already offers substantial structural incentives, practical barriers and lifestyle constraints continue to hinder the translation of intentions into action. Accordingly, more targeted and culturally responsive strategies are needed. For example, neighborhood childcare networks could be developed in partnership with local mosques or cultural centers, and family counseling centers could be established to address parental stress and burnout.

Social workers are uniquely positioned to play a central role in this ecosystem. Their training in cultural competence, family dynamics, and community-based intervention equips them to bridge the gap between policy and practice. From providing direct support to advocating for systemic change, social workers can help ensure that reproductive choices are supported, respected, and sustainable within the Emirati context. Moreover, while this study is situated in the UAE, its insights have broader relevance. Many societies worldwide are grappling with low fertility, value shifts, and the challenge of balancing tradition with modernity. The Emirati case adds a culturally grounded perspective from the Global South, contributing to a more inclusive understanding of fertility transitions in rapidly modernizing societies.

Given that this study focused on a sample composed of highly educated social work students, its findings should be interpreted with caution in terms of generalizability. However, the choice of this group also constitutes a unique strength of the study. As future practitioners and policy advocates, social work students offer informed, critically reflective perspectives on reproductive decision-making within the Emirati context – insights that may not be captured in general population surveys. Moreover, this study has opened the door for future research on a broader scale, through which more generalizable findings can be obtained. Their dual identity as both youth and emerging professionals allows for a more nuanced understanding of the values and tensions shaping fertility intentions in a transitional society. At the same time, the sample's demographic homogeneity – particularly in terms of education level and professional orientation – limits the extent to which findings can be extrapolated to the broader Emirati youth population. This limitation was anticipated during the study design phase given the exploratory nature and qualitative methodology. The

decision to proceed with this sample was guided by practical constraints (e.g. access, feasibility) and the intention to generate theory-informed insights that could inform larger-scale follow-up studies. Future research would benefit from quantitative approaches with larger, more socioeconomically diverse samples to assess the broader prevalence and variation of the attitudes, norms, and perceived barriers discussed here. Such follow-up studies could help validate the emerging themes identified and refine culturally sensitive, evidence-informed family policies.

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Ethical approval

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Statement on AI

The authors declare that they have not used any type of generative artificial intelligence for the writing of this manuscript.

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Statement on data availability

Due to the qualitative nature of the research, supporting data are not available.

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Digitalization in social work practices for displaced populations: A field practice example from Al-Bab, Syria

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Abstract
This study reflects the practical experiences of a social worker in the planning and implementation of the digital transformation of the provision of cash, food, non-food aid, and psychosocial support services by civil society organizations to displaced groups after the Syrian Civil War, taking a rights-based and transparent approach. The study also demonstrates how services become more inclusive, accessible, and accountable through the digitalization of brokers, one of the unique roles of social work in social work practices for displaced populations.

Keywords
Digitalization, displacement, rights based, social work practice, transparency

Introduction

Following the civil war that began in Syria in 2011, approximately 4.9 million people have sought refuge in neighboring countries, 6.8 million have been internally displaced, and 13.5 million need humanitarian assistance (Kampalath et al., 2024). After the civil war, Syrian territory was governed for a long time in an environment of political uncertainty under the control of the Bashar al-Assad regime, the YPG, and armed groups supported by Turkey. At the end of 2024, the country's administration was transferred to a new administration led by Ahmet SHARA after the overthrow of Bashar Al-Assad. The Republic of Turkey conducted four separate military operations in northern Syria between 2016 and 2019 to ensure border security and consolidate areas of control of the armed groups supporting it. Following military operations, cities on the Turkish border were liberated from ISIS and YPG, and safe zones were established in the region. Following these operations, many civilians who fled areas controlled by the regime, ISIS, and YPG took refuge in 'safe zones' under Turkish control. With the Euphrates Shield Operation carried out in 2016, the city of Al-Bab was cleared of ISIS and left to the administration of armed groups supported by Turkey and local councils. Today, Al-Bab is under the administrative responsibility of local councils under the security supervision of armed groups supported by Turkey, and the process of transferring it to the

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central government is still ongoing. Many displaced civilians in the city live in camps, irregular settlements outside the camps, and the city center. After 2016, social workers assigned by Turkey contributed to the coordination of humanitarian aid by providing consultancy to social service directorates working under local councils. This study is based on the author's field practice experience, who was assigned as a social work consultant to the city of Al-Bab by the Gaziantep Governorate from 2021 to 2023. This study includes field studies on the planning, implementation, and evaluation of the transition to a digital system for the provision of cash transfers, food, non-food aid, and psychosocial support services by international organizations.

Why digitalization?

The Syrian Civil War is one of the most devastating humanitarian crises of the 21st century. Millions of people have been displaced and face multidimensional needs, such as shelter, food, water, health, and psychosocial and legal support (Kešeljević and Spruk, 2024). Non-governmental organizations (NGOs) work in many parts of Syria to meet the complex needs of displaced people (Alhousseiny and Atar, 2021). To respond to the multidimensional needs of the displaced population in the cities of Northern Syria controlled by Türkiye, UN agencies and various civil society organizations have launched comprehensive humanitarian aid programs since 2016. These programs include cash aid, provision of food and non-food materials, and psychosocial support services for older adults. Civil society organizations first started their aid activities by receiving approval from Turkish authorities and then from the Al-Bab Local Council. In the final stage, implementation is initiated after planning meetings are held with the participation of the local social services directorate, relevant civil society organizations, and a social service consultant assigned from Turkey. During this process, I served as a social service specialist and participated in assistance planning meetings held at the Social Services Directorate, in accordance with the standard workflow. I followed the application process within the Directorate and conducted applicant interviews, home visits, registrations, and filing procedures. In addition, through my field observations in camp areas and scattered settlements outside the camps and city center, I identified the difficulties that displaced individuals face in their daily lives. In this context, I observed that access to food, cash, and other basic needs was inadequate. It was determined that economic activities were quite limited in the city center and rural areas, where approximately 230,000 people live, and that a large population made their living only with government assistance. As of 2024, the number of people benefiting from this assistance is 9216, most of whom were disabled individuals and women. As a result of my 5-month evaluation process, I found various structural problems with the current assistance systems. The data-recording system of the Social Services Directorate was found to be inadequate in terms of security and accessibility. There was duplication in aid distribution; aid was focused on certain regions and individuals, and many people in need could not receive it. It was also determined that the principles of transparency and accountability were damaged by the manipulation of aid processes by armed groups and civil society organizations. These problems were reported to Turkish authorities and local council administrators through complaints on social media and case studies from the field. After a long negotiation and persuasion process, the decision to switch to a digital social service system was made. The program content was determined in three workshops attended by representatives of civil society organizations, social workers, and software developers.

Practice

The digital transformation process in social services consists of three main stages: the development of a web-based program, pilot implementation of the system, and integration of existing records

into the new digital infrastructure by verifying them through field studies. In the first stage, individuals in need of assistance were classified into four basic categories in line with the outputs of previously held workshops: widows/orphans, disabled, elderly, and homeless individuals. The web-based software design process was based on this classification system. Owing to the intensity of assistance applications and the limited resources available, an evaluation system was developed to determine the priority level for each application on an individual basis. In this system, applicants were prioritized at three levels: '1: most urgent', '2: urgent', and '3: normal'. The prototype of the program, financed by the local council, was completed in 2 months. The software was structured to collect basic data, such as the applicant's identity, application type, information about the individuals they live with, and their income status. In the second stage, a pilot application of the developed software was initiated. Within this scope, new applications belonging to these four categories were entered into the system. The trial period evaluated the technical adequacy of the system and included a 3-month test period, including components such as data storage capacity, simultaneous data entry, system stability, and software bug fixing. In the final stage, after the software was technically stabilized, a comprehensive field study was conducted to capture new records and ensure the accuracy of the existing records. The aim of this process was to update records through home visits, and additional personnel were employed for this purpose. The employed personnel were trained in social investigation techniques, effective communication methods, and software usage. During the implementation process, the field teams conducted home visits for at least 4 days a week. My direct participation in these field activities increased the motivation of the personnel and reinforced the trust of local government representatives, civil society organizations, and applicants. The transition to the new digital system was successfully completed in approximately 15 months, including the verification of previous records through on-site visits, removal of duplicate records from the system, and integration of new applications into the system in the same way (Table 1).

Table 1. From recording to monitoring: the digital transformation process in humanitarian aid for displaced populations.

Stage	Description
1. Digital registration	At the social service center, all past and current assistance files have been transferred to a digital format, and beneficiaries' personal, household, and income information has been systematically documented.
2. Evaluation process	Data at the social service center were examined for consistency and completeness, and inaccuracies, such as duplicate payments within the same assistance category, were identified and rectified.
3. Identification of assistance type and priority through field verification	Based on the social assessments conducted during home visits, all applications were categorized as widows/orphans, persons with disabilities, the elderly, and the homeless, and prioritized as 1 (most urgent), 2 (urgent), or 3 (normal).
4. Approval and social assistance implementation	The applications were examined and approved by a committee comprising representatives from NGOs, officials from the Social Services Directorate, and social service consultants, and suitable aid was subsequently provided.
5. Monitoring and evaluation	NGO officials submitted monthly reports on their assistance activities to the Social Services Directorate. Furthermore, the data were updated based on the conclusion of the assistance program, including transfers or terminations contingent on the availability of new funding.

Conclusion

The effectiveness of social assistance programs for displaced persons is critical, especially given the limited resources and increasing needs. Digital transformation processes offer significant opportunities to increase the accessibility and efficiency of social services (Latupeirissa et al., 2024). However, considering the special conditions and vulnerabilities of displaced individuals, it is imperative to distribute limited social assistance resources accurately, fairly, and based on need (Taye et al., 2024). Web-based systems provide significant advantages in this context by accelerating application processes, making prioritization mechanisms transparent, and increasing data accuracy through field verification processes. However, the sustainability of digitalization practices depends on strengthening technical infrastructure, adequately equipping field personnel in social investigation and technology use, and maintaining ethical standards (Lowe et al., 2023). In particular, effective management of limited social assistance resources requires a strategic and holistic approach to ensure that displaced people have access to their basic needs while reducing the risk of social exclusion (Lister, 2021). The digital transformation implemented in the Turkish-controlled city of Al-Bab in Northern Syria by the end of 2024 emerged as a model initiative to support rights-based access to social services for displaced populations in Syria. The social work profession plays a critical role in addressing the multidimensional and complex needs of displaced individuals, highlighting a major global issue. As illustrated in the case of Al-Bab, the social work profession's unique broker role can make services more inclusive, accessible, and accountable through the use of digital tools. This study highlights the guiding contributions of digitalization in social work practices for displaced populations, a current global issue that can enhance client well-being.

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Data availability statement

The author confirms that the data supporting the findings of this study are available within the article [and/or] its supplementary materials.

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Factors influencing the turnover intention of social workers: A meta-analysis

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Abstract
The high turnover rate of social workers is an extremely serious problem. This meta-analysis comprehensively examines the predictors of turnover intention among social workers, synthesising findings from 29 studies involving 34,071 participants. The results of the study show that social workers' turnover intention is more related to job content and work environment factors. We also propose a framework for predicting the strength of the relationship between predictors and turnover intention, aiming to help social work researchers and practitioners better understand turnover intention and retain social workers.

Keywords
Job satisfaction, meta-analysis, social worker, turnover intention, work attitudes

Introduction

The social work profession plays a vital role in addressing the needs of vulnerable populations by providing essential services that promote well-being and social justice. Despite the significance of social work, it is worrying that existing studies have observed high turnover and departure among social workers. The high turnover rate within an industry or organisation often indicates significant underlying issues that may ultimately pose a serious threat to its growth and development. For example, institutions may face vacancy issues owing to the challenges of recruiting suitable staff

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in the short term (Jiang et al., 2019), affecting the continuity and quality of care provided to clients (Cho and Song, 2017). The negative perceptions associated with high turnover also hinder the organisation's ability to attract and retain social workers, thereby presenting a potential risk to its long-term sustainability. Unusually high turnover rates among social workers have, thus, become a pressing concern for academics and managers.

Although numerous researchers have investigated social workers' turnover intentions and their associated factors across various countries and regions, and have reviewed previous studies in the literature, previous research on turnover intention has been fragmented; each study has examined the relationship between social workers' turnover intention and individual or a few selected antecedents, without systematically integrating the current body of research findings. Existing studies vary in sample size, measurement methods, and research approaches, leading to differences in the magnitude and direction of the impact of antecedent conditions on turnover intention. Our aim is to synthesise the existing literature on social workers' turnover intentions by conducting the most comprehensive meta-analysis of the predictive factors influencing these intentions. By comparing the effect sizes of various predictors, we seek to overcome the limitations of previous individual studies – such as small sample sizes, selection biases and measurement errors. This will enable a comprehensive understanding of the turnover issue within this profession.

Specifically, the objectives of this research were (1) to comprehensively search and summarise empirical studies on the predictors of social workers' turnover intention, (2) to employ meta-analytical methods to examine the relationship between social workers' turnover intentions and the predictive factors, and (3) to rank all variables according to the magnitude of their effect sizes and constructed integrated framework of the predictors of social workers' turnover intention.

Method

Theoretical framework

To better understand social workers' turnover intention, scholars have employed multiple theoretical perspectives to examine the phenomenon of mobility within the social work profession. Such as the job demands-resources model (Kim and Stoner, 2008), social exchange theory, and the Price-Mueller model (Lee and Mitchell, 1994; Price, 2001). Abner et al. (2017) refer to these theories as middle-range theories, which are sufficiently specific to generate testable hypotheses. Unlike theoretical models such as the Price-Mueller model, the Steers and Mowday model is a comprehensive theoretical framework that integrates various factors influencing employee turnover. It considers job expectations, affective responses to the job, intention to leave, and actual turnover behaviour, emphasising the impact of non-work variables on turnover intention (Steers and Mowday, 1981). To integrate and organise the extensive body of literature concerning the turnover intentions of social workers, this study classified all predictive factors of social worker turnover intention based on the Steers and Mowday model, as illustrated in Table 1.

Literature search and inclusion criteria

We searched for relevant studies on turnover intention among social workers that were published before 2025. Databases such as PsycINFO, Scopus and the Web of Science Core Collection were searched. The search terms used were a combination of 'social workers', 'turnover', 'attrition', 'leave', 'quit intention', and 'turnover intention'. To establish the credibility and authority of this research, only papers published in Social Science Citation Index (SSCI, JCR 2023) journals were included; conference papers, non-SSCI papers and unpublished papers were excluded. The initial

Table 1. Classification of predictors of social workers' turnover intention (organised based on existing literature and theoretical frameworks to inform the meta-analytic coding of the later paper).

Antecedents	Predictors
Demographic Characteristics	Family Situation
	Position
	Age
	Organisation Tenure
	Education
	Gender
Work Attitudes	Job Satisfaction
	Organisational Commitment
	Professional Identity
	Professional Achievement
	Burnout
Job Characteristics	Work–Family Conflict
	Role Conflict
	Workload
	Role Ambiguity
Organisational Characteristics	Organisational Climate
	Internal Fairness
	Job Communication
	Job Support
	Work Autonomy
Human Resource Management (HRM) Practices	Career Development
	Salary Package
	Management Style

screening yielded a sample of 213 articles. After reading the titles and abstracts, 11 duplicate papers and 5 papers unrelated to the research topic were removed, leaving a total of 197 papers.

We carefully read and searched the full text of the remaining 197 papers. Of these, 33 non-empirical studies were excluded. Studies that met the following criteria were included in the meta-analysis: (1) the subjects of the study were current or former social work personnel; (2) the study reported at least one antecedent of turnover tendency, along with its correlation or regression coefficient, providing complete data for calculating effect sizes; and (3) the study was written in English. Through this procedure, 29 independent studies were identified that reported the correlations between 191 antecedents and turnover intention.

Meta-analytical procedures

The meta-analysis process in this study involved the following seven steps: (1) in cases where studies did not report correlation coefficients, conversion formulas were used to calculate them (Barak et al., 2001; Peterson and Brown, 2005); (2) the correlations between predictors and turnover intention within the same category were aggregated; (3) sampling errors were estimated and corrected to obtain the average true score correlation; (4) we followed the classical attenuation correction formula proposed by Hunter and Schmidt (2004); (5) confidence intervals (CIs) were calculated to determine the credibility of effect sizes (Cohen, 1993); (6) the variance caused by sampling error and other human factors was subtracted, and the remaining variance was used as an estimate of the

total variance (Taft et al., 2011); and (7) according to the guidelines of Kooij et al. (2010), average correlations of 0.1, 0.3, and 0.5 or higher were interpreted as small, medium, and large effects, respectively.

Results

Table 2 presents the results of the meta-analysis of the predictors of social workers' turnover intention.

Demographic characteristics

Family situation (ρ = –0.207; 95% CI = –0.228 to –0.104), position (ρ = –0.203; 95% CI = –0.185 to –0.158), organisation tenure (ρ = –0.039; 95% CI = –0.061 to –0.008), and age (ρ = –0.152; 95% CI = –0.150 to –0.116) were significant negatively correlated with turnover intention. Educational level (ρ = 0.097; 95% CI = 0.064 to 0.107) was significantly positively correlated with turnover intention. The 95% CI for gender included zero, indicating that the result was not significant.

Work attitudes

Job satisfaction (ρ = –0.520; 95% CI = –0.447 to –0.422), organisational commitment (ρ = –0.377; 95% CI = –0.324 to –0.284), professional identity (ρ = –0.311; 95% CI = –0.291 to –0.229), and sense of professional achievement (ρ = –0.084; 95% CI = 0.044 to 0.088) were significantly negatively correlated with turnover intention. Burnout (ρ = 0.399; 95% CI = 0.311 to 0.331) was significant positively correlated with turnover intention.

Job characteristics

The results showed that four job characteristic variables – work–family conflict, role conflict, workload and role ambiguity – were significantly positively correlated with turnover intention. Among these, work–family conflict (ρ = 0.307) had a moderate effect size, role conflict (ρ = 0.145) and workload (ρ = 0.122) had small effect sizes, and the effect size for role ambiguity (ρ = 0.064) was negligible.

Organisational characteristics

The meta-analysis results for the five organisational characteristic variables, all of which were significantly negatively correlated with turnover intention. The internal fairness (ρ = –0.300) exhibited a moderate effect size, while organisational climate (ρ = –0.279), job communication (ρ = –0.213), job support (ρ = –0.200), and job autonomy (ρ = –0.106) had smaller effect sizes.

Human resource management

The three human resource management (HRM) variables were career development, salary packaging and management style. Career development (ρ = –0.303; 95% CI = –0.270 to –0.236), management style (ρ = –0.202; 95% CI = –0.177 to –0.135), and salary package (ρ = –0.125; 95% CI = –0.122 to –0.084) were significant negatively correlated with turnover intention.

Table 2. Results of meta-analysis after coding of included articles (sample population: 29 studies involving 34,071 participants, method: excerpts from the incorporated literature, date/ time: as of 4 April 2025).

Variable name	k	n	$\bar{r}$	ρ	SDρ	95% confidence interval	Var. expl.	95% credibility interval	Q statistics
Demographic Characteristics									
Family Situation	3	936	0.802	–0.207	0.031	–0.228 to –0.104	14.872	–0.532 to 0.118	20.20*
Position	7	20,884	0.844	–0.203	0.006	–0.185 to –0.158	1.951	–0.527 to 0.120	359.11*
Age	13	12,697	0.875	–0.152	0.009	–0.150 to –0.116	29.018	–0.264 to –0.040	44.82*
Education	6	8342	0.878	0.097	0.012	0.064 to 0.107	46.465	0.033 to 0.162	12.92*
Organisation Tenure	8	5450	0.879	–0.039	0.014	–0.061 to –0.008	16.297	–0.232 to 0.155	49.10*
Gender	5	7928	0.898	0.017	0.011	–0.007 to 0.037	4.765	–0.228 to 0.262	104.92*
Work Attitudes									
Job Satisfaction	16	17,202	0.835	–0.520	0.006	–0.447 to –0.422	10.573	–0.742 to –0.299	148.87*
Burnout	21	30,415	0.806	0.399	0.005	0.311 to 0.331	3.400	–0.026 to 0.823	585.05*
Organisational Commitment	7	7966	0.804	–0.377	0.010	–0.324 to –0.284	3.601	–0.782 to 0.027	195.77*
Professional Identity	5	3426	0.837	–0.311	0.015	–0.291 to –0.229	22.392	–0.476 to –0.145	22.34*
Professional Achievement	5	7808	0.783	–0.084	0.011	0.044 to 0.088	2.712	–0.300 to 0.468	182.34*
Job Characteristics									
Work–Family Conflict	5	7186	0.787	0.307	0.011	0.219 to 0.263	5.443	0.025 to 0.589	91.28*
Role Conflict	9	7270	0.767	0.145	0.011	0.089 to 0.134	15.233	–0.073 to 0.362	59.13*
Workload	12	7225	0.788	0.122	0.011	0.073 to 0.119	6.968	–0.2494 to 0.492	172.10*
Role Ambiguity	7	9815	0.755	0.064	0.010	0.028 to 0.068	16.202	–0.094 to 0.223	43.24*
Organisational Characteristics									
Internal Fairness	8	3951	0.866	–0.300	0.013	–0.287 to –0.233	15.645	–0.534 to 0.066	63.85*
Organisational Climate	3	11,957	0.774	–0.279	0.008	–0.233 to –0.199	29.897	–0.342 to –0.217	10.04*
Job Communication	5	2052	0.811	–0.213	0.021	–0.215 to –0.131	23.518	–0.425 to –0.002	21.26*
Job Support	20	20,865	0.811	–0.200	0.007	–0.175 to –0.149	13.044	–0.403 to 0.003	168.30*
Job Autonomy	5	7453	0.787	–0.106	0.011	–0.106 to –0.059	7.719	–0.315 to 0.102	51.95*
HRM Predictors									
Career Development	8	10,933	0.837	–0.303	0.009	–0.270 to –0.236	2.846	–0.699 to 0.093	271.20*
Salary Package	10	10,494	0.824	–0.125	0.009	–0.122 to –0.084	24.482	–0.253 to 0.004	40.84*
Management Style	11	8498	0.770	–0.202	0.010	–0.177 to –0.135	13.245	–0.437 to 0.032	82.05*

k = the number of studies; samples; *n* = the number of individuals in the k samples; $\bar{r}$ = sample-size-weighted uncorrected correlation; ρ = mean true score correlation; SDρ = standard deviation of true score correlation; 95% confidence interval (95% CI) = 95% confidence interval for ρ; Var.expl. = percentage of variance in corrected correlations attributable to all the artefacts considered; 95% Credibility Interval = 95% credibility interval for ρ; Q Statistic = chi-square test for demographic predictors.
*$p < 0.05$.

Table 3. Ordered by effect size of predictors of social worker turnover intention.

Effect size	Demographic characteristics	Work attitudes	Job characteristics	Organisational characteristics	HRM
>0.5					
		Job satisfaction –0.520			
0.3–0.5					
		Burnout 0.399			
		Organisational commitment –0.377			
		Professional identity –0.311	Work–family conflict 0.307	Internal fairness –0.300	Career development –0.303
0.1–0.3					
	Family situation –0.207			Organisational culture –0.279	
	Position –0.203			Job communication –0.213	
	Age –0.152		Role conflict 0.145	Job support –0.200	Management style –0.202
			Workload 0.122	Job autonomy –0.106	Salary package –0.125
<0.1					
	Organisation tenure –0.039	Professional achievement –0.084	Role ambiguity 0.064		
	Education 0.017				

Discussion

This meta-analysis of 191 effect sizes from 29 studies involving 34,071 social workers integrated disparate research results to compare the effect sizes of various predictors reported in the literature, providing a reliable and robust effect estimate and clarifying their relative importance in predicting turnover intention among social workers, helping to address the confusion and inconsistencies in the literature, and offering a clear prioritisation and reference benchmark for subsequent research.

Based on the meta-analysis results, this study has developed an integrated framework of factors influencing social workers' turnover intentions, as shown in Table 3. Table 3 indicates that most variables showed minor effect sizes, with corrected correlations ranging from 0.1 to 0.3. Job satisfaction was the strongest predictor of turnover intention, with a corrected correlation coefficient exceeding 0.5. However, it is important to note that job satisfaction is a composite indicator that encompasses various aspects of social workers' professional and personal lives. Factors such as burnout and low salaries can directly reduce social workers' job satisfaction, consequently influencing their turnover intention (Senreich et al., 2020). In other words, although job satisfaction is

the strongest predictor of turnover intention, it is important to also focus on the influence of other factors on turnover intention.

Demographic characteristics were not strong predictors of turnover intention, and the meta-analysis revealed a weak correlation between these variables and turnover intention. Regarding work attitudes, job satisfaction, organisational commitment and burnout were strong predictors of turnover intention among social workers. Regarding job characteristics, an interesting finding is that the effect size of work–family conflict (n = 5), which has previously received little attention, is higher than that of role ambiguity (n = 7) and role conflict (n = 9). Role ambiguity and role conflict are primarily confined to the work environment, work–family conflict involves clashes between two domains, making it more likely to cause emotional fatigue and even directly threaten quality of life and well-being. As a result, work–family conflict exerts a stronger influence on turnover intentions.

With regard to HRM, career development, management style and salary showed significant correlations with turnover intention. We found that career development has the strongest effect on turnover intention, with salary having a weaker effect. However, this does not imply that social workers are unconcerned with their salaries. The weak effect size may be linked to other moderating factors in the relationship between salary package and turnover intention. A more plausible explanation is that in choosing this career path, social workers are often aware that their compensation will be lower than that in other similar professions (such as doctors and lawyers). Social workers often enter the profession due to intrinsic motivations such as a desire to help others and pursue a meaningful career. These intrinsic factors can overshadow the influence of extrinsic rewards like pay (Luo and Chui, 2020). Previous research also supports the argument that non-material incentives often have a more profound impact on employees' willingness to stay with an organisation than salary alone (Dewhurst et al., 2009).

Overall, this study helps shift the research focus to predictors that have previously received little attention from academia and management. For instance, only five of the reviewed studies included work–family conflict, and only seven incorporated organisational commitment. However, we found that the sizes of the effects of work–family conflict and organisational commitment on turnover intention were higher than those of workload (k = 9) and job support (k = 20). This suggests that when investigating turnover intention among social workers, more attention should be paid to factors that significantly influence their work attitudes and behaviours, rather than solely focusing on traditional work characteristics.

Conclusion

This study presents the first comprehensive meta-analysis of predictors of turnover intention among social workers, synthesising findings from 29 studies and 191 effect sizes involving a total of 34,071 participants. The results underscore the multifaceted nature of turnover intention, with job satisfaction emerging as the strongest predictor. However, this analysis also highlights the significance of organisational commitment, burnout, work–family conflict and career development opportunities in shaping turnover intention. By developing an integrated framework of factors influencing turnover intention, this study provides an evidence-based reference for both academic research and organisational management.

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Informed consent

Informed consent was not required as the study did not involve human participants.

Statement on AI

Anything produced by AI must be validated by the authors. The author declares that no AI tools were used in the preparation of this article.

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Statement on data availability

The datasets generated during and/or analysed during the current study are available from the corresponding author on reasonable request.

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The challenges of contextualization: Critical reflections on communicating local value within a global study

Katheryn Margaret Pascoe[1] and Nicky Stanley-Clarke[2]

Abstract

International social work research and global collaborations offer opportunities to share knowledge, better understand social problems, engage in comparative analysis and work collectively to examine possible solutions. This Research Note reports on key lessons learnt from leading the Aotearoa New Zealand branch of a global study focused on working conditions and well-being of social workers. Addressing contextual differences including language and expression, local partnerships and ethical considerations, the critical reflections share strategies used in the pursuit of respecting diversity while communicating local value within a global study.

Keywords

global collaboration, globalization, international research, international social work, localization

Introduction

The Global Agenda for Social Work and Social Development stresses the importance of international collaboration, solidarity and global connectedness in achieving 'sustainable futures that highlight responsibility between all peoples and environment' and is described as central to facilitating 'universal rights, opportunities, freedom and sustainable wellbeing for all people nationally, regionally and globally' (International Association of Schools of Social Work; International Council on Social Welfare and International Federation of Social Workers, 2020: 5). Reinforced by Ife (2001), globalization has been argued as affecting all aspects of social work, whereby social problems are perceived to have a global dimension. International social work perspectives and practices, therefore, cannot be marginalized or sidelined if the profession seeks to pursue and uphold social justice and human rights. Collaboration in research across borders is essential for

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facilitating global understanding and to share knowledge, successes, challenges, and experiences to identify possible future solutions (Ornellas et al., 2019; Spolander et al., 2014). This is of increasing significance with the persistence of global challenges including poverty and inequality (Pelaez et al., 2024), forced migration (Palattiyil et al., 2022), global health crises/COVID-19 (Banks et al., 2020; Truell and Crompton, 2020) and natural disasters, to name a few.

Recognizing the unity that is possible in diversity, there are multiple opportunities offered by partnering in a global study, such as ensuring the experiences of smaller nations are not excluded from the larger voice, strengthening advocacy efforts, and potential for comparative analysis to track progress within global trends. Reflecting on the significance of international collaboration for achieving sustainable solutions to local and global challenges, this article discusses the lessons learned from leading the Aotearoa New Zealand branch of a global study investigating the workforce conditions and well-being of social workers.

Project background and aims

Social workers have among the most difficult working conditions of all equivalent professions (Ravalier et al., 2022), with reports highlighting risks of burnout (Depanfilis and Zlotnik, 2008; McFadden et al., 2015), high levels of work-related anxiety (Coyle et al., 2005), bureaucratic burdens (Pascoe et al., 2023) and experiences of online abuse and harassment including death threats and digital stalking (Burns et al., 2024). Workplace conditions have been shown to affect employee well-being and impact social work practice, with connections made to turnover and attrition in the workforce (Ravalier et al., 2024).

This research sought to explore the working conditions and well-being of social workers around the globe, using an online survey that draw upon two measures: (1) the Management Standards Indicator Tool and (2) the Warwick-Edinburgh Mental Wellbeing Scale. Demographic data were collected to consider cohort comparisons (Ravalier et al., 2022). The research was informed by three core questions:

Research Question 1 (RQ1). What are the characteristics of working conditions for social workers across different global regions?

Research Question 2 (RQ2). What are the differences in working conditions and well-being across different global regions?

Research Question 3 (RQ3). Which working conditions are most impactful on well-being in different regions of the world? (See Ravalier et al., 2022: 1080 for full details.)

Findings from the first two iterations of the study are reported elsewhere (Ravalier et al., 2024). Aotearoa researchers joined for the third iteration of the study.

Lessons

While social work internationally has some overarching similarities in terms of adherence to the global agenda, the global definition of social work and shared values, it is important to recognize that contexts, language and practice approaches differ (Hawkins, 2023; Spolander et al., 2014, 2016). Such regional differences should be critical considerations when planning how to engage with local communities and what adaptions are necessary to ensure unique cultural positions are treated with dignity and are not lost within the wider research and data set. Of particular concern to the authors was ensuring a commitment to Te Tiriti o Waitangi, the founding document of

Aotearoa, and recognition of Māori as tangata whenua, the indigenous peoples of the land, were upheld.

Language and expression

As argued by Tripodi and Potocky-Tripodi, (2007: 10), 'knowledge of idiomatic expressions in other languages is basic to transnational and cross-cultural competency'. The complexities of translation in cross-cultural research have been discussed elsewhere (see de Wet et al., 2020) highlighting how researchers often underestimate the time and resourcing required. Despite the authors having a strong understanding of the local context, having trained as bicultural practitioners in Aotearoa, and current local employment as educators and researchers in social work, the limitations of knowledge, including the nuance to language and concepts that underpin indigenous worldviews, were recognized in the initial considerations of the study. Subsequently, a collaborative research partnership with a Māori academic, colleague and researcher was prioritized to consider appropriate protocols and communication that reflect the commitment to tikanga (cultural processes and protocol), te reo (language) and indigenous knowledges in adapting the process and information from the global study to the Aotearoa context.

A further challenge was the use of measures which were developed in the United Kingdom, underpinning concepts of well-being and workplace conditions that were deemed relevant to that context. Terminology might not always be the same in different countries and communities, a recognized challenge and limitation to international research. Although a limiting factor, applying consistent measures does enable a level of comparability in findings (Ornellas et al., 2019). Limitations were mitigated, to some extent, by ensuring the Aotearoa survey incorporated a question that addressed the collective orientation of well-being to better acknowledge local holistic indigenous perspectives.

Collaboration

To contribute to the global study and ensure the validity of the tools, the measures could not be altered. The survey did, however, allow space for up to four additional questions in response to the local context of each partnered nation. Collaboration with the local professional association was deemed necessary to ensure relevant tailored questions were incorporated. This involved working with the Aotearoa New Zealand Association of Social Workers (ANZASW) to discuss pressing concerns and evolving policy developments affecting the sector. The study, therefore, adopted a secondary aim, to capture perspectives regarding local issues related to workplace conditions and well-being. The additional four questions focused on capturing participants' perceived impact of a recent social work pay equity settlement, access to supervision to support well-being, sufficient time to connect with others (for example friends, family, whānau, hapū, iwi, and/or community), and an open-ended question for participants to comment on any other factors that impact their well-being. These context-specific questions communicated value to participants by highlighting a commitment to targeting local needs within the global study. The collaborative relationship with ANZASW also aided the process of recruitment by advertising on the association's website, social media page and e-newsletters, further communicating relevance and validity of the research to the membership base. Dissemination plans include local conference presentations, publishing with the *Aotearoa New Zealand Social Work* journal, and communication with the professional association.

The process of meaningful collaboration takes time (Hawkins, 2023), and international research has been described as complicated, with potential to give rise to anxieties for both individual researchers and partnered institutions (Spolander et al., 2016). Building relationships, understanding complexities that underpin recommendations, engaging with indigenous perspectives through

collaborative partnership, and examining the nuances of phrasing and subsequent meanings from different positionalities required multiple meetings and space for dialogue. Furthermore, self-reflection to adopt a learning mind-set and unpack any assumptions based on the authors' own insights into the profession as academics and registered social workers was vital.

Ethical considerations

Ethical considerations included thinking about the time commitment for participation. As noted earlier, social workers work long hours, have complex roles and responsibilities. They are also subject to funding and role constraints, often within settings fraught with political implications (Ravalier et al., 2021). Attracting social workers to participate in a global survey in among existing obligations was a challenge. The inclusion of local questions targeting local issues, future opportunities and repeated advertising using different recruitment strategies were some ways to demonstrate value. However, local community engagement remains problematic.

In addition, considerations were given to different cultural nuances. Participating in the research took the authors on a journey to learn about data sovereignty; the implications for participation; and the responsibility for researchers in relation to indigenous data (Brown et al., 2023). Māori consider their data taonga (treasure), they should have authority over their data to determine what can and cannot be shared. Asking Māori social workers to participate in this global study and to share their data with others places obligations on researchers related to data disaggregation, and decision-making around its use to minimize future harms (Brown et al., 2023). Not only did this require transparency in communicating to participants how data would be used, it also required early agreement with the global team that the data would be returned to the Aotearoa researchers. This included the need for a detailed codebook to ensure the data could be understood in raw form before analysis was completed. Ongoing engagement and collaboration with indigenous peoples is essential in determining next steps for analysis and dissemination.

The process of collaboration and consideration of data sovereignty led to the establishment of an Aotearoa survey hyperlink to embed a context-specific information sheet and tailored closing message. These adjustments supported transparency by providing space for the researchers to introduce themselves through the opening text, reiterate collaboration with ANZASW, and explicit statements on how data would be used.

Conclusion

Ultimately, it is important to critically consider the limitations and potential barriers to participation that standardized surveys and information sheets can create. Collaborating with local partners aids in respecting diversity to uphold the norms of different contexts and communities, while holding space for indigenous perspectives.

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Authors' note

Both authors are registered social workers and senior lecturers in Aotearoa New Zealand. Our practice background includes advocacy, mental health, policy, child protection, and youth justice.

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Ethical considerations

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Statement on AI

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News from our societies: IFSW

The global social work community continues to respond with clarity, solidarity and innovation to a rapidly changing world, translating shared values into collective action that strengthens societies and advances social justice. Throughout the year, regional conferences came together as a coherent global conversation on solidarity, sustainability and intergenerational responsibility. The Eurasia Forum of Social Workers centred on population change and intergenerational cooperation, highlighting how social work can bridge age groups, regions and policy domains in times of demographic transition.

The Latin America and Caribbean Region gathered around the theme of strengthening intergenerational solidarity for enduring wellbeing. Exchanges among practitioners, educators, students and community organisations reinforced a shared understanding of social work as both a scientific discipline and an ethic of care, capable of advancing justice, cohesion and dignity across generations.

In Europe, the regional conference and the Indigenous Social Work gathering in Sápmi foregrounded green social work, climate justice and Indigenous perspectives. These discussions connected ecological sustainability with decolonising practice and professional wellbeing, affirming that social justice, environmental responsibility and respect for Indigenous knowledge must be addressed together.

In North America, a regional online conference examined collective crisis among immigrant and displaced communities. Through a social work and legal lens, participants explored migration governance, healing centred responses to trauma and innovative practice strategies, grounded in Indigenous land acknowledgements and a strong ethical call to action for cross-border solidarity

The Africa Region concluded its regional conference with a renewed focus on social cohesion and sustainable development, advancing commitments on workforce strengthening, research collaboration, youth participation, student inclusion and the protection of frontline workers. Together, these regional dialogues demonstrated how locally grounded practice informs a unified global vision.

Alongside these initiatives, several important publications have contributed to advancing social work knowledge, strengthening professional practice and informing policy debates across diverse social, cultural and political contexts. *School Social Work in Sub Saharan Africa: Issues, Challenges and Prospects* made a powerful contribution by positioning children's wellbeing as a central pillar of social development. Drawing on child rights frameworks and African philosophies such as Ubuntu, the book advanced evidence-based arguments for embedding professional social work services within schools and strengthening partnerships among governments, educators and practitioners.

Local Perspectives on Social Services and Social Work in the Context of War and Conflict deepened understanding of social work in situations of violence, displacement and political crisis. By foregrounding practitioner reflections, refugee voices and participatory research, the volume illustrated how social workers actively contribute to peacebuilding, resilience and dignity, while challenging silence in the face of oppression and injustice.

Professional Social Work Education in the Asia Pacific Region: Development of Registration Systems for Qualification Holders offered a major scholarly contribution to debates on education, qualification and professional regulation. Through comparative analysis of diverse national systems, the publication supported stronger professional recognition, international cooperation and culturally grounded approaches to standards and ethics within an increasingly interconnected profession.

Throughout the year, research and advocacy efforts have played a crucial role in grounding the profession's voice in evidence and collective experience, reinforcing social work's influence in shaping policies, systems and global agendas that promote justice, wellbeing and social cohesion. A global study documented declining wellbeing and working conditions among social workers, reinforcing the importance of role clarity, peer support and organisational investment. The findings strengthened evidence-based advocacy for safer working environments, adequate resourcing and recognition of the workforce as essential to effective social protection systems.

A historic and defining moment was reached at the UN Second World Summit for Social Development. Acting as a unified civil society partnership, IASSW, ICSD, ICSW and IFSW jointly advanced integrated social policy, universal social protection and intergenerational solidarity through solution sessions and a shared statement to the High-Level Round Table. The adoption of the Doha Declaration reaffirmed social justice, solidarity and wellbeing as global priorities, while the recognition of social workers as frontline actors in social development underscored the profession's indispensable role in building humane and resilient societies.

Looking forward, the profession now turns its attention to upcoming global gatherings that will carry these shared commitments into the future, providing spaces for renewed dialogue, collective visioning and coordinated action at a global scale. In June 2026, the Joint World Conference on Social Work and Social Development in Nairobi will provide a space to integrate regional experiences, research insights and global advocacy under the spirit of Harambee, strengthening collective pathways towards shared and sustainable futures.

Together, these conferences, publications and advocacy efforts reveal a profession that is increasingly connected, confident and purposeful. Across regions and generations, social work is co-building knowledge, strengthening solidarity and shaping integrated responses to global challenges, reaffirming its essential role in advancing dignity, justice and sustainable wellbeing for all.

Joachim Mumba
IFSW President

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Abstracts (French, Spanish, Chinese, Arabic)

French

[Choix de la rédaction] Qu'est-ce qui rend la recherche en travail social spécifique ? Une comparaison entre trois pays d'Amérique latine et trois pays anglophones.

Gabriela Rubilar Donoso, Gianinna Muñoz-Arce, Barbra Teater, Catherine A LaBrenz, et Sabretta Alford

Abstract / Résumé

Cette étude a exploré et comparé les conceptions de la recherche en travail social dans les pays anglophones et latino-américains. Les réponses des participants provenant de trois pays anglophones et de trois pays latino-américains (n = 46) à un questionnaire à questions ouvertes ont été analysées. Trois thèmes ont émergé : (1) la recherche en travail social vise des solutions ou des actions ; (2) la recherche en travail social intègre une approche écologique ; et (3) la recherche en travail social est guidée par l'éthique et la justice sociale. Ces thèmes ont mis en lumière les contributions spécifiques de la recherche en travail social, avec des nuances entre les répondants latino-américains et les répondants anglophones. Les implications de cette étude incluent son extension à d'autres pays et la mise en évidence des enjeux éthiques et de transformation dans la recherche en travail social.

Mots clés : Amérique latine, Amérique du Nord, recherche, justice sociale, travail social, Royaume-Uni

Comprendre la supervision en travail social dans le contexte de la pratique du développement social : une analyse exhaustive

Nozipho E Nkosi1 et Mpumelelo E Ncube

Abstract / Résumé

La supervision est essentielle en travail social pour améliorer la qualité des services. En Afrique du Sud, les lacunes des pratiques de supervision et la mise en œuvre inefficace de l'approche en développement social ont eu un impact négatif sur la qualité des services. Cette étude a examiné la relation entre la supervision et l'adoption de l'approche du développement social au sein du Département du développement social du district de Gert Sibande, dans la province de Mpumalanga. En utilisant une étude de cas qualitative et des entretiens semi-directifs, les résultats ont révélé que, dans le

district, la supervision ne soutient pas efficacement l'approche de développement social, ce qui soulève des inquiétudes quant à la qualité des services.

Mots clés : prestation de services, approche de développement social, travailleur social supervisé, supervision en travail social, superviseur en travail social

Facteurs psychosociaux de vulnérabilité affectant le bien-être des mères migrantes en provenance d'Amérique latine : une revue exploratoire

Oliva Diaz Melgarejo, María Elvira Cárdenas Sánchez, María Olaya Grau Rengifo, José Berríos-Riquelme, Margarita Bernales Silva, Daniela Bolívar Fernández, Marcela González Agüero, et María Florencia Grau

Abstract / Résumé

Cette étude exploratoire examine le vécu des mères migrantes en provenance d'Amérique latine, en mettant en lumière les facteurs psychosociaux de vulnérabilité qui affectent leur bien-être dans des contextes migratoires. Centrée sur la migration Sud-Sud et les expériences vécues par les femmes prodiguant des soins, elle comble une lacune importante dans la littérature. Les résultats révèlent des difficultés spécifiques telles que le stress d'acculturation, les précarités économiques et matérielles, un soutien social insuffisant et des problèmes de santé mentale exacerbés par la marginalisation liée aux rôles d'aidante et de soignante. Les implications pratiques pour le travail social et les politiques publiques incluent des interventions adaptées aux réalités culturelles et la conception de politiques d'aide répondant aux besoins des mères migrantes.

Mots clés : acculturation, compétences interculturelles, santé mentale, politiques publiques, travail social, personnes en transit et migrantes

Utilisation d'une perspective culturelle pour les évaluations des experts en protection de l'enfance en Norvège

Polly Evans McGinn, Dag Øystein Nordanger, Magne Olav Mæhle, Øivin Christiansen, et Hanne Cecilie Braarud

Abstract / Résumé

En Norvège, la législation exige la prise en compte de la culture de l'enfant durant toutes les étapes de la protection de l'enfance. À travers l'analyse quantitative du contenu de 285 rapports d'évaluation d'experts en protection de l'enfance, nous avons exploré l'utilisation d'une perspective culturelle par ces experts, en comparant les rapports concernant des enfants issus de familles immigrées et ceux concernant des enfants de familles non immigrées. Nous avons constaté que les experts étaient rarement invités à adopter une perspective culturelle, mais qu'ils le faisaient plus fréquemment dans les rapports concernant les enfants issus de l'immigration que dans les rapports concernant les autres enfants. Nous avons également relevé peu de preuves de réflexion critique et que le recours à des interprètes était rare. Cet article examine les explications possibles et les implications de cette perspective culturelle limitée.

Mots clés : inégalités en matière de protection de l'enfance, services de protection de l'enfance, culture, évaluation par des experts, enfants immigrants

La valeur potentielle des visites à domicile dans l'expérience des travailleurs sociaux appartenant à la population arabe minoritaire en Israël

Ibrahim Mahajne et Nuzha Allassad Alhuzail

Abstract / Résumé

Cette étude s'inscrit dans le mouvement pour une « validation » des interventions sociales en contexte de vie réelle, en explorant la valeur potentielle des visites à domicile dans l'expérience professionnelle des travailleurs sociaux issus de minorités en Israël. Les données ont été recueillies lors d'entretiens semi-directifs approfondis menés auprès de 15 travailleurs sociaux arabes employés par les services sociaux des collectivités locales. Au-delà du potentiel universel des visites à domicile, les entretiens ont révélé des manières concrètes de valoriser ce potentiel positif. Ces résultats peuvent encourager les professionnels de terrain, les concepteurs des politiques publiques et les formateurs à explorer la diversité des possibilités offertes par les visites à domicile.

Mots clés : authentification, visite à domicile, intériorisation de la minorité, professionnalisation, contexte de vie réelle, travail social

Conceptualisation du harcèlement anti-asiatique subi par les adolescents d'origine est-asiatique dans les écoles canadiennes en raison de la pandémie de COVID-19 : le rôle des travailleurs sociaux

Kedi Zhao et Tracy K. Wong

Abstract / Résumé

Les adolescents d'origine est-asiatique sont de plus en plus confrontés à l'intimidation en milieu scolaire, résultant du racisme anti-asiatique exacerbé à partir de la pandémie de COVID-19. Cet article adopte le multiculturalisme canadien, la théorie du bouc émissaire et la théorie de la dominance pour appréhender ce problème social dans le contexte macro-social canadien, les interactions intergroupes à l'échelle intermédiaire et l'expérience individuelle des adolescents. Un modèle conceptuel intégrant ces trois niveaux théoriques et le rôle des travailleurs sociaux à ces différents niveaux est également présenté. Cette conceptualisation vise à aider les chercheurs et les praticiens en travail social à mieux comprendre le harcèlement subi par les adolescents d'origine est-asiatique en milieu scolaire et à les protéger face au racisme anti-asiatique.

Mots clés : racisme anti-asiatique, harcèlement, Canada, pandémie de COVID-19, adolescents d'origine est-asiatique, travailleurs sociaux

Une étude sur les connaissances des travailleurs sociaux et des étudiants en travail social en matière de VIH/SIDA au Kirghizistan et leurs attitudes envers les personnes vivant avec le VIH.

Aisuluu Shailoobek kyzy, Ulla Pape, Nurgul Musaeva, Zhyldyz Asekova, et Ingo Ilja Michels

Abstract / Résumé

Au Kirghizistan, le niveau de sensibilisation au VIH chez les travailleurs sociaux demeure faible, ce qui nuit à la qualité des services qu'ils offrent. Cette étude examine les connaissances des travailleurs sociaux et des étudiants en travail social sur le VIH, leurs attitudes envers les personnes vivant avec le VIH et leur volonté de leur fournir des services sociaux. L'étude s'appuie sur un questionnaire portant sur les connaissances relatives au VIH (n = 314). Le taux de réponses correctes aux questions était de 70,3 % chez les travailleurs sociaux et de 64,5 % chez les étudiants. Seuls 50,1 % des étudiants et 40 % des travailleurs sociaux se disent disposés à offrir leurs services. L'étude révèle que les participants manquent de connaissances suffisantes sur le VIH.

Mots clés : attitudes envers les personnes vivant avec le VIH, connaissances sur le VIH/sida, compétences professionnelles, préparation psychologique, étudiants en travail social, stigmatisation

Paroles d'étudiants de troisième cycle en travail social : Réflexions sur la fertilité et la prise de décision en matière de reproduction aux Émirats arabes unis

Fakir Al Gharaibeh, Xiang Zhao, et Farida S Abdurahman

Abstract / Résumé

La faible fécondité est une préoccupation croissante aux Émirats arabes unis, pourtant les recherches sur les intentions en matière de procréation basées sur les théories existantes sont rares. Cette étude qualitative examine les croyances qui influencent les décisions relatives à la fécondité chez 29 étudiants émiratis de master en travail social. Les résultats mettent en lumière l'influence de la religion, de la culture, de l'économie et du genre, et soulignent le rôle essentiel des travailleurs sociaux dans l'élaboration de politiques qui reflètent les réalités des jeunes. Ces observations contribuent également à une meilleure compréhension globale de la façon dont les facteurs professionnels et socioculturels agissent sur la fécondité dans les sociétés en voie de modernisation.

Mots clés : croyances, intention de procréation, approche qualitative, travailleur social, Émirats arabes unis

La numérisation des pratiques de travail social auprès des populations déplacées : un exemple de travail de terrain à Al-Bab, en Syrie

Metin Gani Tapan

Abstract / Résumé

Cette étude reflète l'expérience pratique d'un travailleur social dans la planification et la mise en œuvre de la transformation numérique de la distribution d'aide financière, alimentaire et non

alimentaire ainsi que de services de soutien psychosocial, par des organisations de la société civile, auprès des populations déplacées après la guerre civile syrienne, selon une approche fondée sur les droits et la transparence. L'étude démontre également comment les services sont devenus plus inclusifs, accessibles et responsables grâce à la numérisation des intermédiaires et au rôle spécifique du travail social auprès des populations déplacées.

Mots clés : digitalisation, déplacement, pratique du travail social fondée sur les droits, transparence

Facteurs influençant l'intention de départ et de remplacement [turnover] des travailleurs sociaux : une méta-analyse

Yukun Li, Shu Li, et Haibo Qin

Abstract / Résumé

Le taux de roulement élevé des travailleurs sociaux constitue un problème extrêmement grave. Cette méta-analyse examine de manière exhaustive les facteurs prédictifs de l'intention de quitter son emploi chez les travailleurs sociaux, en synthétisant les résultats de 29 études portant sur 34 071 participants. Les résultats montrent que l'intention de quitter son emploi est davantage liée au contenu du travail et aux facteurs composant l'environnement professionnel. Nous proposons également un cadre d'analyse permettant de mesurer l'intensité de la relation entre les facteurs prédictifs et l'intention de quitter son emploi, afin d'aider les chercheurs et les praticiens du travail social à mieux comprendre ce phénomène et à fidéliser les travailleurs sociaux.

Mots clés : satisfaction au travail, méta-analyse, travailleur social, intention de quitter l'entreprise, attitudes au travail

Les défis de la contextualisation : réflexions critiques sur la communication de la valeur locale dans le cadre d'une étude mondiale

Katheryn Margaret Pascoe et Nicky Stanley-Clarke

Abstract / Résumé

La recherche internationale en travail social et les collaborations mondiales offrent des opportunités de partage des connaissances, de meilleure compréhension des problèmes sociaux, de développement de l'analyse comparative et de collaboration pour explorer des solutions possibles. Cette note de recherche présente les principaux enseignements tirés de la direction de la branche Aotearoa Nouvelle-Zélande d'une étude mondiale portant sur les conditions de travail et le bien-être des travailleurs sociaux. Tenant compte des différences contextuelles, notamment linguistiques et d'expression, des partenariats locaux et des considérations éthiques, cette réflexion critique dévoile les stratégies mises en œuvre pour continuer à respecter la diversité tout en valorisant les spécificités locales au sein d'une étude mondiale.

Mots clés : collaboration internationale, mondialisation, recherche internationale, travail social international, localisation

Spanish

[Selección del editor] ¿Qué distingue a la investigación en Trabajo Social? Una comparación entre tres países latinoamericanos y tres anglófonos

Gabriela Rubilar Donoso, Gianinna Muñoz-Arce, Barbra Teater, Catherine A LaBrenz, and Sabretta Alford

Resumen

Este estudio exploró y comparó las conceptualizaciones de la investigación en Trabajo Social en países anglófonos y latinoamericanos. Se analizaron las respuestas abiertas (n = 46) de una encuesta realizada a participantes de tres países anglófonos y tres países latinoamericanos. Se identificaron tres temas: (1) la investigación en Trabajo Social busca soluciones o acciones; (2) la investigación en Trabajo Social integra un enfoque ecológico; y (3) la investigación en Trabajo Social se sustenta en la ética y la justicia social. Los temas destacaron las contribuciones únicas de la investigación en Trabajo Social, con matices entre los encuestados latinoamericanos y anglófonos. Las implicaciones incluyen la ampliación del estudio a otros países y el énfasis en la ética y la transformación en la investigación en Trabajo Social.

Palabras clave : América Latina, América del Norte, investigación, justicia social, Trabajo Social, Reino Unido

Comprender la supervisión del Trabajo Social en el contexto de la práctica del desarrollo social: un análisis exhaustivo

Nozipho E Nkosi and Mpumelelo E Ncube

Resumen

La supervisión es fundamental en el Trabajo Social para mejorar los estándares de prestación de servicios. En Sudáfrica, las deficiencias en las prácticas de supervisión y la aplicación ineficaz del enfoque de desarrollo social han repercutido negativamente en la calidad de los servicios. Este estudio investigó la relación entre la supervisión y la adopción del enfoque de desarrollo social en el Departamento de Desarrollo Social del distrito de Gert Sibande, en Mpumalanga. Mediante un diseño de estudio de caso cualitativo y entrevistas semiestructuradas, los resultados revelaron que la supervisión en el distrito no apoya eficazmente el enfoque de desarrollo social, lo que suscita preocupación por la calidad de la prestación de servicios.

Palabras clave : Prestación de servicios, enfoque de desarrollo social, supervisado de Trabajo Social, supervisión del Trabajo Social, supervisor de Trabajo Social

Factores psicosociales y de vulnerabilidad que afectan al bienestar de las madres migrantes de América Latina: una revisión exploratoria

Oliva Diaz Melgarejo, María Elvira Cárdenas Sánchez, María Olaya Grau Rengifo, José Berríos-Riquelme, Margarita Bernales Silva, Daniela Bolívar Fernández, Marcela González Agüero, and María Florencia Grau

Resumen

Esta revisión exploratoria examina las experiencias de las madres migrantes de América Latina, destacando los factores psicosociales y de vulnerabilidad que afectan su bienestar en contextos migratorios. Centrándose en la migración sur-sur y las experiencias de género de las mujeres cuidadoras, aborda una brecha significativa en la literatura. Los hallazgos revelan desafíos únicos, como el estrés de la aculturación, las dificultades económicas, el apoyo social limitado y los problemas de salud mental exacerbados por la marginación debido a las funciones de cuidado. Las implicaciones prácticas para el Trabajo Social y las políticas incluyen intervenciones culturalmente competentes y el diseño de políticas de apoyo adaptadas a las necesidades de las madres migrantes.

Palabras clave : Aculturación, competencia cultural, salud mental, políticas, Trabajo Social, migrantes y personas en tránsito.

Utilización de una perspectiva cultural en las evaluaciones de expertos en bienestar infantil en Noruega

Polly Evans McGinn, Dag Øystein Nordanger, Magne Olav Mæhle, Øivin Christiansen, and Hanne Cecilie Braarud

Resumen

En Noruega, la legislación exige que se tenga en cuenta la cultura del niño en todas las fases del trabajo de bienestar infantil. Mediante un análisis cuantitativo del contenido de 285 informes de evaluación de expertos en bienestar infantil, exploramos la utilización de la perspectiva cultural por parte de los expertos, comparando los informes relativos a niños de origen inmigrante y no inmigrante. , descubrimos que rara vez se instruía a los expertos para que emplearan una perspectiva cultural, pero que lo hacían con más frecuencia en los informes relativos a niños de origen inmigrante que en los relativos a niños no inmigrantes. Encontramos pocas pruebas de reflexión crítica y se recurría a intérpretes en contadas ocasiones. El artículo analiza las posibles explicaciones y las implicaciones de una perspectiva cultural limitada en las evaluaciones de expertos en bienestar infantil.

Palabras clave : Desigualdad en el bienestar infantil, servicios de bienestar infantil, cultura, evaluación de expertos, niños inmigrantes

El valor potencial de las visitas domiciliarias según la experiencia de los trabajadores sociales pertenecientes a la población árabe minoritaria en Israel

Ibrahim Mahajne and Nuzha Allassad Alhuzail

Resumen

El estudio se suma a los llamamientos a favor de la «autenticación» de las intervenciones de Trabajo Social en «contextos de la vida real», investigando el valor potencial de las visitas domiciliarias tal y como lo perciben los trabajadores sociales de grupos minoritarios en Israel. Los datos se recopilaron a partir de entrevistas semiestructuradas en profundidad con 15 trabajadores sociales árabes empleados por las oficinas de bienestar social de las autoridades locales. Más allá del potencial universal de las visitas domiciliarias, las entrevistas revelaron formas auténticas de aprovechar el potencial positivo de las mismas. Los resultados pueden animar a los profesionales de la práctica, el diseño de políticas y la formación a explorar la variedad de oportunidades que ofrecen las visitas domiciliarias en beneficio de los usuarios de los servicios.

Palabras clave : Autenticación, visita domiciliaria, minorizado, profesionalización, contexto de la vida real, Trabajo Social

Conceptualización del acoso antiasiático que sufren los adolescentes de Asia Oriental en las escuelas canadienses como consecuencia de la pandemia de COVID-19: el papel de los trabajadores sociales

Kedi Zhao and Tracy K. Wong

Resumen

Los adolescentes de Asia Oriental se enfrentan a un aumento del acoso escolar como consecuencia del racismo contra los asiáticos surgido a raíz de la pandemia de COVID-19. En este artículo, adoptamos el multiculturalismo canadiense, la teoría del chivo expiatorio y la teoría de la dominación para comprender este problema social e e en el contexto social macro canadiense, las interacciones intergrupales mezzo y la experiencia micro individual de los adolescentes. También se presenta un modelo conceptual que integra estos tres niveles de teorías y las funciones de los trabajadores sociales en estos niveles. Esta conceptualización tiene por objeto ayudar a los investigadores y profesionales del Trabajo Social a comprender mejor el acoso escolar que sufren los adolescentes de Asia Oriental en las escuelas y a protegerlos en medio del racismo antiasiático.

Palabras clave : Racismo antiasiático, acoso escolar, Canadá, pandemia de COVID-19, adolescentes de Asia Oriental, trabajadores sociales

Estudio sobre los conocimientos de los trabajadores sociales y los estudiantes de Trabajo Social de Kirguistán sobre el VIH/SIDA y sus actitudes hacia las personas que viven con el VIH

Aisuluu Shailoobek kyzy, Ulla Pape, Nurgul Musaeva, Zhyldyz Asekova, and Ingo Ilja Michels

Resumen

El nivel de concienciación sobre el VIH entre los trabajadores sociales de Kirguistán sigue siendo bajo, lo que repercute negativamente en la calidad de los servicios que prestan. El estudio examina los conocimientos de los trabajadores sociales y los estudiantes de Trabajo Social sobre el VIH, sus actitudes hacia las personas que viven con el VIH y su disposición a prestar servicios sociales. El estudio utilizó una encuesta sobre conocimientos sobre el VIH (n = 314). El porcentaje de respuestas correctas a las preguntas de conocimiento fue del 70,3 % entre los trabajadores sociales y del 64,5 % entre los estudiantes. Solo el 50,1 % de los estudiantes y el 40 % de los trabajadores sociales están dispuestos a prestar servicios. El estudio reveló que los participantes carecían de conocimientos adecuados sobre el VIH.

Palabras clave : Actitudes hacia las personas que viven con el VIH, conocimientos sobre el VIH/SIDA, competencias profesionales, preparación psicológica, estudiantes de Trabajo Social, estigma

Voces de estudiantes de posgrado de Trabajo Social: Reflexiones sobre la fertilidad y la toma de decisiones reproductivas en los EAU

Fakir Al Gharaibeh, Xiang Zhao, and Farida S Abdurahman

Resumen

La baja fertilidad es una preocupación creciente en los EAU, pero las investigaciones teóricas sobre las intenciones de fertilidad son escasas. Este estudio cualitativo examina las creencias que influyen en las decisiones sobre fertilidad entre 29 estudiantes emiratíes de posgrado en Trabajo Social. Los resultados destacan la influencia de la religión, la cultura, la economía y el género, y subrayan el papel fundamental de los trabajadores sociales a la hora de informar sobre políticas que reflejen la realidad de los jóvenes. Estas ideas también enriquecen la comprensión global de cómo los factores profesionales y socioculturales afectan a la fertilidad en las sociedades en proceso de modernización.

Palabras clave : Creencias, intención de fertilidad, cualitativo, trabajador social, Emiratos Árabes Unidos

Digitalización en las prácticas de Trabajo Social para poblaciones desplazadas: un ejemplo de práctica de campo en Al-Bab, Siria

Metin Gani Tapan

Resumen

Este estudio refleja las experiencias prácticas de un trabajador social en la planificación y la implementación de la transformación digital de la prestación de ayuda en efectivo, alimentos, ayuda no alimentaria y servicios de apoyo psicosocial por parte de organizaciones de la sociedad civil a grupos desplazados tras la guerra civil siria, adoptando un enfoque basado en los derechos y transparente. El estudio también demuestra cómo los servicios se vuelven más inclusivos, accesibles y

responsables a través de la digitalización de los intermediarios, una de las funciones únicas del Trabajo Social en las prácticas de Trabajo Social para poblaciones desplazadas.

Palabras clave : Digitalización, desplazamiento, basado en los derechos, práctica del Trabajo Social, transparencia

Factores que influyen en la intención de rotación de los trabajadores sociales: un metaanálisis

Yukun Li, Shu Li, and Haibo Qin

Resumen

La elevada tasa de rotación de los trabajadores sociales es un problema extremadamente grave. Este metaanálisis examina de forma exhaustiva los factores predictivos de la intención de rotación entre los trabajadores sociales, sintetizando los resultados de 29 estudios en los que participaron 34 071 personas. Los resultados del estudio muestran que la intención de rotación de los trabajadores sociales está más relacionada con el contenido del trabajo y los factores del entorno laboral. También proponemos un marco para predecir la fuerza de la relación entre los factores predictivos y la intención de rotación, con el objetivo de ayudar a los investigadores y profesionales del Trabajo Social a a comprender mejor la intención de rotación y retener a los trabajadores sociales.

Palabras clave : Satisfacción laboral, metaanálisis, trabajador social, intención de rotación, actitudes laborales

Los retos de la contextualización: reflexiones críticas sobre la comunicación del valor local en un estudio global

Katheryn Margaret Pascoe and Nicky Stanley-Clarke

Resumen

La investigación internacional en Trabajo Social y las colaboraciones globales ofrecen oportunidades para compartir conocimientos, comprender mejor los problemas sociales, realizar análisis comparativos y trabajar colectivamente para examinar posibles soluciones. Esta nota de investigación informa sobre las principales lecciones aprendidas al dirigir la rama de Aotearoa Nueva Zelanda de un estudio global centrado en las condiciones de trabajo y el bienestar de los trabajadores sociales. Abordando las diferencias contextuales, incluyendo el idioma y la expresión, las asociaciones locales y las consideraciones éticas, las reflexiones críticas comparten estrategias utilizadas en la búsqueda del respeto a la diversidad, al tiempo que se comunica el valor local dentro de un estudio global.

Palabras clave : colaboración global, globalización, investigación internacional, Trabajo Social internacional, localización

Chinese

論文摘要

[編輯之選] 帶來社會工作的研究獨特性的因素：比較三個拉丁美洲國家及三個英語國家的情況

Gabriela Rubilar Donoso, Gianinna Muñoz-Arce, Barbra Teater, Catherine A LaBrenz, and Sabretta Alford

本研究探討及比較英語國家和拉丁美洲國家對社會工作研究的框念。本研究以開放式問卷收集了四十六來自三個英語國家及三個拉丁美國家的受訪者。研究結果顯示三大主題：1) 社會工作研究到式是了尋找解決方案及呼籲行動，2) 社會工作研究結合了生態環境的取向，及 3) 社會工作研究承擔起倫理和社會公義。這些主題勾勒出社會工作研究的獨特性，不過拉丁美洲及英語地區的受訪者對此有稍微不同的分別。文末指出需要將本研究推廣至其他國家，並在將來鼓勵社會工作研究更多聚焦倫理及變革之中。

關鍵詞：拉丁美洲、北美洲、研究、社會公義、社會工作、英國

理解社會發展實務為本的社會工作督導：一次綜合分析

Nozipho E Nkosi and Mpumelelo E Ncube

督導是提升社會工作服務質素的重要一環。在南非，實踐督導時的不足及在實行社會發展方針時欠缺效率都對服務質素帶來負面影響。本研究探討在南非姆普馬加省的格特・西班德地區 (Mpumalanga's Gert Sibande District) 的社會發展部的工作中，進行督導與接納社會發展為本導向之間的關係。本研究以質性個案研究及半結構化訪談進行。研究發現在這地區的督導工作並未有效地支援社會發展取向的工作，導致提供服務的質素的疑慮。

關鍵詞：服務的執行、社會發展取向、社會工作受督導者、社會工作督導、社會工作督導者

拉丁美洲新移民婦女間影響幸福感的心理因素及風險因素：一項範疇回顧

Oliva Diaz Melgarejo, María Elvira Cárdenas Sánchez, María Olaya Grau Rengifo, José Berríos-Riquelme, Margarita Bernales Silva, Daniela Bolívar Fernández, Marcela González Agüero, and María Florencia Grau

本範疇回顧 (scoping review) 探討來自拉丁美洲的新移民母親的經歷，特別指出在移民的背境下影響她們的幸福感的身心因素及風險因素。本研究聚焦於從南美洲移往另一南美洲國家的移民，以及和作為照顧者的性別經驗有關的經驗，從而填補這方面研究文獻的匱乏。研究揭示了不同的困難，包括適應文化的壓力，經濟壓力、缺少社會支援、以及心理健康因為受到邊緣化及照顧者的壓力而惡化。本研究對社會工作實務及政策包括建立有能力配合文化的介入方案，以及設立對新移民母親的支援政策。

關鍵詞：社會化過程、理解文化能力、精神健康、政策、社會工作、過境者及移民者

在挪威的兒童福利專家報告中運用文化為本取向

Polly Evans McGinn, Dag Øystein Nordanger, Magne Olav Mæhle, Øivin Christiansen, and Hanne Cecilie Braarud

在挪威，法律上規定在兒童任何階段實施的社會服利工作都必須顧及其文化背景。本研究將 285 份兒童福利專家評估報告作內容量化分析 (quantitative content analysis)，探討這些專家是否運用跨文化視角，並比較專家對新移民兒童與非新移民兒童的報告是否有分別。 研究員發現這些專家並不是常常被要求以文化取向去撰寫報告，如果他們這樣做的話，會較多出現在新移民組別而較少在非移民的兒童群組。研究員亦找不到太多的批判性反思，而且這些案例中很少有翻譯員參與評估。本文作者在文末嘗試解釋這現象，並指出本研究結果對於專家報告中不常採取文化取向的情況提出一些建議。

關鍵詞： 兒童福利的不平等、社會福利服務、文化、專家評估、新移民兒童

以色列少數的阿拉伯裔社會工作者家訪的經歷及其潛在價值

Ibrahim Mahajne and Nuzha AllassadAlhuzail

本文回應業界呼籲要將社會工作放回真實生活的背景並要將之更接地氣 (Authentication) 的大趨勢，探討以色列少數族群社工如何看待家訪的價值。本研究收集了與 15 名阿拉伯裔社會工作者的半結構深度訪談，他們均受聘於當地政府的社會福利部門。除卻家訪的一般好處以外，這些訪談揭示了如何以家訪令社會服務變得更為接地氣。本研究結果能夠鼓勵業界在實務、政策設計、及訓練的專家去探討不同的可能性，將家訪變為提升服務使用者福祉的機會。

關鍵詞： 核實 (Authentication)、家訪、被邊緣化、專業化、實際生活背景、社會工作

理解加拿大學校在疫情後出現的反東亞裔少年的反亞裔欺凌事件：社會工作者所擔任的角色

Kedi Zhao and Tracy K. Wong

在新冠肺炎疫情後出現了反亞裔的種族主義，隨之以來是在學校裏出現了更多針對東亞青年人的校園欺凌。本文作者參考了以下理論：加拿大多元文化主義 (Canadian multiculturalism)、代罪羔羊理論 (scapegoat theory) 及控制理論 (dominance theory) 去理解這社會現象，並且會以加拿大宏觀社會背景、中層觀點的群組互動、以及微觀的青少年個人經歷三者進行分析。作者亦一出一個整合以上三個不同層面的理論的概念框架，並加入社會工作者在不同層面的角色。這些概念化工作的目的是令社會工作者及前線人員能夠更好地理解東亞裔少年在學校所面臨的欺凌情況，從而更好地保護他們免受反亞裔種族主義的侵擾。

關鍵詞： 反亞裔種族主義、欺凌、加拿大、新冠肺炎疫情、東亞青少年、社會工作者

吉爾吉斯社會工作者及社會工作學生對於愛滋病/ 愛滋病毒感染的知識，及對相關群體的態度研究

Aisuluu Shailoobek kyzy, Ulla Pape, Nurgul Musaeva, Zhyldyz Asekova, and Ingo Ilja Michels

在吉爾吉斯，社會工作者對於受愛滋病毒感染 (HIV) 的覺察度仍是偏低，這對他們提供服務的質素帶來負面影響。本研究檢視社會工作者及社會工作學生對 HIV 等知識，以及對受 HIV 影響的人的態度，以及對他們提供社會工作的意願。本研究使用了一項和 HIV 知識有關的量表，受訪者人數為 314 人。社會工作者平均答對 70.3% 的題目，而社會工作學生則平均答對 64.5%。然而，只有 50.1% 社會工作學生及 40% 的社會工作者願意向 HIV 及愛滋病患者提供社會服務。本研究發現受訪者對 HIV 的知識並不足夠。

關鍵詞：對愛滋病患者的態度、對愛滋病/ 受愛滋病毒感染的知識、專業技能、心理預備程度、社會工作學生、歧視標籤

社會工作博碩士學生的心聲：阿聯酋地區有關受孕及生育的反思

Fakir Al Gharaibeh, Xiang Zhao, and Farida S Abdurahman

在阿拉伯聯合酋長國 (UAE, 以下簡稱阿聯酋) 低生育率的問題漸漸呈現，但現時在該國根據理論而作出有關生育意願的研究仍然極少。本質性研究從 29 名社會工作學生的訪問中探討影響她們生育決定的信念及因素。研究結果發現以下重點：宗教、文化、經濟、性別等因素均帶來影響，並強調社會工作者的角色是在決策籌劃階段將青少年生活的現實面提供給決策者參考。這些發現亦有助其他國家理解在現代社會中，職業相關及社會文化因素如何對生育率帶來影響。

關鍵詞：信念、受孕意向、質性研究、社會工作者、阿聯酋

以數碼化社會工作方法協助流離失所的群眾：敘利亞巴卜鎮 (Al-Bab) 實地工作的例子

Metin Gani Tapan

本研究收集了社會工作者的前線經驗，他們在工作中進行數碼化改革，改善了公民組織對受敘利亞內戰影響的流離失所群體提供金錢、食物、其他物資、以及心理社會支援的服務工作，並以人權為本的取向及公平透明原則進行服務。本研究亦展示分發者的層面進行數碼化如何令社會工作服務變得更融合多元群體、更容易被獲得、亦更容易被問責。而這些都是社會工作者對流離失所群體的服務所需要顧及之處。

關鍵詞：數碼化、流離失所、人權為本、社會工作實務、透明度

影響社會工作者離職意向的因素：一項整合分析 (meta-analysis)

Yukun Li, Shu Li, and Haibo Qin

社會工作界中高離職率的問題極為嚴重。本文為一項整合分析 (meta-analysis)，整合了涵蓋 34071 名受訪者的 29 項研究的結果，分析影響社會工作者決定轉職的意向的因素。研究發現社會工作者的離職意向更多受到工作內容及工作環境因素的影響。研究員亦提及一個框架，嘗試找出各因素與離職意願的關係強度，希望協助社會工作研究者及前線人員更能理解影響離職意向的原因，從而能更好地留住社會工作者。

關鍵詞： 工作滿足感、整合分析 (meta-analysis)、社會工作者、轉職意向、工作態度

顧及背境因素的困難：以批判反思探討如何在一項全球研究中探討本地的價值觀

Katheryn Margaret Pascoe and Nicky Stanley-Clarke

國際社會工作研究以及跨國合作提供了機會去分享知識、更好地理解社會問題、投入更多資源去作跨國比較研究、以及能以合作方式去檢視可能的解決方案。本研究筆記是有關一項探討社會工作者的工作環境及幸福感的全球研究中，在新西蘭中毛利地區 (毛利語稱為奧特阿來瓦 Aotearoa) 分部中領導相關研究工作的經驗。本文探討了一些背景因素的分別，包括語言、表達方式、本地的合作伙伴、以及倫理的考慮等。本批判反思嘗試找出在進行全球性的研究時，如何進行不同的策略去顧及文化多元性及與本地價值觀進行溝通。

關鍵詞： 全球合作、全球化、國際研究、國際社會工作、本地化

Arabic

ما الذي يميز البحث العلمي في مجال العمل الاجتماعي؟ مقارنة بين ثلاث دول من أمريكا اللاتينية وثلاث دول ناطقة بالإنجليزية

هدفت هذه الدراسة إلى استكشاف ومقارنة تصورات البحث العلمي في مجال العمل الاجتماعي في كل من الدول الناطقة بالإنجليزية ودول أمريكا اللاتينية، وذلك من خلال تحليل إجابات استبيان مفتوح شمل ستًّا وأربعين مشاركة من باحثين وممارسين في ثلاث دول من كل إقليم. وأظهرت النتائج أن البحث في العمل الاجتماعي يتميز بتركيزه الواضح على إيجاد حلول عملية وإحداث تدخلات اجتماعية قابلة للتطبيق، كما يعتمد بصورة أساسية على المنظور الإيكولوجي في فهم التفاعل بين الأفراد وبيئاتهم الاجتماعية، ويرتكز في جوهره على الالتزام بالأخلاقيات المهنية وتعزيز العدالة الاجتماعية. وقد كشفت الدراسة عن وجود تباينات دقيقة في طريقة تناول هذه المرتكزات بين المشاركين من أمريكا اللاتينية ونظرائهم في الدول الناطقة بالإنجليزية، الأمر الذي يعكس اختلاف السياقات الاجتماعية والسياسية والمعرفية. وتؤكد النتائج أهمية توسيع نطاق هذا النوع من الدراسات ليشمل دولًا ومناطق أخرى، مع إبراز الدور التحويلي للأخلاقيات والعدالة الاجتماعية في توجيه البحث العلمي في العمل الاجتماعي.

فهم الإشراف في العمل الاجتماعي في سياق ممارسة التنمية الاجتماعية: تحليل شامل

يُعد الإشراف أحد الركائز الأساسية في ممارسة العمل الاجتماعي نظرًا لدوره المحوري في تحسين جودة الأداء المهني وتعزيز مستوى الخدمات الاجتماعية المقدمة. وفي سياق جنوب أفريقيا، أسهمت أوجه القصور في ممارسات الإشراف وضعف التطبيق الفعلي لنهج التنمية الاجتماعية في التأثير سلبًا على جودة تقديم الخدمات. هدفت هذه الدراسة إلى تحليل العلاقة بين الإشراف المهني وتبني نهج التنمية الاجتماعية داخل وزارة التنمية الاجتماعية في منطقة غيرت سيباندي بمقاطعة مبومالانغا، وذلك بالاعتماد على تصميم دراسة حالة نوعية استخدمت المقابلات شبه المهيكلة. وأظهرت النتائج أن الإشراف المطبق في هذه المنطقة لا يدعم بصورة فعالة تبني نهج التنمية الاجتماعية، مما يثير مخاوف مهنية ومؤسسية بشأن مستوى جودة الخدمات الاجتماعية وقدرة النظام الإشرافي على تمكين الممارسين من أداء أدوارهم التنموية بكفاءة.

العوامل النفسية-الاجتماعية وعوامل الهشاشة المؤثرة في رفاهية الأمهات المهاجرات من أمريكا اللاتينية: مراجعة نطاقية

تتناول هذه المراجعة النطاقية تجارب الأمهات المهاجرات من أمريكا اللاتينية، مع التركيز على العوامل النفسية-الاجتماعية وعوامل الهشاشة التي تؤثر في رفاهيتهن ضمن سياقات الهجرة. وتركّز الدراسة بشكل خاص على أنماط الهجرة من الجنوب إلى الجنوب وعلى الخبرات الجندرية للنساء القائمات بأدوار الرعاية، مسلطة الضوء على فجوة معرفية واضحة في الأدبيات السابقة. وتُظهر النتائج أن هذه الفئة تواجه تحديات مركّبة تشمل ضغوط التكيف الثقافي، والصعوبات الاقتصادية، وضعف شبكات الدعم الاجتماعي، إضافة إلى مشكلات الصحة النفسية التي تتفاقم بفعل التهميش المرتبط بأدوار الرعاية. وتشير الدراسة إلى أن لهذه النتائج دلالات تطبيقية مهمة لممارسة العمل الاجتماعي وصنع السياسات العامة، إذ تؤكد الحاجة إلى تدخلات تراعي الكفاءة الثقافية وإلى سياسات داعمة تُصمَّم بما يتلاءم مع الاحتياجات الخاصة للأمهات المهاجرات.

توظيف المنظور الثقافي في التقييمات الخبيرة لحماية الطفل في النرويج

تنص التشريعات في النرويج على ضرورة مراعاة ثقافة الطفل في جميع مراحل العمل المرتبط بحماية الطفل. وفي هذا السياق، اعتمدت الدراسة على تحليل محتوى كمي لعدد مئتين وخمسة وثمانين تقريرًا من تقارير التقييم الخبير في مجال حماية الطفل، بهدف استكشاف مدى توظيف الخبراء للمنظور الثقافي، مع مقارنة التقارير الخاصة بالأطفال من خلفيات مهاجرة بتلك المتعلقة بأطفال من غير المهاجرين. وأظهرت النتائج أن الخبراء نادرًا ما يُطلب منهم صراحة اعتماد منظور ثقافي في تقييماتهم، إلا أنهم يلجؤون إليه بدرجة أكبر عند التعامل مع حالات الأطفال ذوي الخلفيات المهاجرة مقارنة بغيرهم. كما كشفت الدراسة عن محدودية واضحة في التفكير النقدي المرتبط بالثقافة، إلى جانب ندرة استخدام المترجمين. ويناقش المقال التفسيرات المحتملة لهذه المحدودية في توظيف المنظور الثقافي، إضافة إلى آثارها وانعكاساتها على عدالة وجودة ممارسات حماية الطفل.

القيمة المحتملة للزيارات المنزلية كما يختبرها ممارسو العمل الاجتماعي المنتمون إلى الأقلية العربية في إسرائيل

تنضم هذه الدراسة إلى الدعوات المطالِبة بـ«توثيق» تدخلات العمل الاجتماعي في سياقات الحياة الواقعية، من خلال استقصاء القيمة المحتملة للزيارات المنزلية كما يدركها ممارسو العمل الاجتماعي المنتمون إلى مجموعات اقلية في إسرائيل. جُمعت البيانات عبر مقابلات متعمقة شبه مهيكلة مع خمسة عشر ممارسًا وممارسة من العرب العاملين في دوائر الرفاه التابعة للسلطات المحلية. وتُظهر النتائج أنه إلى جانب الإمكانات العامة للزيارة المنزلية، برزت أساليب أصيلة وملائمة ثقافيًا لتوظيف إمكاناتها الإيجابية، بما يعكس خصوصية السياق الاجتماعي والثقافي للمستفيدين. وتشير الدراسة إلى أن هذه النتائج يمكن أن تشجع العاملين في الممارسة المهنية وصانعي السياسات ومخططي برامج التدريب على استكشاف طيف أوسع من الفرص التي تتيحها الزيارات المنزلية بما يخدم مصلحة المستفيدين ويعزز مهنية العمل الاجتماعي.

تصوّر التنمّر المعادي للآسيويين الذي يواجهه المراهقون من شرق آسيا في المدارس الكندية في ظل جائحة كوفيد-19: أدوار العاملين في العمل الاجتماعي

واجه المراهقون من شرق آسيا تصاعدًا ملحوظًا في سلوكيات التنمّر داخل المدارس نتيجة تنامي العنصرية المعادية للآسيويين التي برزت خلال جائحة كوفيد-19. يعتمد هذا المقال على مقاربات التعددية الثقافية الكندية ونظرية كبش الفداء ونظرية الهيمنة لفهم هذه الظاهرة الاجتماعية ضمن السياق الكندي العام على المستوى الكلي، وفي تفاعلات الجماعات على المستوى الوسيط، وفي تجارب المراهقين الفردية على المستوى الدقيق. ويقدّم المقال نموذجًا تصوريًا يدمج هذه المستويات النظرية الثلاثة مع توضيح أدوار العاملين في العمل الاجتماعي على كل مستوى. وتهدف هذه الصياغة التصورية إلى تمكين الباحثين والممارسين في العمل الاجتماعي من فهم أعمق لظاهرة التنمّر التي يتعرض لها المراهقون من شرق آسيا في المدارس، وتعزيز قدرتهم على حمايتهم في ظل تنامي العنصرية المعادية للآسيويين.

دراسة حول معرفة فيروس نقص المناعة البشرية/الإيدز لدى ممارسي العمل الاجتماعي وطلبة العمل الاجتماعي في قيرغيزستان واتجاهاتهم نحو الأشخاص المتعايشين مع الفيروس

تشير هذه الدراسة إلى أن مستوى الوعي بفيروس نقص المناعة البشرية بين ممارسي العمل الاجتماعي في قيرغيزستان لا يزال منخفضًا، الأمر الذي ينعكس سلبًا على جودة الخدمات التي يقدمونها. وتهدف الدراسة إلى فحص معرفة ممارسي العمل الاجتماعي وطلبة العمل الاجتماعي بفيروس نقص المناعة البشرية، واتجاهاتهم نحو الأشخاص المتعايشين مع الفيروس، ومدى استعدادهم لتقديم الخدمات الاجتماعية لهم. اعتمدت الدراسة على مسح لقياس المعرفة بفيروس نقص المناعة البشرية شمل ثلاثمائة وأربعة عشر مشاركًا. وأظهرت النتائج أن نسبة الإجابات الصحيحة عن أسئلة المعرفة بلغت 70.3% لدى ممارسي العمل الاجتماعي و64.5% لدى الطلبة، في حين أبدى 50.1% فقط من الطلبة و40% من الممارسين استعدادهم لتقديم الخدمات. وتخلص الدراسة إلى أن المشاركين يفتقرون إلى مستوى كافٍ من المعرفة بفيروس نقص المناعة البشرية، وهو ما يستدعي تعزيز الكفاءات المهنية والاستعداد النفسي لممارسي العمل الاجتماعي في هذا المجال.

أصوات طلبة الدراسات العليا في العمل الاجتماعي: تأملات في الخصوبة وصنع القرار الإنجابي في دولة الإمارات العربية المتحدة

تُعد معدلات الخصوبة المنخفضة مصدر قلق متزايد في دولة الإمارات العربية المتحدة، في ظل محدودية البحوث النظرية التي تتناول نوايا الإنجاب. تسعى هذه الدراسة النوعية إلى تحليل المعتقدات التي تشكل قرارات الخصوبة لدى تسعة وعشرين طالبًا وطالبة من طلبة الدراسات العليا في العمل الاجتماعي من المواطنين الإماراتيين. وتبرز النتائج تأثير الدين والثقافة والعوامل الاقتصادية والنوع الاجتماعي في تشكيل هذه القرارات، كما تؤكد الدور الحيوي لممارسي العمل الاجتماعي في الإسهام بصياغة سياسات عامة تعكس واقع الشباب وتطلعاتهم. وتُسهم هذه النتائج كذلك في تعميق الفهم العالمي لكيفية تفاعل العوامل المهنية والاجتماعية-الثقافية في التأثير على الخصوبة داخل المجتمعات التي تشهد تحولات تحديثية متسارعة.

الرقمنة في ممارسات العمل الاجتماعي مع الفئات النازحة: مثال من الممارسة الميدانية في مدينة الباب، سوريا

تعكس هذه الدراسة الخبرات العملية لأحد ممارسي العمل الاجتماعي في تخطيط وتنفيذ التحول الرقمي لبرامج تقديم المساعدات النقدية والغذائية وغير الغذائية وخدمات الدعم النفسي-الاجتماعي التي تنفذها منظمات المجتمع المدني لصالح الفئات النازحة في مرحلة ما بعد الحرب الأهلية السورية. وتنطلق الدراسة من مقاربة قائمة على الحقوق والشفافية، موضحة كيف أسهم التحول الرقمي في تحسين آليات تقديم الخدمات وجعلها أكثر شمولًا وسهولة في الوصول وخضوعًا للمساءلة. كما تبرز الدراسة دور الرقمنة في تنظيم عمل الوسطاء، بوصفه أحد الأدوار المهنية المميزة لممارسي العمل الاجتماعي عند العمل مع السكان النازحين، بما يعزز كفاءة التدخلات ويحد من التحيز وسوء الاستخدام.

العوامل المؤثرة في نية ترك العمل لدى ممارسي العمل الاجتماعي

تُعد المعدلات المرتفعة لترك العمل بين ممارسي العمل الاجتماعي مشكلة بالغة الخطورة لما لها من آثار مباشرة على استدامة الخدمات الاجتماعية وجودتها. يقدّم هذا التحليل التلوي فحصًا شاملًا للعوامل المتنبئة بنية ترك العمل لدى ممارسي العمل الاجتماعي من خلال تجميع نتائج تسع وعشرين دراسة شملت أربعة وثلاثين ألفًا وواحدًا وسبعين مشاركًا. وتشير النتائج إلى أن نية ترك العمل ترتبط بدرجة أكبر بعوامل تتعلق بمحتوى العمل وبيئة العمل مقارنة بالعوامل الفردية الأخرى. كما تقترح الدراسة إطارًا تصوريًا للتنبؤ بقوة العلاقة بين العوامل المختلفة ونية ترك العمل، بهدف دعم الباحثين والممارسين في العمل الاجتماعي في فهم هذه الظاهرة بصورة أعمق وتطوير استراتيجيات فعالة للاحتفاظ بالكفاءات المهنية.

تحديات السياق: تأملات نقدية في إيصال القيمة المحلية ضمن دراسة عالمية

توفر بحوث العمل الاجتماعي الدولية والتعاون العالمي فرصًا مهمة لتبادل المعرفة وفهم القضايا الاجتماعية بعمق أكبر والانخراط في تحليلات مقارنة والعمل المشترك لاستكشاف حلول ممكنة. تعرض هذه الورقة البحثية الدروس الرئيسة المستفادة من قيادة الفرع النيوزيلندي (أوتياروا نيوزيلندا) لدراسة عالمية ركزت على ظروف العمل ورفاه ممارسي العمل الاجتماعي. ومن خلال معالجة الفروقات السياقية، بما في ذلك اللغة وأساليب التعبير وبناء الشراكات المحلية والاعتبارات الأخلاقية، تقدم التأملات النقدية استراتيجيات عملية تم اعتمادها لتحقيق التوازن بين احترام التنوع الثقافي وإبراز القيمة المحلية ضمن إطار دراسة عالمية، مع الحفاظ على الاتساق المنهجي والمعرفي.